# MASS GAP OF FOUR-DIMENSIONAL LATTICE YANG–MILLS THEORY FOR EVERY COMPACT SIMPLE GAUGE GROUP

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Abstract. *We fix the gauge of four-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory on lines that meet every plaquette once, so that each free link interacts with twelve others. For every compact simple gauge group the theory then has a unique infinite-volume state, exponential clustering and an explicit mass gap at fixed lattice spacing, past the curvature limit of the ungauged theory; for SU(2) and SU(3) the ranges reach $\beta_W \le 0.345$ and $\beta_W \le 0.76$. A mass gap in physical units for every continuum limit follows from one estimate of Dobrushin–Shlosman type in a cube of fixed physical size; that estimate and the existence of the limit remain open. The estimate holds at strong coupling, forces the gauge-fixed variables to be disordered at the scale of the cube, and for SU(2) needs a cube of side at least of order $(\beta_W / \log \beta_W)^{1/4}$.*

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An earlier version, titled "Mass Gap of Four-Dimensional Lattice Yang–Mills Theory in a Forest Gauge", appeared as Hexagon preprint 2610.00341. This version adds the theorem for every compact simple gauge group, the reduction of the continuum gap to one physical scale, what that reduction requires of the cube estimate, smoothed observables, and complete proofs of the results earlier taken from our first paper. The LaTeX source, the checks and the Lean certificate are in github.com/creelie/4Y-M, release v3.7.0.

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## 1. Introduction

Wilson's lattice gauge theory [66] assigns an element $Q_e$ of a compact group $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ to every link $e$ of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ and weighs a configuration by $\exp(N\beta \sum_p \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\, Q_p)$, where $Q_p$ is the ordered product of the four link variables around the plaquette $p$.[1] At small $|\beta|$ the theory is under control: it has a unique infinite-volume state, correlations decay exponentially, and the transfer matrix has a gap [54, 57].[2] The question is how far into the coupling range such statements can be proved with explicit constants, since the problem of the continuum limit [39] begins where strong coupling ends and Bałaban's weak-coupling analysis [4, 5, 6] takes over.

Two methods give explicit ranges. The Bakry–Émery method [2, 3] of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [58] bounds the Hessian of the action; in [13] we showed that the sharp bound is $4d = 16$ and that no curvature argument for the ungauged measure goes beyond $|\beta| < 1/32$. The Dobrushin method [26, 27] bounds the influence of each link on the conditional law of another; for SU(2) the single-link conditional law is a von Mises–Fisher law on the three-sphere, the sharp Kantorovich modulus of that family is one quarter [13] (Theorem G.4 in Appendix G), and every link has eighteen partners, which gives $\beta_W < 2/9$ and nothing beyond, because the coefficients are attained.

Both limits come from the same count. A link of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ lies in six plaquettes and shares each with three other links. Gauge invariance makes part of this redundant: in a box, the variables on a forest of links can be set to the identity without changing any gauge-invariant expectation [24].[3] The forest we use is a field of straight lines with one line through every site, chosen so that every plaquette contains exactly one fixed link. Then every free link has exactly twelve free partners, two in each of its plaquettes (Lemma 2.2), and both methods improve.

**Theorem 1.1** (SU(2))**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ and $0 \le \beta_W < \frac{1}{3}$. For every gauge-invariant local observable $O$ the expectations $W_\Lambda(O)$ in boxes with free boundary converge, along every sequence of boxes that exhausts $\mathbb{Z}^4$, to a limit $\omega(O)$ that does not depend on the sequence. The state $\omega$ is invariant under translations and the hypercubic group and reflection positive;*

[1] This is the normalisation of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [58] and of our earlier paper [13]. The conventional inverse coupling is $\beta_W = N^2\beta$, so the weight is $\exp(\frac{\beta_W}{N}\sum_p \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\, Q_p)$; for SU(2), identified with the unit quaternions, $\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}\, Q_p = \mathrm{Re}\, Q_p$ and $\beta_W = 4\beta$. Standard accounts of the lattice theory are the books of Montvay and Münster [51] and of Gattringer and Lang [31]; the Hamiltonian version is due to Kogut and Susskind [43].

[2] Strong-coupling results of this kind go back to Osterwalder and Seiler [54], who proved exponential clustering and a gap by a convergent expansion, and to Seiler's monograph [57]; the general framework for lattice gauge fields and their continuum limits is that of Brydges, Fröhlich and Seiler [19]. More recent work treats the strong-coupling regime by probabilistic methods: the survey of Chatterjee [22], his large-$N$ solution of $\mathrm{SO}(N)$ lattice gauge theory at strong coupling [23] and its planar extension by Basu and Ganguly [9], the Langevin dynamics of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [58], and the area law in an enlarged region by Cao, Nissim and Sheffield [21]. For finite gauge groups Adhikari and Cao proved correlation decay at weak coupling [1]. In two dimensions the continuum Yang–Mills measure has been constructed by Gross, King and Sengupta [34], Driver [29] and Lévy [44]; in four dimensions Bałaban's renormalisation group, as expounded by Dimock [25], gives ultraviolet stability in finite volume, and Magnen, Rivasseau and Sénéor constructed the theory with an infrared cutoff [47]. None of these results gives a mass gap in physical units.

[3] Creutz used a maximal tree to remove the gauge freedom completely; the temporal gauge, with all links in one direction fixed, is the special case of a family of straight lines. In a maximal tree almost every link is fixed in some region and none in others, so the number of partners of a free link is not uniform, and the temporal gauge leaves fourteen partners per link. The point here is a pattern that fixes exactly one link in every plaquette.

*truncated correlations of Lipschitz observables decay at every rate below* $-\log(3\beta_W)$*; and the transfer matrix has spectral gap*

$$m \geq -\log(3\beta_W) > 0.$$

*For* $-\frac{1}{3} < \beta_W < 0$ *all statements except reflection positivity and the gap hold.*

The step behind Theorem 1.1 is short once the line field is in place.[4] The number $\frac{1}{3}$ is also the end of the road for this kind of argument.

**Theorem 1.2** (Ceiling)**.** *Let* $F'$ *be any set of links of* $\mathbb{Z}^4$ *without cycles, and give two distinct links outside* $F'$ *that share a plaquette the coefficient* $|\beta|$*, the largest single-link Kantorovich coefficient of* SU(2)*. Then the weighted Dobrushin condition with these coefficients fails for* $\beta_W \geq \frac{1}{3}$*. For the line field the coefficients are attained, so no single-link Kantorovich argument in that gauge reaches* $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$*.*

The ceiling concerns coefficients between single links. Take instead as a block the three free links of one plaquette. The free links of the line field split into such triples with period two (Lemma 5.1), the coupling inside the block plaquette is no longer paid for, and each link keeps ten outside partners. The price is the sensitivity of a law on three spheres instead of one, which we bound analytically by integrating out the middle link of the block.

**Theorem 1.3** (SU(2) with plaquette blocks)**.** *Let* $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ *and* $0 \leq \beta_W \leq 0.345$*. The number* $\alpha(\beta_W)$ *of* (5.3) *is increasing,* $\alpha(\frac{1}{3}) \leq 0.9561$ *and* $\alpha(0.345) \leq 0.9973$*. The conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold with decay at every rate below* $-\frac{1}{2}\log\alpha(\beta_W)$ *and a transfer-matrix gap*

$$m \geq -\tfrac{1}{2}\log\alpha(\beta_W) > 0;$$

*at* $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$ *this gives* $m \geq 0.0224$*. For* $-0.345 \leq \beta_W < 0$ *all statements except reflection positivity and the gap hold.*

At small coupling the rate of Theorem 1.1 is the better one, so both bounds stand side by side; Theorem 1.3 matters past $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$, where the gap of Theorem 1.1 has closed.

The curvature method gains as well, and for every $N$. Let $\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ be the Hessian of $\sum_p \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p$ on $G^E$ and $F$ the set of fixed links.

**Theorem 1.4** (Curvature in the gauge)**.** *For every* $N$*, every field* $Q$ *and every tangent vector* $v = (X_e Q_e)$ *with* $X_e = 0$ *for* $e \in F$*,*

$$|\operatorname{Hess} S_0(v, v)| \leq \tfrac{29}{2}|v|^2,$$

*against the sharp constant* 16 *without gauge fixing. Consequently, for* $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$ *and* $|\beta| < \frac{1}{29}$*, or* $G = \mathrm{SO}(N)$*,* $N \geq 3$*, and* $|\beta| < \frac{N-2}{58N}$*, the conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold with the rate and gap of Theorem 1.5. For* SU(3) *this is* $\beta_W < \frac{9}{29} = 0.310$*.*

The constant $\frac{29}{2}$ is a statement about $\mathrm{U}(N)$, so it holds on every closed subgroup, and the curvature of the group does the rest. This gives the theorem for every compact simple gauge group, the exceptional groups included, with an explicit gap. Let $\rho : G \to \mathrm{U}(N)$ be a faithful unitary representation of a compact connected Lie group $G$, weigh a configuration

[4] The combination of a forest gauge fixing with the sharp quarter of [13] was first assembled during a run of Anaxia, the reasoning engine of the BLLM system [11], release v3.0.5. In that run the engine combines proof steps along typed links (a step that produces a single-link Kantorovich bound may only feed a step that consumes one), and in every run with typed crossing it reached a composite accepting a lattice mass gap for four-dimensional SU(2) at $\beta_W < \frac{1}{3}$, which no untyped or random run reached. The composite was first proposed by the language model inside the engine, and the engine's network reproduces it. The engine did not supply the line field, the free-boundary limit, the ceiling, the curvature bound or anything in the SU(3) part; the authors wrote and checked every proof in this paper. Release v3.1.0 of the engine [12] records its Yang–Mills runs in the failure log: the narrowing of the target from the continuum gap to explicit couplings in this gauge, the change from analytic one-link bounds to bounds certified box by box, and the change to blocks of several links. These records follow the course of the work and supply no step of the proofs.

TABLE 1. Least Ricci curvature $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$ of the compact simple groups in a faithful representation $\rho$ of least dimension $N$, and the range of Theorem 1.5 for the conventional inverse coupling $\beta_W = N^2\beta$.

| Group | $\rho$ | $h^\vee$ | $\ell_\rho$ | $\kappa_G$ | $\beta_W <$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $N \geq 2$ | $\mathbb{C}^N$ | $N$ | 1 | $\frac{N}{2}$ | $\frac{N^2}{29}$ |
| $\mathrm{SO}(N)$, $N \geq 5$ | $\mathbb{R}^N$ | $N-2$ | 2 | $\frac{N-2}{4}$ | $\frac{N(N-2)}{58}$ |
| $\mathrm{SO}(3)$ | $\mathbb{R}^3$ | 2 | 4 | $\frac{1}{4}$ | $\frac{3}{58}$ |
| $\mathrm{Sp}(n)$, $n \geq 2$ | $\mathbb{C}^{2n}$ | $n+1$ | 1 | $\frac{n+1}{2}$ | $\frac{2n(n+1)}{29}$ |
| $G_2$ | 7 | 4 | 2 | 1 | $\frac{14}{29}$ |
| $F_4$ | 26 | 9 | 6 | $\frac{3}{4}$ | $\frac{39}{29}$ |
| $E_6$ | 27 | 12 | 6 | 1 | $\frac{54}{29}$ |
| $E_7$ | 56 | 18 | 12 | $\frac{3}{4}$ | $\frac{84}{29}$ |
| $E_8$ | 248 | 30 | 60 | $\frac{1}{4}$ | $\frac{124}{29}$ |

by $\exp(N\beta\sum_p \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,\rho(Q_p))$, and let $\kappa_G$ be the least Ricci curvature of $G$ for the bi-invariant metric $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\mathrm{Tr}(\rho(X)\rho(Y))$; we identify $G$ with $\rho(G) \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$.

**Theorem 1.5** (Every compact simple group)**.** *Suppose that the Lie algebra of $G$ is semisimple, so that $\kappa_G > 0$, and that*

$$N|\beta| < \tfrac{2}{29}\,\kappa_G.$$

*Then the conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold, for $\beta < 0$ all of them except reflection positivity and the gap, with decay at every rate below*

$$m_G(\beta) = \operatorname{arccosh}\Big(1 + \frac{1}{12}\Big(\frac{\kappa_G}{N|\beta|} - \frac{29}{2}\Big)\Big) > 0$$

*and a transfer-matrix gap $m \geq m_G(\beta)$. For a simple $G$, $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$, where $h^\vee$ is the dual Coxeter number and $\ell_\rho$ the Dynkin index of $\rho$; Table 1 lists the values.*

For $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $\kappa_G = \frac{N}{2}$, and for $\mathrm{SO}(N)$, $\kappa_G = \frac{N-2}{4}$, so Theorem 1.5 contains the ranges of Theorem 1.4 and supplies their rate.[5] For small $|\beta|$ the existence of a gap is classical for every compact group, with no explicit range [54, Thm. 3.6]; what is new is an explicit range for every group, past the range $N|\beta| < \kappa_G/16$ that the Hessian bound 16 gives without gauge fixing, and an explicit gap. As $\beta \to 0$ the gap grows like $\log \frac{\kappa_G}{6N|\beta|}$.

No Bakry–Émery argument for the ungauged measure can pass $|\beta| = \frac{1}{32}$ [13, Thm. C]; the gauge fixing changes the measure, not the metric, which is why it can. For SU(2) the curvature range $\beta_W < \frac{4}{29}$ lies inside that of Theorem 1.1. For SU(3) the Dobrushin route goes much further.

**Theorem 1.6** (SU(3))**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$ and $0 \leq \beta_W \leq \frac{3}{4}$. Then the conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold, with decay at every rate below $-\log(1.33319\,\beta_W)$ and a transfer-matrix gap*

$$m \geq -\log(1.33319\,\beta_W) > 0.$$

The proof of Theorem 1.6 bounds the Kantorovich modulus of the one-link measure $\nu_b(dU) \propto e^{\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Ub)}dU$ on SU(3) uniformly over staple sums $b$. Its analytic part is a lower bound for the spectral gap of $\nu_b$ through Bochner's formula with a cross term (Lemma 7.3),

[5] The dual Coxeter number is $h^\vee = N$ for $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $N-2$ for $\mathrm{SO}(N)$, $n+1$ for $\mathrm{Sp}(n)$, $4, 9, 12, 18, 30$ for $G_2, F_4, E_6, E_7, E_8$, and the Dynkin index of a representation is normalised to one on the defining representation of $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ [41, Ch. 6]. The identity $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$ is the statement that the Ricci tensor of a compact simple group with a bi-invariant metric is one quarter of the negative Killing form, $\mathrm{Ric}(X, X) = -\frac{1}{4}B(X, X)$ [50], together with $B(X, X) = 2h^\vee\,\mathrm{Tr}(\rho(X)^2)/\ell_\rho$. Lower Ricci bounds of the same kind, for special holonomy and for Riemannian submersions, are studied in [17, 32].

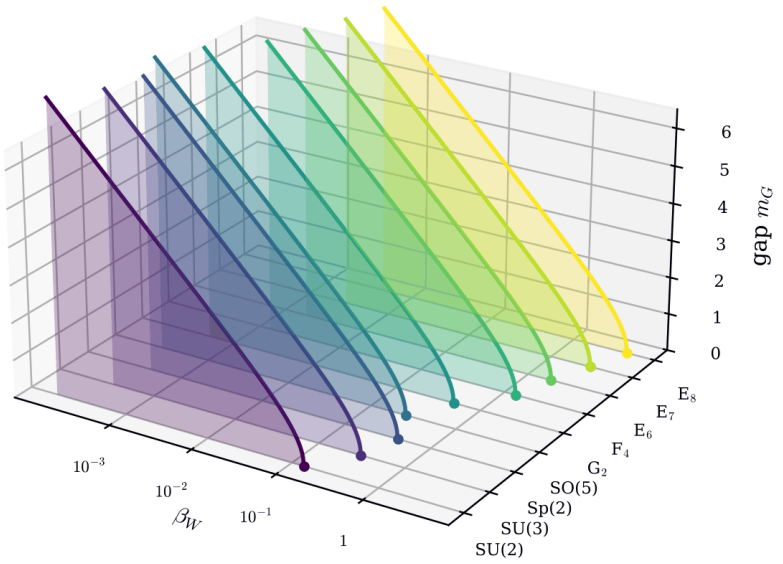



FIGURE 1. The gap $m_G(\beta)$ of Theorem 1.5 as a function of $\beta_W = N^2\beta$ on a logarithmic scale, for nine groups in the representations of Table 1. Each curve ends at the edge $\beta_W = 2N\kappa_G/29$ of the range, marked by a dot, where the gap tends to zero; as $\beta_W \to 0$ it grows like $\log(\kappa_G/(6N|\beta|))$. The curves differ only by the factor $N\kappa_G$, since $m_G$ depends on $N|\beta|/\kappa_G$ alone.

a corrector chosen box by box among polynomials of degree two in the matrix entries (Lemma 7.4), the reduction of $b$ to diagonal matrices (Lemma 7.5), the character expansion of the moments of $\nu_b$ (Lemma 7.6) and an interpolation inequality on boxes of staple sums (Lemma 7.7). The remaining step evaluates the resulting bound on 2341 boxes with rigorous error bounds; the theorem rests on that computation, which is described in full in Section 7.7 and Appendix E.

The plaquette blocks of Theorem 1.3 work for SU(3) as well. They use the same modulus of the one-link measure, but only through the three links of a block, so they need $\Lambda(2\beta_W)$ small and not $2r\Lambda(r) < 1$: near the end of Theorem 1.6 they give a much larger gap, and they go past it.

**Theorem 1.7** (SU(3) with plaquette blocks)**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$ and $0 \le \beta_W \le \frac{19}{25} = 0.76$. Then $\alpha_3(\beta_W) < 1$ for the number of (8.2), with $\alpha_3(0.72) \le 0.9182$, $\alpha_3(\frac{3}{4}) \le 0.9653$ and $\alpha_3(0.76) \le 0.99950$. The conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold with decay at every rate below $-\frac{1}{2}\log\alpha_3(\beta_W)$ and a transfer-matrix gap*

$$m \ge -\tfrac{1}{2}\log\alpha_3(\beta_W) > 0;$$

*at $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ this gives $m \ge 0.0177$, against $1.1 \cdot 10^{-4}$ from Theorem 1.6, and at $\beta_W = 0.76$, where Theorem 1.6 no longer applies, $m \ge 2.5 \cdot 10^{-4}$.*

All seven theorems are statements at fixed lattice spacing. They do not touch the continuum limit, the crossover to Bałaban's regime, or a gap in physical units, which together are the Clay problem; Section 9 says where each method stops and what remains of the four open problems of [13]. The obstruction proved in [14], that a lattice gap uniform in lattice units forces trivial continuum two-point functions, applies to all of them. Section 10 goes past it in one respect: a Dobrushin–Shlosman condition on one cube of fixed physical size, uniform along the continuum tuning, gives a mass gap in physical units for every continuum limit (Theorems 10.2 and 10.4). The conclusion extends to observables smoothed

TABLE 2. Explicit ranges of uniqueness, decay and a transfer-matrix gap for four-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory. The first three rows hold for the ungauged measure; the last three are the results of this paper.

| Method | SU(2), $\beta_W$ | SU(3), $\beta_W$ |
|---|---|---|
| Curvature, Shen–Zhu–Zhu [58] | $< \frac{1}{12}$ | $< \frac{3}{16}$ |
| Curvature, sharp [13] | $< \frac{1}{8}$ | $< \frac{9}{32}$ |
| Dobrushin, sharp quarter [13] | $< \frac{2}{9}$ | |
| Curvature, forest gauge | $< \frac{4}{29}$ | $< \frac{9}{29}$ |
| Dobrushin, forest gauge | $< \frac{1}{3}$ | $\leq \frac{3}{4}$ |
| Plaquette blocks, forest gauge | $\leq 0.345$ | $\leq 0.76$ |

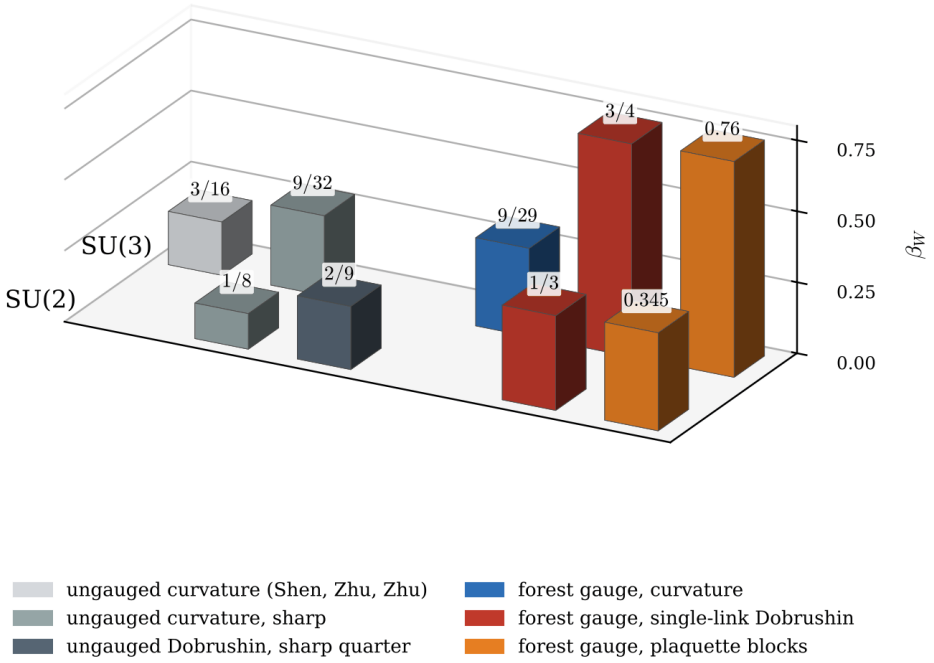



FIGURE 2. Ranges of Table 2. The height of each bar is the largest inverse coupling $\beta_W$ covered by the method. Grey bars are methods for the ungauged measure; blue, red and orange bars use the forest gauge. For SU(2) the red bar ends at the ceiling of Theorem 1.2 and the orange bar, plaquette blocks, passes it (Theorem 1.3); for SU(3) the red bar is Theorem 1.6 and the orange bar, plaquette blocks, gives a larger gap there and passes it (Theorem 1.7).

by the spatial gradient flow (Proposition 10.5). The cube condition and the existence of the limit are the two statements left open. Section 10.5 shows that the condition holds at strong coupling, fails at every fixed cube size at weak coupling, forces the gauge-fixed variables to be disordered on the scale of the cube, and cannot be reached from estimates on single lines of links; for SU(2) it needs cubes of side at least of order $(\beta_W / \log \beta_W)^{1/4}$ (Proposition 10.12).

Section 2 constructs the line field. Section 3 shows that a Dobrushin bound for the gauge-fixed specification gives the full conclusion of Theorem 1.1. Sections 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 prove Theorems 1.1–1.7, and Section 9 measures what is left; Section 10 reduces the continuum gap to one cube and the existence of the limit. The appendices contain the residue table of the line field, the comparison lemma and its version for blocks, the blocks of the local Hessian inequality, the details of the certified computation, the reconstruction of

the transfer matrix with the equivalence of a gap and exponential clustering (Appendix F), and a complete proof of the sharp quarter for the single-link law of SU(2) (Appendices G–I), so that the paper does not depend on our earlier one for any step.

## 2. The line field

Write $e_0, \dots, e_3$ for the unit vectors of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ and $(x, \mu)$ for the link from $x$ to $x + e_\mu$. A *direction field* is a map $\sigma : \mathbb{Z}^4 \to \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$; its links are $F = \{(x, \sigma(x)) : x \in \mathbb{Z}^4\}$. At each site put $\pi_x(\mu) = \sigma(x + e_\mu)$. The plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ has the links $(x, \mu)$, $(x + e_\mu, \nu)$, $(x + e_\nu, \mu)$, $(x, \nu)$, so it contains

$$[\sigma(x) \in \{\mu, \nu\}] + [\pi_x(\mu) = \nu] + [\pi_x(\nu) = \mu] \tag{2.1}$$

links of $F$.

**Lemma 2.1.** *Every plaquette of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ contains exactly one link of $F$ if and only if, at every site $x$, $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$ and permutes the other three directions cyclically.*

*Proof.* Fix $x$, let $s = \sigma(x)$ and let $R$ be the set of the other three directions. For a plane $\{s, \nu\}$ the count (2.1) is $1 + [\pi_x(s) = \nu] + [\pi_x(\nu) = s]$; it equals one for all $\nu \in R$ exactly when $\pi_x(s) = s$ and $\pi_x(\nu) \neq s$ for $\nu \in R$, that is, when $\pi_x$ fixes $s$ and maps $R$ into $R$. For a plane $\{\mu, \nu\} \subset R$ the count is $[\pi_x(\mu) = \nu] + [\pi_x(\nu) = \mu]$. Draw an arrow $\mu \to \pi_x(\mu)$ for every $\mu \in R$ with $\pi_x(\mu) \in R \setminus \{\mu\}$. Each vertex of $R$ has at most one outgoing arrow, and the condition says that each of the three pairs of $R$ carries exactly one arrow. Three arrows on three vertices with out-degree at most one give out-degree exactly one everywhere, and a tournament on three vertices with all out-degrees one is a directed three-cycle. □

From now on $\sigma$ is the field of period two given in Table 3 of Appendix A, read from $x$ modulo two. The table lists $\pi_x$ at each of the sixteen residue classes; in each row $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$ and is a three-cycle on the rest, so every plaquette contains exactly one link of $F$ by Lemma 2.1.[6]

**Lemma 2.2.** (i) *$F$ is a disjoint union of bi-infinite straight lines, one through every site: every site has exactly one outgoing and one incoming link of $F$, and both point in the direction $\sigma(x)$.*

(ii) *For every box $\Lambda$ (a product of four finite intervals, with the links and plaquettes it contains), $F \cap E(\Lambda)$ is a disjoint union of segments, hence a forest.*

(iii) *A link $e = (x, \mu) \notin F$ lies in six plaquettes. Four of them contain a link of $F$ that shares an end point with $e$, and these lie in the planes $\{\mu, \sigma(x)\}$ and $\{\mu, \pi_x(\mu)\}$. In the other two, which lie in the remaining plane $\{\mu, \rho\}$, the link of $F$ is opposite to $e$.*

(iv) *Every link outside $F$ shares a plaquette with exactly twelve other links outside $F$, two in each of its plaquettes.*

*Proof.* (i) Since $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$, $\sigma(x + e_{\sigma(x)}) = \sigma(x)$. Because $\sigma$ has period two, $x - e_\mu \equiv x + e_\mu$, so also $\sigma(x - e_{\sigma(x)}) = \sigma(x)$, and the link $(x - e_{\sigma(x)}, \sigma(x))$ is in $F$. Conversely, if $(x - e_\nu, \nu) \in F$, then $\sigma(x - e_\nu) = \nu$, and straightness at $x - e_\nu$ gives $\sigma(x) = \nu$. So the incoming link is unique and continues the outgoing one.

(ii) A line meets a box in a segment, and distinct lines are disjoint.

(iii) The plaquettes of $e$ are, for each $\nu \neq \mu$, the one at $x$ and the one at $x - e_\nu$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$. A link of $F$ sharing an end point with $e$ is the outgoing or the incoming link of $F$ at $x$ or at $x + e_\mu$. At $x$ both point in the direction $s = \sigma(x) \neq \mu$, and they lie in the plaquettes at $x$ and at $x - e_s$ in the plane $\{\mu, s\}$. At $x + e_\mu$ both point in the direction $t = \pi_x(\mu)$,

[6] There are exactly eight period-two direction fields with this property, all equivalent to $\sigma$ under the symmetries of the lattice. A field with one fixed link at every site and one in every plaquette exists only in four dimensions: a link lies in $2(d-1)$ plaquettes and a site carries $d(d-1)/2$ of them, and $2(d-1) = d(d-1)/2$ forces $d = 4$. The statements of this section are also checked by `decide` in the Lean file `GaugeFix.lean` of the archive.

(a) the line field in the slice $x_3 = 0$ (b) one plaquette in the gauge

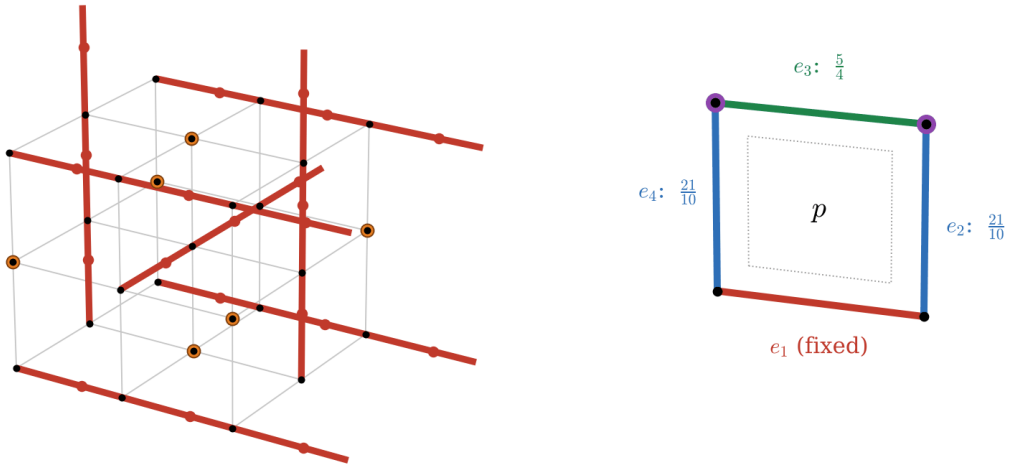



FIGURE 3. (a) The line field in the slice $x_3 = 0$ of a box of side three. Thick red segments are the links of $F$ in the directions $0, 1, 2$, with a dot marking the direction of travel; an orange ring marks a site whose line leaves the slice in direction 3. Every line is straight (Lemma 2.2(i)), and the segments that leave the box are its boundary stubs. (b) One plaquette with its fixed link $e_1$. The weights are those of the local inequality of Lemma 6.2 for the three free links: $\frac{21}{10}$ on the two links adjacent to $e_1$ and $\frac{5}{4}$ on the opposite one. The two purple corners are the ones that enter the corner form (6.3) once $Y_1 = 0$.

which lies in $R \setminus \{\mu\}$ because $\pi_x$ is a three-cycle on $R$, and they lie in the plaquettes at $x$ and at $x - e_t$ in the plane $\{\mu, t\}$. These four plaquettes are distinct because $s \neq t$. Each plaquette contains exactly one link of $F$, so in the two plaquettes of the third plane $\{\mu, \rho\}$ the link of $F$ is a link of direction $\mu$ or $\rho$ not touching $e$; the links of direction $\rho$ in such a plaquette touch $e$, so it is the opposite link.

(iv) Each of the six plaquettes contains $e$, one link of $F$ and two other links, and two distinct links share at most one plaquette. □

## 3. Gauge fixing and the free-boundary state

Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ be compact with Haar measure $dU$, and let $\Lambda$ be a box. The Wilson measure with free boundary is

$$W_\Lambda(dQ) = \frac{1}{Z_\Lambda} \exp\Big(N\beta \sum_{p \in P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p\Big) \prod_{e \in E(\Lambda)} dQ_e.$$

The measure is invariant under the gauge transformations $Q_{(x,y)} \mapsto g_x Q_{(x,y)} g_y^{-1}$ with $g \in G^\Lambda$. Call the links outside $F$ *active* and write $A$ for their set. For a function $O$ of the links, $O^F$ is $O$ with every link of $F$ set to the identity.

**Lemma 3.1** (Gauge fixing)**.** *Let $\mu_\Lambda^F$ be the probability measure on $G^{A \cap E(\Lambda)}$ whose density with respect to Haar measure is proportional to $\exp(N\beta \sum_{p \in P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F)$. For every gauge-invariant $O$ on $G^{E(\Lambda)}$,*

$$W_\Lambda(O) = \mu_\Lambda^F(O^F).$$

*Proof.* Each segment of $F \cap E(\Lambda)$ is a path $x_0, x_1, \dots, x_k$ along one direction. Given the variables on $F$, put $g_{x_0} = 1$ and $g_{x_{i+1}} = g_{x_i} Q_{(x_i, x_{i+1})}$ on every segment. The transformed field has $Q_e^g = 1$ on $F \cap E(\Lambda)$, and for fixed values on $F$ the map $Q_A \mapsto Q_A^g$ is a product of

left and right translations, which preserves Haar measure. Gauge invariance of the action and of $O$ and the change of variables give the claim. □

No leftover holonomy appears because $F \cap E(\Lambda)$ is a forest. The measures $\mu_\Lambda^F$ are finite-volume versions of the specification $\gamma^F$ on $G^A$: for $e \in A$, $\gamma_e^F$ resamples $Q_e$ from the law with density proportional to $\exp(N\beta \sum_{p \ni e} \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F)$ given all other active links. No infinite-volume gauge transformation is performed; $\gamma^F$ is a specification in its own right. Fix a metric $\delta$ on $G$ of diameter $D$ that is bi-invariant (for SU(2) the chordal metric on $S^3$, $D = 2$; for SU($N$) the Hilbert–Schmidt distance). The Kantorovich coefficient of $e'$ on $e$ is

$$C_{ee'} = \sup \frac{W_1(\gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid Q), \gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid Q'))}{\delta(Q_{e'}, Q'_{e'})},$$

the supremum over pairs of configurations that differ only at $e'$. It vanishes unless $e$ and $e'$ share a plaquette.

**Proposition 3.2.** *Suppose that every row and every column of $(C_{ee'})$ sums to at most $\alpha < 1$. Then:*

(i) *$\gamma^F$ has exactly one Gibbs measure $\mu_F$;*
(ii) *for every gauge-invariant local $O$ the limit $\omega(O) = \lim W_\Lambda(O)$ exists along every sequence of boxes exhausting $\mathbb{Z}^4$ and equals $\mu_F(O^F)$;*
(iii) *$\omega$ is invariant under translations and the hypercubic group;*
(iv) *if $\beta \geq 0$, $\omega$ is reflection positive for reflections in hyperplanes through sites and in hyperplanes bisecting links;*
(v) *for gauge-invariant local $O, O'$ with $O$ Lipschitz in each link, $|\operatorname{Cov}_\omega(O, O')| \leq C_{O,O'} e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(O,O')}$ for every $\lambda < -\log \alpha$;*
(vi) *if $\beta \geq 0$, the transfer matrix of $\omega$ has spectral gap at least $-\log \alpha$.*

*Proof.* (i) Gibbs measures exist by compactness, and the comparison lemma of Appendix B with $S = \emptyset$ shows that any two coincide.

(ii) Extend $\mu_\Lambda^F$ by Haar measure on the active links outside $\Lambda$, and let $S$ be the set of active links with a plaquette outside $P(\Lambda)$; this includes every active link outside $E(\Lambda)$. For an active link $e \notin S$ all six plaquettes of $e$ lie in $P(\Lambda)$, so the conditional law of $Q_e$ under the extended measure is $\gamma_e^F$. Let $T$ be the support of $O^F$ and $\lambda < -\log \alpha$. The comparison lemma with weights $e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(\cdot, T)}$ gives

$$|\mu_\Lambda^F(O^F) - \mu_F(O^F)| \leq L \frac{\theta D}{1 - \theta} \sum_{z \in S} e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(z,T)},$$

with $\theta = \alpha e^\lambda < 1$ and $L$ a Lipschitz constant of $O^F$; the sum is at most $C_T R^3 e^{-\lambda R}$ when $R$ is the distance from $T$ to the complement of $\Lambda$. For $O$ continuous but not Lipschitz, approximate uniformly. Lemma 3.1 gives $W_\Lambda(O) = \mu_\Lambda^F(O^F)$.

(iii) $W_\Lambda(\tau_v O) = W_{\Lambda - v}(O)$, and the boxes $\Lambda - v$ also exhaust $\mathbb{Z}^4$; by (ii) the limit does not depend on the sequence. The line field is a device for computing $W_\Lambda$ and is never shifted. The same argument applies to the hypercubic group.

(iv) For $\beta \geq 0$ the measure $W_\Lambda$ is reflection positive for every box symmetric under the reflection [54], and reflection positivity passes to the limit along such boxes, which is $\omega$ by (ii).

(v) $\operatorname{Cov}_\omega(O, O') = \operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_F}(O^F, O'^F)$, and setting the links of $F$ to the identity keeps the Lipschitz property. The bound is Corollary B.2.

(vi) Let $\vartheta$ be a time reflection and $\tau_t$ a time translation. For gauge-invariant local $O$ that are Lipschitz in each link, (v) gives $|\omega(\vartheta(\bar{O})\tau_t O) - |\omega(O)|^2| \leq C_O e^{-\lambda t}$. On the support of $O$ these functions are dense in the gauge-invariant part of $L^2(\omega)$: gauge-invariant functions are functions on the compact quotient of $G^E$ by the gauge group, Lipschitz functions for

the quotient metric are dense in $L^2$ of every finite measure on it, and they lift to gauge-invariant Lipschitz functions. By Proposition F.1 the spectrum of the transfer matrix on the complement of the vacuum lies in $[0, e^{-\lambda}]$, for every $\lambda < -\log \alpha$. □

The proposition replaces the torus limits and the uniqueness of the ungauged Gibbs measure used in [13, Thm. F] by the free-boundary limit, which has all the properties the reconstruction of the transfer matrix needs.[7]

## 4. SU(2) up to one third

*Proof of Theorem 1.1.* Identify SU(2) with the unit quaternions and use the chordal metric. For an active link $e$ and a plaquette $p \ni e$, the staple $s_p$ is the product of the other three link variables in the order that makes $\mathrm{Re}(Q_e s_p) = \frac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Tr}\, Q_p$, with links of $F$ equal to one. Since $N\beta\,\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\, Q_p = 4\beta\langle Q_e, \bar{s}_p\rangle$ in $\mathbb{R}^4$, the conditional law of $Q_e$ is the von Mises–Fisher law $\nu_b(dx) \propto e^{\langle x,b\rangle}dx$ on $S^3$ with $b = 4\beta\sum_{p\ni e}\bar{s}_p$. Changing a partner $e'$ by $\delta$ in the chordal metric changes one staple by an isometric image of that displacement, so $b$ moves by $4|\beta|\delta$, and the sharp quarter (Theorem G.4), $W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le \frac{1}{4}|b - b'|$, gives $C_{ee'} \le |\beta|$. By Lemma 2.2(iv) every row and column has twelve nonzero entries, so $\alpha \le 12|\beta| = 3|\beta_W|$. Proposition 3.2 applies for $|\beta_W| < \frac{1}{3}$. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.2.* For the line field, every staple of an active link contains two active links, so the six staples can be chosen with sum zero while the staple through a given partner $e'$ moves freely. At $b = 0$ the derivative of $\nu_b$ in the direction $h$ has Kantorovich norm $\frac{1}{4}|h|$ by Lemma G.3(i), so $C_{ee'} = |\beta|$ exactly, and every row sum is $12|\beta| = 3|\beta_W|$.

Now let $F'$ be any forest and $C'$ the matrix of the statement. Suppose a positive weight $w$ satisfies $C'w \le \alpha w$. For a box $\Lambda_n$ of side $n$ let $C_n$ be the principal submatrix on the active links of $E(\Lambda_n)$; then $C_n w \le \alpha w$ on these links, and the Collatz–Wielandt inequality for nonnegative matrices gives $\rho(C_n) \le \alpha$. Since $C_n$ is symmetric, $\rho(C_n)$ is at least the mean row sum. The box has $4n^4 - O(n^3)$ links and $n^4$ sites, and a forest has fewer links than sites, so the number $a$ of active links is at least $3n^4 - O(n^3)$. Let $a_p$ be the number of active links of the plaquette $p$; the box has $P = 6n^4 - O(n^3)$ plaquettes and $\sum_p a_p = 6a - O(n^3)$. Two links share at most one plaquette, so the row sums add up to $|\beta|\sum_p a_p(a_p - 1)$, and by convexity

$$\frac{|\beta|}{a}\sum_p a_p(a_p - 1) \ge \frac{|\beta|P}{a}\,\bar{a}(\bar{a} - 1) = 6|\beta|(\bar{a} - 1) - o(1),$$

with $\bar{a} = \sum_p a_p/P = 6a/P - o(1) \ge 3 - o(1)$. Hence $\alpha \ge 12|\beta| - o(1)$ for every $n$, and $\alpha \ge 12|\beta| = 3|\beta_W|$. □

Without gauge fixing the same count gives eighteen partners and the ceiling $\beta_W = \frac{2}{9}$ of [13, Prop. 13]; the temporal gauge, a family of lines in one direction, leaves fourteen. The line field is optimal among forests: twelve is the mean number of partners forced by the number of free links, and it is attained at every link.

## 5. SU(2) past one third: plaquette blocks

Throughout this section $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ is the group of unit quaternions with the chordal metric $|x - y|$, $\bar{x}$ is the conjugate, $\langle x, y\rangle = \mathrm{Re}(x\bar{y})$ is the inner product of $\mathbb{R}^4$, and $dx$ is the normalised Haar measure on $S^3$. Left and right multiplication by unit quaternions and conjugation are isometries, and $\mathrm{Re}(xyz) = \mathrm{Re}(yzx) = \langle y, z\bar{x}\rangle$. Put

$$Z_0(c) = \int_{S^3} e^{\langle c,x\rangle}dx = \sum_{j\ge 0}\frac{(|c|^2/4)^j}{j!\,(j+1)!}, \qquad c \in \mathbb{R}^4,$$

[7] On a torus the line field closes up into cycles, and the holonomies along them cannot be removed by a gauge transformation; the argument never uses a torus. The state $\omega$ is defined only on gauge-invariant observables, which is all that the Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction [52, 53, 54] uses.

let $\nu_c(dx) \propto e^{\langle c,x\rangle}dx$ be the von Mises–Fisher law, and write $g = \log Z_0$, so that $\nabla g(c)$ is the mean and $\operatorname{Hess} g(c)$ the covariance of $\nu_c$.

5.1. **The blocks.** A *block plaquette* is a plaquette of the set $\mathcal{B}$ described in Table 4 of Appendix C, and its *block* is the set of its three active links.

**Lemma 5.1.** *The set $\mathcal{B}$ is invariant under translations by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ and:*

(i) *the blocks partition the active links;*
(ii) *every plaquette $p \notin \mathcal{B}$ meets three distinct blocks, one in each of its active links;*
(iii) *every active link lies in exactly five plaquettes outside $\mathcal{B}$, so it shares a plaquette outside $\mathcal{B}$ with exactly ten active links, none of them in its own block;*
(iv) *if an active link $j$ and a link of a block $B$ lie in a common plaquette outside $\mathcal{B}$, then every link of $B$ has its midpoint within distance 2 of the midpoint of $j$.*

*Proof.* All four statements are invariant under $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ and involve plaquettes at distance at most two from one site, so they hold on $\mathbb{Z}^4$ as soon as they hold on the torus $(\mathbb{Z}/P\mathbb{Z})^4$ with $P \geq 6$, where no such configuration wraps around. They are checked on the tori of side four and six by the program described in Appendix C; the side four already suffices for (i)–(iii). For (iii), an active link lies in six plaquettes, one of which is its block plaquette, and each of the other five contains two further active links, which lie in other blocks by (ii). □

Fix a block plaquette $p$ with active links $e_1, e_2, e_3$. Reading the plaquette product cyclically and deleting its fixed link, $\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p = \operatorname{Re}(y_1y_2y_3)$, where $y_i$ is $Q_{e_i}$ or $Q_{e_i}^{-1}$. Every other plaquette containing $e_i$ meets the block only in $e_i$ by Lemma 5.1(ii) and contributes $4\beta\langle y_i, \bar{s}\rangle$ to the exponent, where $s$ is the staple of $y_i$ in it. Hence the conditional law of the block given all other active links is

$$\mu_b(dy) \propto \exp\Big(\sum_{i=1}^{3}\langle y_i, b_i\rangle + 4\beta \operatorname{Re}(y_1y_2y_3)\Big)dy_1\,dy_2\,dy_3, \tag{5.1}$$

with $b_i$ the sum of $4\beta\bar{s}$ over the five staples, so that $|b_i| \leq 20|\beta|$. Inversion is an isometry of $S^3$ and preserves Haar measure, so we may work with $y$ instead of $Q$. On $(S^3)^3$ we use the metric $d(y,y') = \sum_i |y_i - y_i'|$.

5.2. **The sensitivity of one block.** Let $\lambda_*$ and $\tau$ be a lower and an upper bound for the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{Hess} g(c)$ on the ball $|c| \leq 24|\beta|$, and $M$ an upper bound there for the norm of the third derivative $D^3g(c)$ as a trilinear form. Put

$$\begin{aligned} w &= 8\beta^2(\tau - \lambda_*), \qquad s = \tfrac{1}{4} + (e^w - 1)e^w\sqrt{\tau}, \\ C &= 20|\beta|(4|\beta|\tau s + 16\beta^2 M), \qquad K = \frac{(1+|\beta|)\,s}{1-C}, \end{aligned} \tag{5.2}$$

assuming $C < 1$.

**Lemma 5.2.** *Let $\nu$ be a probability measure and $\lambda = e^R\nu/\nu(e^R)$ with $\operatorname{osc} R \leq \omega$. For bounded $f, h$,*

$$\operatorname{Cov}_\lambda(f,h) \leq \operatorname{Cov}_\nu(f,h) + (e^\omega - 1)e^\omega \operatorname{sd}_\nu(f)\operatorname{sd}_\nu(h).$$

*Proof.* We may assume $0 \leq R \leq \omega$. The density $\rho = e^R/\nu(e^R)$ lies in $[e^{-\omega}, e^\omega]$, so $\delta = \|\rho - 1\|_\infty \leq e^\omega - 1$. With $\tilde{f} = f - \nu f$ and $\tilde{h} = h - \nu h$,

$$\begin{aligned} \operatorname{Cov}_\lambda(f,h) - \operatorname{Cov}_\nu(f,h) = \nu\big((\rho-1)\tilde{f}\tilde{h}\big) \\ - \nu\big((\rho-1)\tilde{f}\big)\,\nu\big((\rho-1)\tilde{h}\big), \end{aligned}$$

and the right side is at most $(\delta + \delta^2)\operatorname{sd}_\nu(f)\operatorname{sd}_\nu(h)$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. □

**Lemma 5.3.** *Let $\beta \geq 0$, $a, c_0 \in \mathbb{R}^4$ with $|a|, |c_0| \leq 20\beta$, and*

$$\kappa(dx) \propto \exp\big(\langle x, a\rangle + g(c_0 + 4\beta\bar{x})\big)dx \quad \text{on } S^3.$$

*For every 1-Lipschitz $f$ and every $h \in \mathbb{R}^4$:*

(i) $\mathrm{Cov}_\kappa(f, \langle x, h\rangle) \le s|h|$;
(ii) *if $c_0$ moves in the direction $k$, then* $|\frac{d}{dt}\kappa(f)| \le (4\beta\tau s + 16\beta^2 M)|k|$.

*Proof.* (i) Taylor's formula at $c_0$ gives $g(c_0 + 4\beta u) = g(c_0) + 4\beta\langle \nabla g(c_0), u\rangle + R(u)$ with $R(u) = 8\beta^2 \operatorname{Hess} g(\xi)(u,u)$ for some $\xi$ on the segment, $|\xi| \le 24\beta$. For $u = \bar{x}$ of norm one, $R(\bar{x}) \in [8\beta^2\lambda_*, 8\beta^2\tau]$, so $\operatorname{osc} R \le w$. Since $\langle \nabla g(c_0), \bar{x}\rangle = \langle x, \overline{\nabla g(c_0)}\rangle$, $\kappa$ is the tilt $e^R\nu/\nu(e^R)$ of $\nu = \nu_c$ with $c = a + 4\beta\overline{\nabla g(c_0)}$. The sharp quarter, Theorem G.4, gives $\mathrm{Cov}_\nu(f, \langle x, h\rangle) = \frac{d}{dt}\nu_{c+th}(f) \le \frac{1}{4}|h|$. A 1-Lipschitz function on a set of diameter two has $\mathrm{sd} \le 1$, and $\mathrm{sd}_\nu\langle x, h\rangle \le \sqrt{\tau}|h|$ because $|c| \le |a| + 4\beta \le 24\beta$. Lemma 5.2 gives (i).

(ii) The derivative is $\mathrm{Cov}_\kappa(f, \langle \nabla g(c_0 + 4\beta\bar{x}), k\rangle)$. Write $\nabla g(c_0 + 4\beta u) = \nabla g(c_0) + 4\beta \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)u + N(u)$. The constant term does not contribute. The linear term is $\langle x, h\rangle$ with $h = 4\beta \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)k$, $|h| \le 4\beta\tau|k|$, and contributes at most $4\beta\tau s|k|$ by (i). For $|u|, |u'| \le 1$, $\|\operatorname{Hess} g(c_0 + 4\beta v) - \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)\| \le 4\beta M|v| \le 4\beta M$ on the segment between them, so $|N(u) - N(u')| \le 16\beta^2 M|u - u'|$; the function $\langle N(\bar{x}), k\rangle$ is therefore $16\beta^2 M|k|$-Lipschitz, its standard deviation is at most that constant, and its covariance with $f$ is at most $16\beta^2 M|k|$. □

**Lemma 5.4.** *Let $C < 1$. If $b$ and $b'$ satisfy $|b_i|, |b_i'| \le 20|\beta|$ and differ only in one coordinate $b_i$, then*

$$W_1(\mu_b, \mu_{b'}) \le K\,|b_i - b_i'|$$

*in the metric $d$.*

*Proof.* The map $y_1 \mapsto -y_1$ turns $\mu_b$ for $\beta$ into the law for $-\beta$ with $b_1$ replaced by $-b_1$ and is an isometry, so we may take $\beta \ge 0$; the cyclic symmetry of $\mathrm{Re}(y_1y_2y_3)$ lets us take $i = 1$. Let $f$ be 1-Lipschitz for $d$ and $\varepsilon = |b_1 - b_1'|$.

*The middle link.* Given $y_1, y_3$, the law of $y_2$ is $\nu_c$ with $c = b_2 + 4\beta\,\overline{y_3y_1}$, which does not involve $b_1$. Changing $y_1$ by $\eta$ moves $c$ by $4\beta\eta$, and the sharp quarter moves $\nu_c$ by at most $\beta\eta$ in $W_1$. Hence $F(y_1, y_3) = \mathbb{E}[f \mid y_1, y_3]$ is $(1+\beta)$-Lipschitz in each variable, and $\mu_b(f) = \mu_b^{13}(F)$, where $\mu_b^{13}$ is the law of $(y_1, y_3)$:

$$\mu_b^{13} \propto e^{\langle y_1, b_1\rangle + \langle y_3, b_3\rangle}\, Z_0\big(b_2 + 4\beta\,\overline{y_3y_1}\big).$$

Since $|b_2 + 4\beta\overline{y_3y_1}| = |b_2y_3 + 4\beta\bar{y}_1| = |y_1b_2 + 4\beta\bar{y}_3|$, its conditional laws are

$$\kappa_1(dy_1 \mid y_3) \propto e^{\langle y_1, b_1\rangle + g(b_2y_3 + 4\beta\bar{y}_1)}dy_1,$$
$$\kappa_3(dy_3 \mid y_1) \propto e^{\langle y_3, b_3\rangle + g(y_1b_2 + 4\beta\bar{y}_3)}dy_3,$$

both of the form of Lemma 5.3, with $|c_0| = |b_2|$.

*Two sites.* Integrating Lemma 5.3(i) along the segment from $b_1$ to $b_1'$ gives $W_1(\kappa_1, \kappa_1') \le s\varepsilon$ for the same $y_3$. Moving $y_3$ to $y_3'$ moves $c_0 = b_2y_3$ along a segment of length $|b_2||y_3 - y_3'| \le 20\beta|y_3 - y_3'|$ inside the ball $|c_0| \le 20\beta$, so Lemma 5.3(ii) gives $W_1(\kappa_1(\cdot \mid y_3), \kappa_1(\cdot \mid y_3')) \le C|y_3 - y_3'|$, and the same for $\kappa_3$, which does not depend on $b_1$. Let $\pi$ be a coupling of $\mu_b^{13}$ and $\mu_{b'}^{13}$ minimising $d_1 + d_3$, $d_k = \mathbb{E}_\pi|y_k - y_k'|$. Replacing $(y_1, y_1')$ by an optimal coupling of $\kappa_1(\cdot \mid y_3)$ and $\kappa_1'(\cdot \mid y_3')$ keeps a coupling, so minimality gives $d_1 \le s\varepsilon + Cd_3$; in the same way $d_3 \le Cd_1$. Hence $d_1 \le s\varepsilon/(1 - C^2)$ and

$$|\mu_b(f) - \mu_{b'}(f)| \le (1+\beta)(d_1 + d_3) \le \frac{(1+\beta)s}{1 - C}\,\varepsilon = K\varepsilon.$$ □

## 5.3. **The constants.**

**Lemma 5.5.** *Write $g(c) = \varphi(|c|^2)$ and $r = |c|$. For $c \ne 0$ the eigenvalues of* $\operatorname{Hess} g(c)$ *are $2\varphi'(r^2)$, three times, and $2\varphi'(r^2) + 4r^2\varphi''(r^2)$, and the norm of $D^3g(c)$ is*

$$\max\Big(|A + \Gamma|, \tfrac{2}{3}|A|\Big), \qquad A = 12r\varphi''(r^2), \quad \Gamma = 8r^3\varphi'''(r^2).$$

*On the ball $r \le 2.07$ every eigenvalue of* $\operatorname{Hess} g$ *lies between* 0.158491 *and* 0.25000001*, and the norm of $D^3g$ is at most* 0.0615586.

*Proof.* Differentiating $\varphi(|c|^2)$ gives $D^2g(v,v) = 2\varphi'|v|^2 + 4\varphi''\langle c,v\rangle^2$ and $D^3g(v,v,v) = 12\varphi''\langle c,v\rangle|v|^2 + 8\varphi'''\langle c,v\rangle^3$. For $|v|=1$ and $t=\langle c/r, v\rangle \in [-1,1]$ the cubic form is $At+\Gamma t^3$, whose largest absolute value is attained at $t=\pm1$ or at an interior critical point, where it equals $\frac{2}{3}|A||t| \le \frac{2}{3}|A|$; by Banach's theorem [7] the supremum of a symmetric trilinear form on the diagonal of the unit sphere is its norm. The numerical bounds are obtained in ball arithmetic [40] from the series of $Z_0$, truncated after forty terms with a proved bound on the tail, on $2\cdot 10^4$ subintervals of $[0, 2.07]$; the program is described in Appendix C. □

5.4. **The proof of Theorem 1.3.** Let $\gamma^{\mathcal{B}}$ be the block specification: for a block $B$, $\gamma^{\mathcal{B}}_B$ resamples the three links of $B$ from (5.1). It comes from the same interaction as $\gamma^F$, so the two specifications have the same Gibbs measures. Define the block coefficients

$$C_{Bj} = \sup \frac{W_1(\gamma^{\mathcal{B}}_B(\cdot \mid Q), \gamma^{\mathcal{B}}_B(\cdot \mid Q'))}{|Q_j - Q'_j|}$$

for an active link $j \notin B$, the supremum over pairs of configurations that differ only at $j$, with $W_1$ for the metric $d$.

**Proposition 5.6.** *Suppose that $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le \alpha < 1$ for every active link $j$. Then the conclusions (i)–(vi) of Proposition 3.2 hold with $-\frac{1}{2}\log\alpha$ in place of $-\log\alpha$.*

*Proof.* The proof of Proposition 3.2 goes through with Lemma B.3 of Appendix B in place of Lemma B.1, and with the set $S$ of part (ii), and the support of $H$ in Corollary B.2, enlarged to the union of the blocks that meet it. The enlargement multiplies the size of these sets by at most three and moves them by at most one, which changes only the constants. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.3.* Let $|\beta| \le 0.345/4$ and take the constants of Lemma 5.5, whose ball $r \le 2.07$ contains $|c| \le 24|\beta|$. With these fixed constants every quantity in (5.2) is increasing in $|\beta|$, and so is

$$\alpha(\beta_W) = 40|\beta|K. \tag{5.3}$$

Changing an active link $j$ by $\eta$ changes one staple of each of its ten partners outside its block by an isometric image of the displacement, so the field $b_i$ of each such partner $i$ moves by at most $4|\beta|\eta$, and Lemma 5.4, applied once for each of these ten fields, gives $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le 40|\beta|K$. Evaluating (5.2) in ball arithmetic at $\beta_W = 0.345$ gives $w \le 0.0054459$, $s \le 0.252746$, $C \le 0.050243$, $K \le 0.289069$ and $\alpha \le 0.99729$; at $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$ it gives $\alpha \le 0.95602$. Proposition 5.6 applies. □

*Remark* 5.7. Most of the range is kept. A second bound for the same sensitivity, which keeps the law of the middle link instead of linearising it, evaluated in floating point on a quadrature grid and maximised over the fields $b$ by a random search followed by the Nelder–Mead method, gives 0.2783 at $\beta_W = 0.34$, against 0.2881 from Lemma 5.4, and $40|\beta|$ times it crosses one near $\beta_W = 0.357$. That computation is not certified and is not used in the proof. Past this point the gain from integrating out one link is spent, and larger blocks are needed, such as the free links of a cube of the line field, whose sensitivity no longer reduces to two sites.

## 6. Curvature in the gauge

In this section $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ is a closed connected subgroup with Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$ and the inner product $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\operatorname{Tr}(XY)$; the bound of Theorem 1.4 is proved first for $\mathrm{U}(N)$. A tangent vector at a field $Q$ is $v = (X_e Q_e)$, $|v|^2 = \sum_e |X_e|^2$. For the plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\mu < \nu$ number its links $e_1 = (x,\mu)$, $e_2 = (x+e_\mu, \nu)$, $e_3 = (x+e_\nu, \mu)$, $e_4 = (x,\nu)$, transport their vectors to $x$,

$$Y_1 = X_{e_1}, \quad Y_2 = Q_{e_1} X_{e_2} Q_{e_1}^*, \quad Y_3 = Q_{e_4} X_{e_3} Q_{e_4}^*, \quad Y_4 = X_{e_4}, \tag{6.1}$$

and write $W = Q_p$. The second derivative of $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p$ along the geodesic $Q_e(t) = e^{tX_e}Q_e$ is

$$\begin{aligned} f_p = &\sum_{i=1}^{4} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_i^2 W) + 2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_1 Y_2 W) + 2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_3 Y_4 W) \\ &- 2\sum_{i\in\{1,2\},\, j\in\{3,4\}} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_i W Y_j), \end{aligned} \tag{6.2}$$

so that $\operatorname{Hess} S_0(v,v) = \sum_p f_p$. To see this, write $Q_p = Q_{e_1}Q_{e_2}Q_{e_3}^*Q_{e_4}^*$. Since $Q_{e_1}e^{tX_{e_2}} = e^{tY_2}Q_{e_1}$ and $e^{-tX_{e_3}}Q_{e_4}^* = Q_{e_4}^* e^{-tY_3}$, the plaquette variable along the geodesic is $Q_p(t) = e^{tY_1}e^{tY_2}We^{-tY_3}e^{-tY_4}$. Differentiating twice at $t=0$ gives the four squares, the two products of neighbouring factors and the four products across $W$, and the squares and the product $WY_3Y_4$ are moved cyclically under the trace. The corner form of $p$ is

$$c_p = 2\langle Y_1, Y_4\rangle - 2\langle Y_1, Y_2\rangle + 2\langle Y_2, WY_3W^*\rangle - 2\langle Y_3, Y_4\rangle. \tag{6.3}$$

It collects the inner products of the transported vectors of two links that meet at a right angle at a corner of $p$.

**Lemma 6.1.** *On $\mathbb{Z}^4$, or on a box with free boundary, for every field $Q$ and every square-summable $X$,*

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_y \Big[ |D_y X|^2 + \sum_\mu \big| X_{y,\mu} + Q^*_{y-e_\mu,\mu} X_{y-e_\mu,\mu} Q_{y-e_\mu,\mu} \big|^2 \Big] \\ = 4|X|^2 + \sum_p c_p, \end{aligned}$$

*where $D_y X = \sum_\mu [X_{y,\mu} - Q^*_{y-e_\mu,\mu} X_{y-e_\mu,\mu} Q_{y-e_\mu,\mu}]$ is the covariant divergence and terms with a link outside the box are omitted.*

*Proof.* At a site $y$ write $o_\mu$ for the vector of the outgoing link in direction $\mu$ and $i_\mu$ for the transported vector of the incoming one, so that $D_y X = \sum_\mu (o_\mu - i_\mu)$. Every link is outgoing at one end and incoming at the other, so the squares $|o_\mu|^2 + |i_\mu|^2$, which appear once in $|D_y X|^2$ and once in $|o_\mu + i_\mu|^2$, add up to $4|X|^2$. The collinear cross term $-2\langle o_\mu, i_\mu\rangle$ of $|D_y X|^2$ cancels the term $+2\langle o_\mu, i_\mu\rangle$ of $|o_\mu + i_\mu|^2$. The remaining cross terms of $|D_y X|^2$ pair two perpendicular ends at $y$, and each such pair is a corner of exactly one plaquette, with the sign and the transport of (6.3) (this is the proof of [13, Lemma 1]). In a box two perpendicular ends at $y$ span a plaquette of the box, because a box is a product of intervals. □

**Lemma 6.2.** *Let $k \in \{1,2,3,4\}$, let $k \pm 1$ (mod 4) be the positions adjacent to $k$ and $k+2$ the opposite one. For every $N$, every $W \in \mathrm{U}(N)$ and all $Y_1, \dots, Y_4 \in \mathfrak{u}(N)$ with $Y_k = 0$,*

$$\pm f_p + \tfrac{9}{10} c_p \le \tfrac{21}{10}\big(|Y_{k-1}|^2 + |Y_{k+1}|^2\big) + \tfrac{5}{4}|Y_{k+2}|^2.$$

*Proof.* Replacing $W$ by $-W$ changes the sign of $f_p$ and fixes $c_p$, so the sign $+$ suffices. Conjugation by a unitary matrix preserves both sides, so we may take $W = \operatorname{diag}(w_a)$. The form $\mathcal{F} = \mathrm{RHS} - f_p - \frac{9}{10}c_p$ then splits into a block for each diagonal position $a$, in the real variables $y_i = -i(Y_i)_{aa}$, and a block for each pair $a \neq b$, in the complex variables $z_i = (Y_i)_{ab}$, since $(Y_i)_{ba} = -\bar{z}_i$. Appendix D shows that every block is positive definite. □

*Proof of the bound in Theorem 1.4.* Every plaquette has exactly one link of $F$, and $X$ vanishes on it. By Lemma 2.2(iii) each active link is adjacent to the fixed link in four of its plaquettes and opposite to it in two. Summing Lemma 6.2 over the plaquettes,

$$\sum_p (\pm f_p + \tfrac{9}{10} c_p) \le (4 \cdot \tfrac{21}{10} + 2 \cdot \tfrac{5}{4})|X|^2 = \tfrac{109}{10}|X|^2.$$

By Lemma 6.1, $\frac{9}{10}\sum_p c_p = \frac{9}{10}\Sigma - \frac{36}{10}|X|^2$, where $\Sigma \ge 0$ is the left side of the lemma. Hence

$$\pm \operatorname{Hess} S_0(v,v) + \tfrac{9}{10}\Sigma \le (\tfrac{109}{10} + \tfrac{36}{10})|X|^2 = \tfrac{29}{2}|X|^2.$$

In a box, links near the boundary lie in fewer plaquettes and receive less. □

The factor $\frac{9}{10}$ is chosen so that the corners are paid by the divergence identity at the price $\frac{36}{10}$ while the local blocks stay positive; Lemma 6.1 is the divergence identity of [13, Lemma 1] with the collinear term written as a square, so nothing is lost by Cauchy–Schwarz.

The two lemmas concern vectors in $\mathfrak{u}(N)$ and fields in $\mathrm{U}(N)$, so the bound holds without change on every closed subgroup $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$, the vectors $X_e$ ranging over its Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$. It is also the Hessian of $S_0$ on $G^E$: the metric is bi-invariant, the geodesics of $G$ through $Q_e$ are the curves $e^{tX}Q_e$ with $X \in \mathfrak{g}$, which are geodesics of $\mathrm{U}(N)$, and the Hessian is read off from second derivatives along geodesics.

**Lemma 6.3.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ be closed and connected with simple Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$, let $\mathfrak{t} \subset \mathfrak{g}$ be a maximal abelian subalgebra, and write the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{ad} H$ on $\mathfrak{g} \otimes \mathbb{C}$ and of $H$ on $\mathbb{C}^N$, for $H \in \mathfrak{t}$, as $i\alpha(H)$ and $i\mu(H)$, with $\alpha$ running over the roots and $\mu$ over the weights of $\mathbb{C}^N$ counted with multiplicity. Then $\mathrm{Ric}_G = \kappa_G \langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ with*

$$\kappa_G = \frac{\sum_\alpha \alpha(H)^2}{4 \sum_\mu \mu(H)^2} \qquad (0 \neq H \in \mathfrak{t}).$$

*Proof.* For a bi-invariant metric the curvature is $R(X,Y)Z = -\frac{1}{4}[[X,Y],Z]$ on left-invariant fields [50, Sect. 7], so for an orthonormal basis $(E_i)$ of $\mathfrak{g}$,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{Ric}(X,X) &= \sum_i \langle R(E_i,X)X, E_i \rangle \\ &= \tfrac{1}{4} \sum_i |[X,E_i]|^2 = -\tfrac{1}{4} \operatorname{Tr}(\operatorname{ad} X)^2, \end{aligned}$$

since $\operatorname{ad} X$ is skew. The Killing form $B(X,Y) = \operatorname{Tr}(\operatorname{ad} X \operatorname{ad} Y)$ and $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ are invariant under the adjoint action, and $\mathfrak{g}$ is simple, so $B = -4\kappa \langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ for a constant $\kappa$ and $\mathrm{Ric} = \kappa \langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$. On $H \in \mathfrak{t}$ the two forms are $B(H,H) = -\sum_\alpha \alpha(H)^2$ and $\langle H, H \rangle = -\operatorname{Tr} H^2 = \sum_\mu \mu(H)^2$. □

Table 1 evaluates the ratio of Lemma 6.3 for every compact simple Lie algebra and a faithful representation of least dimension, on the root systems of [38, Sect. 12.1]; the weights of the representations of dimensions 27 and 56 of $E_6$ and $E_7$ are the roots of $E_8$ with prescribed inner products with a subsystem $A_2$, respectively $A_1$, projected to its orthogonal complement, by the decompositions $248 = (78,1) + (27,3) + (\overline{27},\bar{3}) + (1,8)$ and $248 = (133,1) + (56,2) + (1,3)$ [59]. Taking for $H$ the coroot $\theta^\vee$ of the highest root gives $\sum_\alpha \alpha(\theta^\vee)^2 = 4h^\vee$ and $\sum_\mu \mu(\theta^\vee)^2 = 2\ell_\rho$, so $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$, with the Dynkin index normalised to one on the defining representation of $\mathrm{SU}(N)$. The ratio depends on $\mathfrak{g}$ and $\rho$ only, so it is the same for every compact group with Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$, simply connected or not.

**Lemma 6.4.** *Let $e \neq e'$ be two links of a plaquette $p$, and write*

$$\operatorname{Hess} \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr} Q_p(v,v) = \sum_{e,e' \in p} H^p_{ee'}(X_e, X_{e'})$$

*with bilinear forms satisfying $H^p_{ee'}(a,b) = H^p_{e'e}(b,a)$. Then $|H^p_{ee'}(a,b)| \leq |a|\,|b|$ for all $a, b \in \mathfrak{u}(N)$ and every field.*

*Proof.* By (6.2) the terms of $f_p$ that mix two positions $i \neq j$ are $2 \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr}(Y_1 Y_2 W)$, $2 \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr}(Y_3 Y_4 W)$ and $-2 \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr}(Y_i W Y_j)$, so $H^p_{ee'}$ is $\pm \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr}(abW)$ or $\pm \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr}(aWb)$ after an isometric transport of $a$ and $b$, and $|\operatorname{Tr}(abW)| \leq \|a\|_{\mathrm{HS}} \|bW\|_{\mathrm{HS}} = |a|\,|b|$. □

**Corollary 6.5.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ be closed and connected with semisimple Lie algebra and $N|\beta| < \frac{2}{29}\kappa_G$. For every box the measure $\mu^F_\Lambda$ satisfies the Bakry–Émery condition with $K = \kappa_G - \frac{29}{2} N|\beta| > 0$, uniformly in the box, and hence a logarithmic Sobolev inequality with constant $2/K$ and a Poincaré inequality with constant $1/K$.*

*Proof.* The set $\{Q_F = 1\}$ is a product factor, so its Ricci curvature is at least $\kappa_G$ on every link, and the Hessian of the restricted action is the restriction of $N\beta \operatorname{Hess} S_0$ to $X_F = 0$. Apply the bound and [3, Cor. 5.7.2]. □

6.1. **Decay with an explicit rate.** Let $A'$ be a finite set of active links and $P'$ a finite set of plaquettes whose active links lie in $A'$. An action $S = \sum_{p \in P'} c_p \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F$ with $0 \le c_p \le 1$ is *admissible* if $|\operatorname{Hess} S(v,v)| \le \frac{29}{2}|v|^2$ for all $v$ tangent to $G^{A'}$. Two links lie in at most one common plaquette, so by Lemma 6.4 and Lemma 2.2(iv) the mixed blocks of its Hessian satisfy $|\operatorname{Hess} S_{ee'}(a,b)| \le |a|\,|b|$, and each link has at most twelve partners. The action $S_\Lambda = \sum_{p \in P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F$ of a box is admissible by the bound proved above, and so is every convex combination of two admissible actions. Let $\mu$ be the probability measure on $G^{A'}$ with density proportional to $e^{N\beta S}$ with respect to Haar measure, let $L = \Delta + N\beta\langle \nabla S, \nabla \cdot \rangle$ be its Langevin generator, which is self-adjoint in $L^2(\mu)$, and $P_t = e^{tL}$. Write $\nabla_e$ for the gradient in the factor of the link $e$, and for weights $w : A' \to (0,\infty)$ put $\Gamma^w(f) = \sum_e w_e |\nabla_e f|^2$; $\Gamma$ is the case $w \equiv 1$.

**Lemma 6.6.** *Let $\lambda \ge 0$ and $w_e = e^{\lambda d_e}$, where $|d_e - d_{e'}| \le 1$ whenever $e$ and $e'$ share a plaquette, and put*

$$K_\lambda = \kappa_G - N|\beta|\Big(\tfrac{29}{2} + 12\big(\cosh\tfrac{\lambda}{2} - 1\big)\Big).$$

*Then $\Gamma^w(P_t f) \le e^{-2K_\lambda t} P_t \Gamma^w(f)$ for every smooth $f$ and $t \ge 0$.*

*Proof.* Put $V = -N\beta S$. On the product manifold $M = G^{A'}$ the projection to the tangent space of one factor is parallel, the rough Laplacian commutes with it, and the Ricci tensor is block diagonal. Hence the Bochner–Weitzenböck formula $\nabla \Delta g = \bar{\Delta} \nabla g + \operatorname{Ric}(\nabla g)$, applied factor by factor, together with the derivative of the drift, gives for smooth $g$

$$\begin{aligned} &\tfrac{1}{2} L\Gamma^w(g) - \Gamma^w(g, Lg) \\ &\quad = \sum_e w_e \big(|\nabla \nabla_e g|^2 + \operatorname{Ric}_G(\nabla_e g, \nabla_e g)\big) \\ &\qquad + \sum_{e,e'} w_e \operatorname{Hess} V_{ee'}(\nabla_e g, \nabla_{e'} g), \end{aligned}$$

where $\Gamma^w(g,h)$ is the polarised form.[8] Put $u_e = \nabla_e g$ and $v_e = \sqrt{w_e}\, u_e$. By the symmetry of $\operatorname{Hess} V$,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{e,e'} w_e \operatorname{Hess} V_{ee'}(u_e, u_{e'}) &= \operatorname{Hess} V(v,v) \\ &\quad + \sum_{e \ne e'} \Big(\cosh \tfrac{\lambda(d_e - d_{e'})}{2} - 1\Big) \operatorname{Hess} V_{ee'}(v_e, v_{e'}), \end{aligned}$$

because $\frac{w_e + w_{e'}}{2\sqrt{w_e w_{e'}}} = \cosh \frac{\lambda(d_e - d_{e'})}{2}$. The first term is at least $-\frac{29}{2} N|\beta|\,|v|^2$. In the second only partners contribute, each with a coefficient at most $\cosh\frac{\lambda}{2} - 1$ and a block of norm at most $N|\beta|$, and $2|v_e|\,|v_{e'}| \le |v_e|^2 + |v_{e'}|^2$ with twelve partners per link bounds it by $12(\cosh\frac{\lambda}{2} - 1)N|\beta|\,|v|^2$. Since $\operatorname{Ric}_G \ge \kappa_G$ and $|v|^2 = \Gamma^w(g)$,

$$\tfrac{1}{2} L\Gamma^w(g) - \Gamma^w(g, Lg) \ge K_\lambda \Gamma^w(g).$$

For fixed $t$ let $\varphi(s) = P_s \Gamma^w(P_{t-s} f)$, $0 \le s \le t$. Then $\varphi'(s) = P_s\big(L\Gamma^w(g_s) - 2\Gamma^w(g_s, Lg_s)\big) \ge 2K_\lambda \varphi(s)$ with $g_s = P_{t-s} f$, and $\varphi(0) \le e^{-2K_\lambda t}\varphi(t)$ is the claim. □

[8] For $w \equiv 1$ this is Bochner's identity $\Gamma_2 = |\nabla^2 g|^2 + (\operatorname{Ric} + \operatorname{Hess} V)(\nabla g, \nabla g)$; the weights enter only through the factor index, which the connection, the Laplacian and the Ricci tensor preserve, so only the off-diagonal blocks of $\operatorname{Hess} V$ see them.

**Lemma 6.7.** *Suppose $K_\lambda > 0$. Let $f$ and $g$ be smooth functions on $G^{A'}$ that depend only on the links of $A_f$ and of $B_g$, and let $D$ be the least number of steps from $A_f$ to $B_g$ in the graph on $A'$ whose edges join links that share a plaquette. Then*

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_\mu(f,g)| \le \frac{e^{-\lambda D/2}}{K_\lambda}\,\|\nabla f\|_\infty \sum_{e\in B_g} \|\nabla_e g\|_\infty,$$

*where $\|\nabla f\|_\infty^2 = \sup \sum_e |\nabla_e f|^2$.*

*Proof.* Since $K_0 \ge K_\lambda > 0$, Lemma 6.6 with $\lambda = 0$ gives $\Gamma(P_t f) \le e^{-2K_0 t}\|\nabla f\|_\infty^2$, so $P_t f$ converges uniformly to a constant, which is $\mu(f)$ by invariance, $M$ being connected. Since $\frac{d}{dt}\mu(gP_t f) = \mu(gLP_t f) = -\mu(\Gamma(g, P_t f))$,

$$\operatorname{Cov}_\mu(f,g) = \int_0^\infty \mu(\Gamma(P_t f, g))\,dt.$$

Let $d_e$ be the smaller of $D$ and the graph distance from $e$ to $A_f$, so that $|d_e - d_{e'}| \le 1$ for partners, $w_e = 1$ on $A_f$, $w_e = e^{\lambda D}$ on $B_g$, and $\Gamma^w(f) \le \|\nabla f\|_\infty^2$. For $e \in B_g$, Lemma 6.6 gives $|\nabla_e P_t f|^2 \le w_e^{-1}\Gamma^w(P_t f) \le e^{-\lambda D}e^{-2K_\lambda t}\|\nabla f\|_\infty^2$. Hence $|\Gamma(P_t f, g)| \le e^{-\lambda D/2}e^{-K_\lambda t}\|\nabla f\|_\infty \sum_{e\in B_g}\|\nabla_e g\|_\infty$, and integration in $t$ gives the bound. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.5.* Let $\lambda^* > 0$ solve $K_{\lambda^*} = 0$, so that $\frac{\lambda^*}{2} = m_G(\beta)$, and let $0 < \lambda < \lambda^*$; then $K_\lambda > 0$.

*Decay in boxes.* Lemma 6.7 with $S = S_\Lambda$ gives

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_\Lambda^F}(f,g)| \le C_{f,g}e^{-\lambda D/2},$$

uniformly in the box.

*Limit.* For boxes $\Lambda \subset \Lambda'$ let $S_s = (1-s)S_\Lambda + sS_{\Lambda'}$ on the active links of $\Lambda'$, $s \in [0,1]$, and $\mu_s$ the corresponding measure; $S_s$ is admissible, $\mu_0$ is $\mu_\Lambda^F$ times Haar measure on the active links outside $\Lambda$, and $\mu_1 = \mu_{\Lambda'}^F$. For smooth $f$ of the active links of $\Lambda$,

$$\frac{d}{ds}\mu_s(f) = N\beta \sum_{p\in P(\Lambda')\setminus P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_s}(f, \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F),$$

and $|\nabla_e \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p| \le \|Q_p\|_{\mathrm{HS}} = \sqrt{N}$. A step in the graph of Lemma 6.7 moves a link by at most one lattice unit, so a plaquette at graph distance $k$ from the support $T$ of $f$ lies within distance $k+1$ of $T$, there are at most $C_T(k+1)^4$ of them, and every plaquette outside $P(\Lambda)$ is at graph distance at least $R-1$, $R$ the distance from $T$ to the complement of $\Lambda$. Lemma 6.7 gives

$$|\mu_{\Lambda'}^F(f) - \mu_\Lambda^F(f)| \le C_f R^4 e^{-\lambda R/2}.$$

The limit therefore exists along every increasing sequence of boxes, and two sequences are compared through their intersections, which are boxes. Continuous gauge-invariant $O$ are uniform limits of smooth gauge-invariant ones, for instance of $e^{\tau\Delta}O$, since the heat semigroup of $G^E$ commutes with left and right translations; with Lemma 3.1 the limit $\omega(O)$ of $W_\Lambda(O)$ exists for all of them.

*Properties.* Invariance and, for $\beta \ge 0$, reflection positivity follow as in Proposition 3.2(iii)–(iv). For Lipschitz $O$ the functions $e^{\tau\Delta}O$ are smooth with the same Lipschitz constant, since $\mathrm{Ric}_G \ge 0$ [3, Sect. 3.3], so the bound of the first step passes to $\omega$ and to Lipschitz observables. Two links of one plaquette have time coordinates that differ by at most one, so observables at time separation $t$ are at graph distance at least $t - c$, and truncated correlations decay at every rate below $m_G(\beta)$. The gap follows from Proposition F.1 as in Proposition 3.2(vi). □

*Proof of the rest of Theorem 1.4.* By Lemma 6.3 and Table 1, $\kappa_{\mathrm{SU}(N)} = \frac{N}{2}$ and $\kappa_{\mathrm{SO}(N)} = \frac{N-2}{4}$; for SO(4), whose Lie algebra is $\mathfrak{so}(3)\oplus\mathfrak{so}(3)$ acting on $\mathbb{R}^4\otimes\mathbb{C} = \mathbb{C}^2\otimes\mathbb{C}^2$, each ideal gives $\frac{1}{2}$ by the same computation. The conditions of Theorem 1.4 are those of Theorem 1.5. □

*Remark* 6.8. Let $h_F$ be the supremum of $\pm\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ on the gauge-fixed directions, so that uniform curvature reaches $|\beta| < 1/(2h_F)$ and no further. At the identity field $-\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ restricted to $X_F = 0$ has the eigenvalue $9 + \sqrt{17} = 13.123$ on the torus of side two, so $9 + \sqrt{17} \le h_F \le \frac{29}{2}$. A gradient search over SU(2) fields of periods two, four and six gives $h_F = 13.97401$, attained by an abelian field; certificates made of plaquette forms and vertex forms on the period-two cell cannot go below 14.384. With this gauge the curvature method stops between $|\beta| = \frac{1}{29}$ and $\frac{1}{26.25}$.

## 7. SU(3) up to 3/4

In this section $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$, $\beta \ge 0$ and $\beta_W = 9\beta$. The distance on SU(3) is $d(U, V) = \|U - V\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$, which is at most the geodesic distance for $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\operatorname{Tr}(XY)$; $K = \operatorname{conv}\mathrm{SU}(3)$; $A(M) = \frac{1}{2}(M - M^*)$ and $P$ removes the trace. With this inner product $\mathrm{Ric} = \frac{3}{2}$, the Casimir of the fundamental representation is $\lambda_F = \frac{8}{3}$ and that of the adjoint representation is 6.

7.1. **Reduction to one link.** The conditional law of an active link is

$$\nu_b(dU) \propto e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)} dU, \qquad b = N\beta \sum_{p \ni e} S_p,$$

where $S_p$ is the staple of $e$ in $p$, a product of SU(3) matrices and identities, or its adjoint. Six staples give $b \in rK$ with $r = 6N\beta = 2\beta_W$. For a matrix $h$ put $\varphi_h(U) = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Uh)$ and

$$L_h(b) = \sup\{\operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_b}(g, \varphi_h) : g \text{ 1-Lipschitz for } d\},$$

$$\Lambda(r) = \sup_{b \in rK} \sup_{\|h\|_{\mathrm{HS}}=1} L_h(b).$$

Changing a partner $e'$ changes one staple by a matrix of norm $d(Q_{e'}, Q'_{e'})$. Along the segment $b_t$ from $b$ to $b'$, which stays in $rK$, $\frac{d}{dt}\nu_{b_t}(g) = \operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_{b_t}}(g, \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(U(b' - b)))$, so $W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le N\beta\Lambda(r)\, d(Q_{e'}, Q'_{e'})$. With twelve partners per link,

$$\alpha \le 12N\beta\Lambda(r) = 2r\Lambda(r) = 4\beta_W\Lambda(2\beta_W). \tag{7.1}$$

Since $K$ is convex and contains 0, the mean of $I, \omega I, \omega^2 I$ with $\omega^3 = 1$, $r'K \subset rK$ for $r' \le r$ and $\Lambda$ is nondecreasing.

7.2. **Gradients and one-forms.**

**Lemma 7.1.** *In the left trivialisation,* $\nabla\varphi_c(U) = -PA(cU)$*; if* $V = \varphi_b$ *then* $\operatorname{Hess} V(X, X) = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(UX^2 b)$*; and* $\Delta\varphi_c = -\lambda_F\varphi_c$.

*Proof.* $\frac{d}{dt}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ue^{tX}c)|_{t=0} = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(cUX) = -\langle PA(cU), X\rangle$ for $X \in \mathfrak{su}(3)$. On a group with a bi-invariant metric $\nabla_X X = 0$ for left-invariant $X$, so the Hessian is the second derivative along $e^{tX}$. The function $\varphi_c$ is a matrix coefficient of the fundamental representation, on which the Casimir acts by $\lambda_F$. □

**Lemma 7.2.** *The bottom of the spectrum of the rough Laplacian* $\nabla^*\nabla$ *on* $L^2$ *one-forms of* SU(3) *is* $\mu_0 = \frac{7}{6}$.

*Proof.* Trivialise one-forms on the left, so that a one-form is a function $f : \mathrm{SU}(3) \to \mathfrak{su}(3)$. For an orthonormal basis $X_a$ acting as left-invariant vector fields, $\nabla_{X_a} Y = \frac{1}{2}[X_a, Y]$ and $\nabla_{X_a} X_a = 0$, so $\nabla^*\nabla = -\sum_a(\rho(X_a) + \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{ad} X_a)^2$. On the isotypic part $V_\pi \otimes V_\pi^* \otimes \mathfrak{su}(3)$ of $L^2 \otimes \mathfrak{su}(3)$ put $A_a = \rho_\pi(X_a)$, $B_a = \operatorname{ad} X_a$ and $T_a = A_a + B_a$, the action on the tensor product. Since $A_a$ and $B_a$ commute, $A_a + \frac{1}{2}B_a = \frac{1}{2}(A_a + T_a)$ and $A_aT_a + T_aA_a = A_a^2 + T_a^2 - B_a^2$, so on a component $\sigma \subset \pi \otimes \mathrm{ad}$

$$\nabla^*\nabla = \tfrac{1}{2}(C_\pi + C_\sigma) - \tfrac{1}{4}C_{\mathrm{ad}} = \tfrac{1}{2}(C_\pi + C_\sigma) - \tfrac{3}{2},$$

with $C(p, q) = \frac{2}{3}(p^2 + q^2 + pq + 3p + 3q)$ for the representation of highest weight $(p, q)$ [30]. The components of $(p, q) \otimes (1, 1)$ are $(p + 1, q + 1)$, $(p + 2, q - 1)$, $(p - 1, q + 2)$, $(p + 1, q - 2)$,

$(p-2,q+1)$, $(p-1,q-1)$ and $(p,q)$, the last with multiplicity two, one or zero as both, one or none of $p,q$ are positive, and only those with nonnegative labels occur. For $\pi=(0,0)$ the only component is $(1,1)$, with value $\frac{3}{2}$. For $\pi=(1,0)$ the components are $(2,1)$, $(0,2)$, $(1,0)$, with values $\frac{31}{6}$, $\frac{19}{6}$, $\frac{7}{6}$, and $(0,1)$ is conjugate. For $p+q\geq 2$ the smallest values occur at $(p-1,q-1)$, $(p,q)$, $(p-2,q+1)$ or $(p+1,q-2)$, and each is at least $\frac{1}{3}(2(p^2+q^2+pq)+3(p+q)-3)-\frac{3}{2}\geq\frac{3}{2}$. □

7.3. **The gap of the one-link measure.**

**Lemma 7.3.** *For $b\in rK$ the spectral gap of $L=\Delta+\langle\nabla V,\nabla\cdot\rangle$, $V=\varphi_b$, on $L^2(\nu_b)$ is at least*

$$\gamma(r)=\tfrac{39}{64}\mu_0+\tfrac{3}{2}-\tfrac{r}{2}=\tfrac{283}{128}-\tfrac{r}{2}.$$

*Proof.* Let $-Lf=\lambda f$ with $\lambda>0$, $\omega=df$ and $\eta=e^{V/2}\omega$; norms are in $L^2(dU)$. Bochner's formula integrated against $\nu_b$ gives $\lambda\nu_b|\omega|^2=\nu_b|\nabla\omega|^2+\nu_b((\mathrm{Ric}-\mathrm{Hess}\,V)(\omega,\omega))$, and since $e^{V/2}\nabla\omega=\nabla\eta-\frac{1}{2}dV\otimes\eta$,

$$\lambda\|\eta\|^2=\|\nabla\eta-\tfrac{1}{2}dV\otimes\eta\|^2+\int(\mathrm{Ric}-\mathrm{Hess}\,V)(\eta,\eta). \tag{7.2}$$

Put $\mathcal{A}=\nabla\eta$ and $\mathcal{B}=\frac{1}{2}dV\otimes\eta$. Then

$$\langle\mathcal{A},\mathcal{B}\rangle=\tfrac{1}{4}\int\langle\nabla V,\nabla|\eta|^2\rangle=\tfrac{\lambda_F}{4}\int V|\eta|^2,$$

because $-\Delta V=\lambda_F V$. Writing $\|\mathcal{A}-\mathcal{B}\|^2=\|\frac{5}{8}\mathcal{A}-\mathcal{B}\|^2+\frac{39}{64}\|\mathcal{A}\|^2-\frac{3}{4}\langle\mathcal{A},\mathcal{B}\rangle$ and dropping the first term,

$$\|\mathcal{A}-\mathcal{B}\|^2\geq\tfrac{39}{64}\mu_0\|\eta\|^2-\tfrac{1}{2}\int V|\eta|^2$$

by Lemma 7.2. With $\mathrm{Ric}=\frac{3}{2}$, (7.2) gives $\lambda\|\eta\|^2\geq(\frac{39}{64}\mu_0+\frac{3}{2})\|\eta\|^2-\int(\mathrm{Hess}\,V(\eta,\eta)+\frac{1}{2}V|\eta|^2)$, and the claim follows from the pointwise bound

$$\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(MX^2)+\tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,M\leq\tfrac{r}{2}|X|^2,\qquad M=bU\in rK, \tag{7.3}$$

since $\mathrm{Hess}\,V(X,X)=\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(MX^2)$ and $V=\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,M$. The maximum over $|X|=1$ of the left side is convex in $M$, so it suffices to take $M=rW$ with $W\in\mathrm{SU}(3)$ and, after a conjugation, $W=\mathrm{diag}(e^{i\theta_k})$ with $\sum_k\theta_k=0$; put $c_k=\cos\theta_k$. Write $X=iH$ with $H$ Hermitian, traceless, $\mathrm{Tr}\,H^2=1$, with diagonal $d_k$ and entries $H_{jk}$. Then

$$\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(WX^2)=-\sum_k c_kd_k^2-\sum_{j<k}(c_j+c_k)|H_{jk}|^2,$$

with $\sum_k d_k^2+2\sum_{j<k}|H_{jk}|^2=1$, so the maximum is the larger of $q_{\mathrm{off}}=\max_{j<k}-\frac{1}{2}(c_j+c_k)$ and $q_{\mathrm{diag}}=\max\{-\sum c_kd_k^2:\sum d_k=0,\ \sum d_k^2=1\}$. If $l$ is the third index, $q_{\mathrm{off}}+\frac{1}{2}\sum_k c_k=\frac{1}{2}c_l\leq\frac{1}{2}$. The value $q_{\mathrm{diag}}$ is minus the smaller eigenvalue of $\mathrm{diag}(c)$ compressed to the plane $\sum d_k=0$; the eigenvalues of the compression solve $\sum_k(c_k-\mu)^{-1}=0$, that is $3\mu^2-2e_1\mu+e_2=0$ with $e_1,e_2$ the elementary symmetric functions of the $c_k$, so $q_{\mathrm{diag}}=\frac{1}{3}(\sqrt{e_1^2-3e_2}-e_1)$. The inequality $q_{\mathrm{diag}}+\frac{1}{2}e_1\leq\frac{1}{2}$ is $\sqrt{e_1^2-3e_2}\leq\frac{1}{2}(3-e_1)$, that is $e_1^2-4e_2+2e_1-3\leq 0$. When $\sum\theta_k=0$, $\sum c_k^2=1+2c_1c_2c_3$, and with this identity the left side equals $-2(1-c_1)(1-c_2)(1-c_3)\leq 0$. □

The weight $\frac{5}{8}$ is the one that gives the coefficient $\frac{1}{2}$ of $V$, and (7.3) is an equality at $W=I$. At $r=\frac{3}{2}$, $\gamma=\frac{187}{128}$.[9]

[9]The direct Bochner bound, with Minkowski's inequality in place of the cross term, gives $(\sqrt{\mu_0}-\frac{g}{2}r)^2+\frac{3}{2}-r$ with $g^2=\max_W\|PA(W)\|^2=2.0655$; it is exact at $b=0$, where the gap is $\frac{8}{3}$, but falls below $\gamma$ for $r>0.24$ and vanishes before $r=1$.

### 7.4. **A corrector of degree two.**

**Lemma 7.4.** *For $b \in rK$, $\|h\| = 1$ and every smooth real function $u$ on* $\mathrm{SU}(3)$,

$$L_h(b) \le \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla u|^2} + \sqrt{\mathrm{Var}_{\nu_b}(\varphi_h + Lu)/\gamma(r)}.$$

*Proof.* Let $-L\psi = \varphi_h - \nu_b\varphi_h$. For a 1-Lipschitz $g$, $|\nabla g| \le 1$ almost everywhere, because $d$ is at most the geodesic distance, so $\mathrm{Cov}(g, \varphi_h) = \nu_b\langle \nabla g, \nabla\psi\rangle \le \nu_b|\nabla\psi|$. Write $\psi = u + \chi$. Since $\nu_b(Lu) = 0$, $\chi$ solves $-L\chi = X - \nu_b X$ with $X = \varphi_h + Lu$, and

$$\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2 = \mathrm{Cov}(\chi, X) \le \sqrt{\mathrm{Var}\,\chi\ \mathrm{Var}\,X} \le \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2\,\mathrm{Var}\,X/\gamma}$$

by Lemma 7.3. Hence $\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2 \le \mathrm{Var}\,X/\gamma$, and $\nu_b|\nabla\psi| \le \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla u|^2} + \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2}$. □

The best $u$ is $\psi$ itself, and then the second term vanishes. With $u = s\varphi_h$, Lemma 7.1 gives $\varphi_h + Lu = (1 - s\lambda_F)\varphi_h + s\Gamma$ with $\Gamma = \langle \nabla V, \nabla\varphi_h\rangle$; the choice $s = 1/\lambda_F$ removes $\varphi_h$ and leaves the drift. This blended corrector reaches $\beta_W = \frac{45}{64}$ and stops near 0.715 (Section 9).[10] We take $u$ in a space of polynomials of degree two.

Let $\mathcal{P}_2$ be the real vector space of real polynomials of degree one or two in the entries $u_{ij}$ of $U$ and $\bar{u}_{ij}$ of $\bar{U}$. It has dimension 189: a basis $(B_k)$ consists of $\frac{1}{2}(m + \bar{m})$ and $\frac{1}{2i}(m - \bar{m})$ for each pair $\{m, \bar{m}\}$ of conjugate monomials with $m \ne \bar{m}$, and $m$ itself when $m = \bar{m}$. Identify $h \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$ with $\mathbb{R}^{18}$ through the real and imaginary parts of its entries. For a real $189 \times 18$ matrix $C$ put

$$q_h = \sum_k \sum_{m=1}^{18} C_{km} h_m B_k \in \mathcal{P}_2,$$

linear in $h$. For diagonal $b = \mathrm{diag}(a_1, a_2, x_3 + iy_3)$ we have $V = \sum_k b_k\varphi_{F_k}$ with $(b_k) = (a_1, a_2, x_3, y_3)$ and $F = (e_{11}, e_{22}, e_{33}, ie_{33})$, so

$$X_h = \varphi_h + Lq_h = \varphi_h + \Delta q_h + \sum_k b_k\langle \nabla\varphi_{F_k}, \nabla q_h\rangle \tag{7.4}$$

is a polynomial of degree at most three, affine in $b$, while $\nabla q_h$ does not depend on $b$. The squares of these functions have degree at most six, so the quadratic forms $h \mapsto \nu_b|\nabla q_h|^2$ and $h \mapsto \nu_b[(X_h - \kappa)^2]$ are combinations of moments of $\nu_b$ of degree at most six.

To compute $\Delta$ and $\langle \nabla f, \nabla g\rangle$ exactly we use the basis of $\mathfrak{su}(3)$

$$e_{jk} - e_{kj}, \quad i(e_{jk} + e_{kj})\ (j < k), \quad i(e_{11} - e_{22}), \quad i(e_{11} + e_{22} - 2e_{33}),$$

acting as left-invariant fields $X_a f(U) = \frac{d}{dt} f(Ue^{tX_a})|_{t=0}$, with weights $w_a = \frac{1}{2}$ for the first seven and $\frac{1}{6}$ for the last. Then $\sum_a w_a X_a \otimes X_a$ is the Casimir tensor of $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\mathrm{Tr}(XY)$, so

$$\langle \nabla f, \nabla g\rangle = \sum_a w_a\, X_a f\, X_a g, \qquad \Delta = \sum_a w_a X_a^2.$$

The fields map monomials to combinations of monomials of the same degree with coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$; for instance $\Delta\varphi_h = -\frac{8}{3}\varphi_h$, as in Lemma 7.1.

### 7.5. **Orbits of staple sums.**

**Lemma 7.5.** *Let $V, W \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$.*

(i) *$L_h(VbW) = L_{V^{-1}hW^{-1}}(b)$ and $L_h(\bar{b}) = L_{\bar{h}}(b)$.*
(ii) *Every $b \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$ is in the orbit of some $\mathrm{diag}(a_1, a_2, z_3)$ with $a_1 \ge a_2 \ge |z_3|$ and $\mathrm{Im}\, z_3 \ge 0$.*
(iii) *A diagonal matrix lies in $K$ if and only if it lies in the convex hull of the diagonal torus $T$ of* $\mathrm{SU}(3)$.

[10] An earlier version of this paper proved Theorem 1.6 for $\beta_W \le \frac{45}{64}$ with $u = s\varphi_h$, $s$ chosen box by box, on 865 boxes at $r = \frac{45}{32}$; the largest bound was 0.999657.

*Proof.* (i) If $U$ has law $\nu_{VbW}$ then $WUV$ has law $\nu_b$; the map preserves $d$ and Haar measure, and $\varphi_h(U) = \varphi_{V^{-1}hW^{-1}}(WUV)$. For $\bar b$ use $U \mapsto \bar U$. (ii) Take a singular value decomposition $b = V_1 \Sigma W_1$ and move the determinants of $V_1, W_1$ into the last entry; a complex conjugation makes $\operatorname{Im} z_3 \geq 0$. (iii) Let $c$ be diagonal with nonzero entries of distinct moduli and let $U$ maximise $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(cU)$ on $\mathrm{SU}(3)$. The derivative along $\mathfrak{su}(3)$ vanishes, so the anti-Hermitian part of $cU$ is a multiple $i\lambda I$ of the identity and $cU = H + i\lambda I$ with $H$ Hermitian. Then $H^2 + \lambda^2 I = cc^*$ is diagonal with distinct entries, $H$ commutes with it and is diagonal, and $U \in T$. Hence $\max_{\mathrm{SU}(3)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(cU) = \max_T \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(ct)$ for such $c$, and by continuity for every diagonal $c$. A diagonal matrix outside $\operatorname{conv} T$ is separated from it by such a functional, which then separates it from $K$. □

Since every $b \in rK$ has operator norm at most $r$,

$$\Lambda(r) = \sup\Big\{ \sup_{\|h\|=1} L_h(b) : b \in \mathcal{R}_r \Big\},$$

where $\mathcal{R}_r$ is the set of $\operatorname{diag}(a_1, a_2, x_3 + iy_3) \in r \operatorname{conv} T$ with $a_1 \geq a_2 \geq |x_3 + iy_3|$ and $y_3 \geq 0$, a subset of the box $[0, r]^2 \times [-r, r] \times [0, r]$ in the coordinates $(a_1, a_2, x_3, y_3)$.

### 7.6. **Exact moments and interpolation.**

**Lemma 7.6.** *For $D, D' \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$ let $\mathbb{E}_H$ be the Haar mean on $\mathrm{SU}(3)$ and*

$$Z(D, D') = \mathbb{E}_H \exp\big(\tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(UD) + \tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(\bar U D')\big).$$

*Then*

$$Z(D, D') = \sum_{p \geq q \geq 0} \frac{s_{(p,q)}(DD'^{\top})\, G_{p,q}(\det D)\, G_{p,q}(\det D')}{d_{p,q}},$$

*with $G_{p,q}(z) = \sum_{k\geq 0} c_{(p+k,q+k,k)} z^k$, $c_\lambda = 2^{-|\lambda|}/\prod \mathrm{hooks}(\lambda)$, $d_{p,q} = \tfrac{1}{2}(p-q+1)(q+1)(p+2)$ and $s_{(p,q)}$ the Schur polynomial. The moments of degree $j$ in $U$ and $k$ in $\bar U$ are $\mathbb{E}_H[u^\alpha \bar u^\beta e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)}] = 2^{|\alpha|+|\beta|} \partial_D^\alpha \partial_{D'}^\beta Z(b, \bar b)$, the entry $u_{ij}$ pairing with $D_{ji}$.*

*Proof.* We use $(\operatorname{Tr} X)^n = \sum_{\lambda \vdash n} f^\lambda s_\lambda(X)$, where $f^\lambda$ is the number of standard tableaux of shape $\lambda$, given by the hook length formula [60, Cor. 7.21.6]. Expanding the exponential gives

$$e^{\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} X} = \sum_{n\geq 0} \frac{(\operatorname{Tr} X)^n}{2^n n!} = \sum_\lambda c_\lambda s_\lambda(X),$$

the sum over partitions with at most three parts. For $U \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$ one has $s_{\lambda+(k,k,k)}(UD) = (\det D)^k s_\lambda(UD)$, so

$$e^{\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(UD)} = \sum_{p\geq q} G_{p,q}(\det D)\, \chi_{p,q}(UD),$$

where $\chi_{p,q}$ is the irreducible character of highest weight $(p, q, 0)$ and $d_{p,q}$ its dimension. Since $\bar U = (U^{-1})^\top$, we have $\chi_{p,q}(\bar U D') = \chi_{p,q}(U^{-1} D'^{\top})$, and Schur orthogonality [20, Ch. 2],

$$\mathbb{E}_H\big[\chi_\rho(UA)\chi_{\rho'}(U^{-1}B)\big] = \delta_{\rho\rho'} \frac{\chi_\rho(AB)}{d_\rho},$$

gives the expansion. The bound below gives absolute convergence. Finally $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub) = \tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub) + \tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(\bar U \bar b)$. □

The computation keeps $p \leq 34$ and $k \leq 11$. Every omitted partition has more than 34 boxes, and since $|s_\lambda(X)| \leq \dim(\lambda)\|X\|^{|\lambda|}$ and $\sum_{\lambda\vdash n} f^\lambda \dim \lambda = 3^n$ by Schur–Weyl duality, the omitted part of each factor is at most $\sum_{n>34}(\frac{3}{2}\|D\|)^n/n!$; Cauchy's estimate on a polydisc around $b$ turns this into a bound for every derivative (Appendix E).

**Lemma 7.7** (Interpolation on a box)**.** *Let $Q = \prod_k [l_k, l_k + w_k]$ in the coordinates $(a_1, a_2, x_3, y_3)$, with corners $b_i$ and multilinear weights $\omega_i(b) \geq 0$, $\sum_i \omega_i(b) = 1$, and let $\varsigma = w_1^2 + w_2^2 + \max(w_3^2, w_4^2)$. For $b \in Q$:*

(i) $Z(b) \ge e^{-\varsigma/8} \sum_i \omega_i(b) Z(b_i)$;
(ii) $\nu_b(f) \le e^{\varsigma/8} \max_i \nu_{b_i}(f)$ *for every* $f \ge 0$ *that does not depend on* $b$;
(iii) *if* $Y_b = (\mathcal{A} + \sum_k (b_k - \beta_k)\mathcal{B}_k)^2$ *with functions* $\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B}_k$ *of* $U$ *and a fixed point* $\beta$, *then*

$$\nu_b(Y_b) \le e^{\varsigma/8}\Big(\max_i \nu_{b_i}(Y_{b_i}) + \sum_k \frac{w_k^2}{4}\,\frac{\max_i Z(b_i)\nu_{b_i}(\mathcal{B}_k^2)}{\min_i Z(b_i)}\Big).$$

*Proof.* Write $E(b) = e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)} = \prod_k e^{c_k b_k}$, where

$$c = (\operatorname{Re} u_{11}, \operatorname{Re} u_{22}, \operatorname{Re} u_{33}, -\operatorname{Im} u_{33}),$$

so that $|c_k| \le 1$ and $c_3^2 + c_4^2 \le 1$. In each coordinate the chord of $e^{c_k x}$ over $[l_k, l_k + w_k]$ lies above the function and, by Hoeffding's lemma [37] for a two-point variable, below $e^{c_k x} e^{c_k^2 w_k^2/8}$. Multiplying,

$$E(b) \le \sum_i \omega_i(b) E(b_i) \le E(b)\, e^{\sum_k c_k^2 w_k^2/8} \le E(b)\, e^{\varsigma/8}. \tag{7.5}$$

Integrating the right inequality gives (i), and (ii) follows from the left one and (i). For (iii) let $\mathcal{F}(b) = Y_b E(b)$ and $I_k$ the linear interpolation in the $k$-th coordinate, so that $\mathcal{F} - I_1 I_2 I_3 I_4 \mathcal{F} = \sum_k I_1 \cdots I_{k-1}(\mathcal{F} - I_k \mathcal{F})$. Along the $k$-th coordinate $\mathcal{F}$ is $\ell^2 e^{c_k x}$ times a positive factor, with $\ell$ affine of slope $\mathcal{B}_k$, and $\partial_k^2 \mathcal{F} = ((c_k \ell + 2\mathcal{B}_k)^2 - 2\mathcal{B}_k^2)E \ge -2\mathcal{B}_k^2 E$. With the Green kernel of the interval, whose integral is at most $w_k^2/8$,

$$\mathcal{F} - I_k \mathcal{F} \le 2\mathcal{B}_k^2 \int G\, E \le \tfrac{w_k^2}{4} \mathcal{B}_k^2 \sum_i \omega_i^{(k)} E(b_i)$$

by the left inequality of (7.5), with weights $\omega_i^{(k)} \ge 0$ of sum one that do not depend on $U$. The operators $I_j$ have nonnegative weights of sum one; integrate over $U$ and divide by $Z(b)$, bounded below by (i). □

7.7. **The cover and the theorem.** Fix a box $Q$ and a matrix $C$. For any constant $\kappa$, $\operatorname{Var}(X_h) \le \nu_b[(X_h - \kappa)^2]$; take $\kappa = \langle \kappa(b), h\rangle$ with $\kappa(b)$ affine in $b$, fitted to the means at the corners. By (7.4), $X_h - \kappa = \mathcal{A} + \sum_k (b_k - \beta_k)\mathcal{B}_k$ with $\beta$ the centre of $Q$ and $\mathcal{B}_k = \langle \nabla\varphi_{F_k}, \nabla q_h\rangle - \langle \partial_k \kappa, h\rangle$, and Lemmas 7.4 and 7.7 give, for all $b \in Q \cap \mathcal{R}_r$,

$$\begin{aligned} \sup_h L_h(b) \le{}& \sqrt{e^{\varsigma/8} \max_i \lambda_A(b_i)} \\ &+ \sqrt{\frac{e^{\varsigma/8}}{\gamma(r)}\Big(\max_i \lambda_V(b_i) + \frac{e_N}{\min_i Z(b_i)}\Big)}, \end{aligned} \tag{7.6}$$

where $e_N = \sum_k \frac{w_k^2}{4} \max_i Z(b_i)\lambda_k(b_i)$ and $\lambda_A$, $\lambda_V$, $\lambda_k$ are the largest eigenvalues of the quadratic forms $h \mapsto \nu_{b_i}|\nabla q_h|^2$, $h \mapsto \nu_{b_i}[(X_h - \kappa)^2]$ at $b = b_i$, and $h \mapsto \nu_{b_i}[\mathcal{B}_k^2]$ on $\mathbb{R}^{18}$. Their entries are moments of $\nu_{b_i}$ of degree at most six, computed with rigorous error bounds (Appendix E); each largest eigenvalue is bounded above by an $LDL^{\top}$ factorisation of $tI$ minus the computed form with certified positive pivots, plus the norm of its error matrix by Weyl's inequality [35, 40].

The matrix $C$ is chosen in each box in floating point. At the mean of the corner moments and at $b = \beta$, Lemma 7.4 for $u = q_h$ is a quadratic problem in $C$: for $\theta > 0$ we minimise the trace of $\nu|\nabla q|^2 + \theta \operatorname{Var}(X)/\gamma$ over the 18 coordinate directions $h$, a least-squares problem of size 189, keep the $\theta$ on a geometric grid of 48 values from 0.05 to 80 that gives the smallest bound, and round $C$ to multiples of $2^{-30}$. Any choice gives a valid bound.

A box is discarded when it contains no point with $a_1 \ge a_2 \ge |z_3|$, or when a linear functional $\ell(b) = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(c^* b)$ satisfies $\min_Q \ell > r \max_T \ell$, which separates it from $r \operatorname{conv} T$ and hence, by Lemma 7.5(iii), from $\mathcal{R}_r$.

**Proposition 7.8.** $2r\Lambda(r) \le 0.999887$ *at* $r = \frac{3}{2}$.

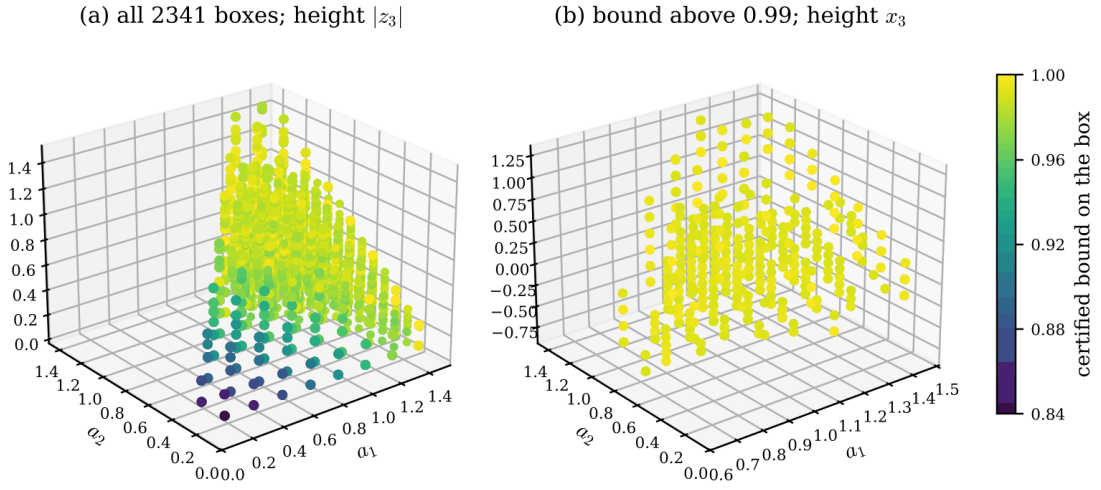



FIGURE 4. The 2341 certified boxes at $r = \frac{3}{2}$, plotted at their centres in the coordinates $(a_1, a_2)$ of the staple sum $\operatorname{diag}(a_1, a_2, x_3 + iy_3)$, coloured by the certified bound on $2r \sup_h L_h$ over the box; the larger points are the boxes of side $r/8$. (a) All boxes, with height $|x_3 + iy_3|$. (b) The 419 boxes with bound above 0.99, with height $x_3$; the largest bounds sit in the interior of $\mathcal{R}_r$, not at its extreme points.

*Proof.* The box $[0, r]^2 \times [-r, r] \times [0, r]$ is cut into 8192 boxes of side $r/8$. Of these, 841 survive the two tests, and 581 satisfy $2rB_Q < 1$ for the right side $B_Q$ of (7.6), with $\gamma(r) = \frac{187}{128}$. Each of the other 260 is cut into sixteen boxes of side $r/16$; 1760 of these survive the tests, and all satisfy $2rB_Q < 1$. The 2341 certified boxes cover $\mathcal{R}_r$. The largest bound is 0.999887, on the box $[1.3125, 1.5] \times [0.9375, 1.125] \times [0.5625, 0.75] \times [0, 0.1875]$, and the median is 0.983. Figure 4 shows the cover, and Appendix E the error analysis. □

The same cover at a larger $r$ bounds $\Lambda(r)$ where $2r\Lambda(r)$ is no longer below one; the plaquette blocks of Section 8 use that bound.

**Proposition 7.9.** *$2r\Lambda(r) \le 1.029967$ at $r = \frac{38}{25}$.*

*Proof.* As in the proof of Proposition 7.8, with $\gamma(r) = \frac{4643}{3200}$ and the threshold $2rB_Q < 1.03$: of the 8192 boxes of side $r/8$, 784 survive the two tests and 690 satisfy the threshold; each of the other 94 is cut into sixteen boxes of side $r/16$, of which 373 survive the tests, and all satisfy it. The 1063 certified boxes cover $\mathcal{R}_r$, and the largest bound is 1.029967. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.6.* Proposition 7.8 gives

$$\Lambda\left(\tfrac{3}{2}\right) \le \frac{0.999887}{3} < 0.333296.$$

For $\beta_W \le \frac{3}{4}$ we have $2\beta_W \le \frac{3}{2}$, and (7.1) with the monotonicity of $\Lambda$ gives

$$\alpha \le 4\beta_W \Lambda\left(\tfrac{3}{2}\right) < 1.333183\, \beta_W \le \tfrac{3}{4} \cdot 1.333183 < 1.$$

Proposition 3.2 applies with the Hilbert–Schmidt metric. □

## 8. SU(3) with plaquette blocks

In this section $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$, $\beta \geq 0$, $\beta_W = 9\beta$, $N\beta = \beta_W/3$, and the notation is that of Section 7: $d$ is the Hilbert–Schmidt distance, $K = \operatorname{conv}\mathrm{SU}(3)$, $\nu_c(dU) \propto e^{\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Uc)}dU$, $\varphi_h(U) = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Uh)$ and $\Lambda(r)$ is the modulus of (7.1). Put $Z(c) = \int e^{\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Uc)}dU$ and $g = \log Z$ on $\mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$, viewed as $\mathbb{R}^{18}$ with the inner product $\langle x, y\rangle = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(xy^*)$. The gradient of $g$ at $c$ is the conjugate mean $m(c)^*$, $m(c) = \nu_c(U) \in K$, and $\operatorname{Hess} g(c)(h,h) = \mathrm{Var}_{\nu_c}(\varphi_h)$. Since $Z(VcW) = Z(c)$ for $V, W \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$, the same holds for $g$.

The blocks are those of Lemma 5.1, which concerns the line field only and holds for every group. For a block plaquette with active links $e_1, e_2, e_3$, $\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,Q_p = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(y_1y_2y_3)$ with $y_i = Q_{e_i}$ or $Q_{e_i}^{-1}$, and the conditional law of the block is

$$\mu_b(dy) \propto \exp\Big(\sum_i \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(y_i b_i) + N\beta\,\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(y_1y_2y_3)\Big)dy, \tag{8.1}$$

where $b_i$ is $N\beta$ times the sum of the five staples of $y_i$ outside the block plaquette, so $b_i \in 5N\beta K$ and $\|b_i\|_{\mathrm{op}} \leq 5N\beta$. On $\mathrm{SU}(3)^3$ we use $d(y,y') = \sum_i \|y_i - y_i'\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$.

8.1. **The sensitivity of one block.** Let $r = 2\beta_W = 6N\beta$. Let $\lambda_*$ and $\tau$ be a lower and an upper bound for the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{Hess} g$ on $rK$, $M$ an upper bound on $rK$ for $|D^3 g(c)(u,v,v)|$ over unit vectors $u, v$, and $\gamma = \gamma(r)$ the gap of Lemma 7.3. Put

$$\begin{aligned} w &= \tfrac{3}{2}(N\beta)^2(\tau - \lambda_*), \qquad s = \Lambda(r) + (e^w - 1)e^w\sqrt{\tau/\gamma}, \\ C &= 5(N\beta)^2\Big(\tau s + \frac{\sqrt{3}\,N\beta\,M\,e^w}{\gamma}\Big), \\ K_3 &= \frac{(1 + N\beta\Lambda(r))\,s}{1 - C}, \qquad \alpha_3 = 10N\beta K_3, \end{aligned} \tag{8.2}$$

assuming $C < 1$.

**Lemma 8.1.** *Let $a, c_0 \in 5N\beta K$ and*

$$\kappa(dx) \propto \exp\big(\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(xa) + g(c_0 + N\beta x)\big)dx \quad \text{on } \mathrm{SU}(3).$$

*For every 1-Lipschitz $f$ and every $h \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$:*

(i) $\mathrm{Cov}_\kappa(f, \varphi_h) \leq s\|h\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$;

(ii) *if $c_0$ moves in the direction $k$ inside $5N\beta K$, then*

$$\big|\tfrac{d}{dt}\kappa(f)\big| \leq N\beta(\tau s + \sqrt{3}N\beta M e^w/\gamma)\|k\|_{\mathrm{HS}}.$$

*Proof.* (i) The segment from $c_0$ to $c_0 + N\beta x$ lies in $6N\beta K = rK$, and Taylor's formula gives

$$g(c_0 + N\beta x) = g(c_0) + N\beta\,\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(x\,m(c_0)) + R(x)$$

with $R(x) = \frac{1}{2}(N\beta)^2 \operatorname{Hess} g(\xi)(x,x)$. Since $\|x\|_{\mathrm{HS}}^2 = 3$, $R \in [\frac{3}{2}(N\beta)^2\lambda_*, \frac{3}{2}(N\beta)^2\tau]$ and $\operatorname{osc} R \leq w$. Hence $\kappa$ is the tilt $e^R\nu/\nu(e^R)$ of $\nu = \nu_{c'}$ with $c' = a + N\beta m(c_0) \in rK$. By definition of $\Lambda$, $\mathrm{Cov}_\nu(f, \varphi_h) \leq \Lambda(r)\|h\|$. The function $f$ is 1-Lipschitz for the geodesic distance, which dominates $d$, so $\mathrm{sd}_\nu f \leq \gamma^{-1/2}$ by Lemma 7.3, and $\mathrm{sd}_\nu \varphi_h \leq \sqrt{\tau}\|h\|$. Lemma 5.2 gives (i).

(ii) The derivative is $\mathrm{Cov}_\kappa(f, \langle \nabla g(c_0 + N\beta x), k\rangle)$. Write $\nabla g(c_0 + N\beta u) = \nabla g(c_0) + N\beta \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)u + N(u)$. The linear term is $\varphi_h$ with $\|h\| \leq N\beta\tau\|k\|$ and contributes at most $N\beta\tau s\|k\|$ by (i). On the segment from $c_0$ the Hessian moves by at most $N\beta M\|u\| \leq \sqrt{3}N\beta M$, so $x \mapsto \langle N(x), k\rangle$ is $\sqrt{3}(N\beta)^2 M\|k\|$-Lipschitz for $d$. The law $\kappa$ is a tilt of $\nu$ by a function of oscillation at most $w$, so its spectral gap is at least $e^{-w}\gamma$ by the Holley–Stroock lemma [36], and the covariance of two Lipschitz functions under $\kappa$ is at most $e^w/\gamma$ times the product of their constants. □

**Lemma 8.2.** *Let $C < 1$. If $b, b'$ have all fields in $5N\beta K$ and differ only in $b_i$, then $W_1(\mu_b, \mu_{b'}) \leq K_3\|b_i - b_i'\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$ for the metric $d$.*

*Proof.* By the cyclic symmetry of $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(y_1y_2y_3)$ we may take $i=1$. Given $y_1,y_3$, the law of $y_2$ is $\nu_c$ with $c=b_2+N\beta y_3y_1\in rK$. Changing $y_1$ by $\eta$ in $d$ moves $c$ by $N\beta\eta$ and $\nu_c$ by at most $N\beta\Lambda(r)\eta$ in $W_1$, as in (7.1); so $F(y_1,y_3)=\mathbb{E}[f\mid y_1,y_3]$ is $(1+N\beta\Lambda(r))$-Lipschitz in each variable. The law of $(y_1,y_3)$ is proportional to $e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(y_1b_1)+\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(y_3b_3)}Z(b_2+N\beta y_3y_1)$, and $Z(b_2+N\beta y_3y_1)=Z(y_3^{-1}b_2+N\beta y_1)=Z(b_2y_1^{-1}+N\beta y_3)$, so its two conditional laws have the form of Lemma 8.1, with $c_0=y_3^{-1}b_2$ and $c_0=b_2y_1^{-1}$. Moving $y_3$ to $y_3'$ moves $y_3^{-1}b_2$ along a segment in $5N\beta K$ of length at most $\|b_2\|_{\mathrm{op}}\|y_3-y_3'\|\le 5N\beta\|y_3-y_3'\|$. The coupling argument of Lemma 5.4 now gives $d_1\le s\varepsilon+Cd_3$, $d_3\le Cd_1$ and $|\mu_b(f)-\mu_{b'}(f)|\le(1+N\beta\Lambda(r))(d_1+d_3)\le K_3\varepsilon$. □

8.2. **The constants and the proof of Theorem 1.7.**

**Lemma 8.3.** *At $r=\frac32$ every eigenvalue of* $\operatorname{Hess} g$ *on $rK$ lies in* $[0.056015,0.247316]$*, and* $|D^3g(c)(u,v,v)|\le 0.182126$ *for $c\in rK$ and unit vectors $u,v$. At $r=\frac{38}{25}$ the same holds with* $[0.054978,0.248280]$ *and* $0.183546$*.*

*Proof.* For $V,W\in\mathrm{SU}(3)$, $g(VcW)=g(c)$ and $x\mapsto VxW$ is an isometry, so the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{Hess} g$ and the norm of $D^3g$ are constant on the orbits, and by Lemma 7.5 it suffices to bound them on $\mathcal{R}_r$. The derivatives of $g$ are the cumulants of $\varphi$ under $\nu_c$. Cut the box $[0,r]^2\times[-r,r]\times[0,r]$ into boxes of side $r/8$ and keep the 841 (784 at $r=\frac{38}{25}$) that survive the two tests of Section 7.7. On each box $Q$ we compute, with rigorous error bounds, the moments of $\varphi$ of degree at most three at the sixteen corners $b_i$ and at the centre $b_0$, and put $k=m(b_0)$, the mean of $\varphi$ at the centre.

*Upper bound.* For $b\in Q$ and every $h$, $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_b}(\varphi_h)\le\nu_b[(\varphi_h-\langle k,h\rangle)^2]\le e^{\varsigma/8}\max_i\nu_{b_i}[(\varphi_h-\langle k,h\rangle)^2]$ by Lemma 7.7(ii).

*Lower bound.* Integrating the right inequality of (7.5) against $f\ge0$ and dividing by $Z(b)\le\sum_i\omega_iZ(b_i)$, the left one, gives $\nu_b(f)\ge e^{-\varsigma/8}\min_i\nu_{b_i}(f)$. With $f=(\varphi_h-\nu_b\varphi_h)^2$ this gives $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_b}(\varphi_h)\ge e^{-\varsigma/8}\min_i\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_{b_i}}(\varphi_h)$.

*Third cumulant.* Put $\delta=m(b)-k$. The mean value theorem and the upper bound give $\|\delta\|\le\tau\rho+e$, with $\rho$ the largest distance from $b_0$ in $Q$ and $e$ the error of the computed mean. Expanding the central moment about $k$,

$$D^3g(b)(u,v,v)=T_b(u,v,v)-\delta_u\operatorname{Var}(\varphi_v)\\-2\delta_v\operatorname{Cov}(\varphi_u,\varphi_v)-\delta_u\delta_v^2,$$

with $T_b=\nu_b[(\varphi-k)^{\otimes3}]$, $\delta_u=\langle\delta,u\rangle$ and the moments under $\nu_b$. For a function $G$ of either sign, writing $G=G^+-G^-$ and applying the two bounds above to $G^\pm$ gives $|\nu_b(G)|\le(\max_i|\nu_{b_i}(G)|+\varepsilon\max_i\nu_{b_i}|G|)/(1-\varepsilon)$ with $\varepsilon=1-e^{-\varsigma/8}$. For $G=(\varphi_u-k_u)(\varphi_v-k_v)^2$ we use $|\nu_{b_i}(G)|\le\|T_{b_i}\|$, the largest singular value of the $18\times324$ unfolding of $T_{b_i}$, and $\nu_{b_i}|G|\le2\sqrt3\,\nu_{b_i}[(\varphi_v-k_v)^2]$, since $\|U-k\|_{\mathrm{HS}}\le2\sqrt3$. The largest eigenvalues and singular values are bounded as in Section 7.7, and the maxima over these boxes are the numbers stated (Appendix C). □

*Proof of Theorem 1.7.* Let first $\beta_W\le\frac34$, so that $r=2\beta_W\le\frac32$. Every field met in Lemmas 8.1 and 8.2 lies in $\frac32K$, so the constants of Lemma 8.3 at $\frac32$, $\Lambda(\frac32)\le\frac{0.999887}{3}$ from Proposition 7.8 and $\gamma=\gamma(\frac32)=\frac{187}{128}$ apply; with these fixed constants every quantity in (8.2) is increasing in $\beta_W$. For $\frac34<\beta_W\le\frac{19}{25}$ the fields lie in $\frac{38}{25}K$, and the constants of Lemma 8.3 at $\frac{38}{25}$, $\Lambda(\frac{38}{25})\le\frac{1.029967}{3.04}$ from Proposition 7.9 and $\gamma(\frac{38}{25})=\frac{4643}{3200}$ apply in the same way. Changing an active link $j$ by $\eta$ changes one staple of each of its ten partners outside its block by a matrix of norm $\eta$, so the field $b_i$ of each such partner moves by $N\beta\eta$, and Lemma 8.2 gives $\sum_B C_{Bj}\le10N\beta K_3=\alpha_3(\beta_W)$. In ball arithmetic, at $\beta_W=\frac34$, $w\le0.017935$, $s\le0.34088$, $C\le0.043520$, $K_3\le0.38609$ and $\alpha_3\le0.96521$; at $\beta_W=0.72$, $\alpha_3\le0.91815$; at $\beta_W=0.76$, with the second set of constants, $w\le0.018609$, $s\le0.34673$, $C\le0.045770$, $K_3\le0.39454$ and $\alpha_3\le0.99950$. Proposition 5.6, whose proof does not use the group, applies with the Hilbert–Schmidt metric. □

*Remark* 8.4. Theorem 1.6 ends where $2r\Lambda(r)$ reaches one. The blocks remove the factor $\frac{12}{10}$ of the single-link sum and keep most of it after paying for the three links: at $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ the gap bound rises from $1.1 \cdot 10^{-4}$ to 0.0177, and the block bound is the better one for $\beta_W \geq 0.715$. Before the corrections for the three links their sum is $\frac{10}{12}$ of the single-link sum $2r\Lambda(r)$, so it can stay below one while $2r\Lambda(r)$ is slightly above one; Proposition 7.9 certifies $2r\Lambda(r) \leq 1.03$ at $r = 1.52$, which is enough at $\beta_W = 0.76$, with little room. Evaluated in floating point with the constants of a scan of $\mathcal{R}_r$, the block sum stays below one up to $\beta_W \approx 0.78$; that computation is not certified and is not used.

## 9. Where the methods stop

SU(2). Theorem 1.2 closes the single-link route in every forest gauge at $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$. Blocks of several links, where the influence of a boundary link on a whole block is bounded at once, in the spirit of the Dobrushin–Shlosman criterion [28], pass it: plaquette blocks reach $\beta_W = 0.345$ (Theorem 1.3), and the sharper floating-point bound of Remark 5.7 stops near 0.357. Larger blocks are the next step.

*Curvature.* Remark 6.8 locates the end of the curvature method in this gauge between $|\beta| = \frac{1}{29}$ and $\frac{1}{26.25}$.

SU(3). The route of Section 7 bounds the $H^{-1}(\nu_b)$ norm of $\varphi_h - \nu_b\varphi_h$, which is at least $L_h(b)$, and needs it uniformly on $rK$. Its Galerkin values (polynomials of degree two) at matrices of $rK$ give $2r$ times the norm equal to 0.79 at $r = 1.25$, 0.89 at $r = 1.4$, 0.97 at $r = 1.5$ and 1.009 at $r = 1.55$, so the route stops at or below $\beta_W \approx 0.77$ even with exact constants. With $u = s\varphi_h$, Lemma 7.4 stops earlier: in floating point its largest values on $\mathcal{R}_r$ lie on the face $\mathrm{diag}(r, \rho, \rho)$ with $\rho$ between $0.75r$ and $0.8r$, and $2r$ times the bound is 0.9458 at $r = 1.36$, 0.9767 at $r = 1.40$ and 1.0080 at $r = 1.44$, so this corrector ends near $\beta_W \approx 0.715$. With $u = q_h$ of degree two the largest values on the same face are 0.9305 at $r = 1.44$, 0.9729 at $r = 1.50$ and 1.0018 at $r = 1.54$ (Figure 5), close to the Galerkin values. Lemma 7.3 therefore costs little at these couplings, and most of the distance between the floating-point value at $r = 1.5$ and the certified 0.999887 of Proposition 7.8 is the interpolation over boxes. Between $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ and 0.77 there is room only for smaller boxes. The plaquette blocks of Theorem 1.7 use $\Lambda(2\beta_W)$ as well, with a little more room: they reach 0.76 with the certified cover of Proposition 7.9 and near 0.78 in floating point (Remark 8.4); past that one needs larger blocks, whose sensitivity does not go through the one-link modulus.

*Other groups.* For groups other than SU(2) and SU(3) only the curvature route is carried out here (Theorem 1.5), and it stops where the bound $\frac{29}{2}$ uses up the curvature of $G$, at $N|\beta| = \frac{2}{29}\kappa_G$. The Dobrushin route needs a bound for the Kantorovich modulus of the one-link measure of each group, which is not attempted here.

*The four open problems.* Our earlier paper [13] listed four problems between the strong-coupling results and the Clay problem [39]: (1) uniqueness and a gap at intermediate fixed coupling; (2) the crossover from strong coupling to Bałaban's weak-coupling regime; (3) the continuum limit with the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms; and (4) a gap in physical units. The present paper moves the boundary of (1): for SU(2) from $\beta_W = \frac{2}{9}$ to 0.345, for SU(3) from $\frac{9}{32}$ to 0.76, with a gap at $\frac{3}{4}$ of 0.0177 in lattice units, and for every compact simple group, the exceptional groups included, past the curvature ceiling of the ungauged measure, with an explicit gap. It does not close (1); the region between these values and the scaling region, near $\beta_W \approx 2.2$ for SU(2) and $\beta_W \approx 6$ for SU(3), is open, and with it problem (2). Problems (3) and (4) are not solved here. Every bound proved here is uniform in lattice units, so by [14] none of them can by itself produce a continuum mass gap; that requires control of the gap in physical units along the renormalisation group flow [4, 16].[11]

[11] Every one of these approaches needs an input at physical length scales. Renormalisation group approaches to the ultraviolet behaviour of gauge and gravitational theories, of which [4, 25] are the rigorous

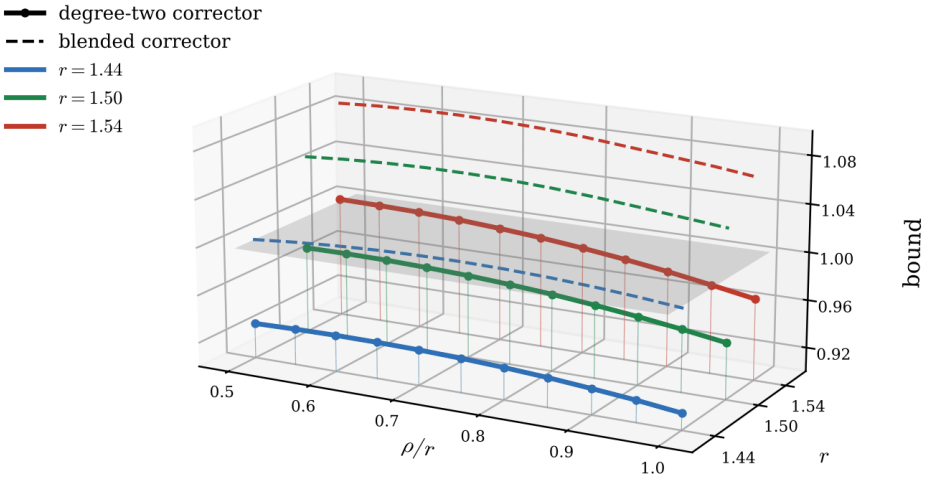



FIGURE 5. The floating-point value of $2r \sup_h$ of the bound of Lemma 7.4 on the face $b = \mathrm{diag}(r, \rho, \rho)$, as a function of $\rho/r$, for $r = 1.44$, 1.50 and 1.54: dashed with the corrector $u = s\varphi_h$ for the best $s$, solid with $u = q_h$ of degree two for the best $C$. The grey plane is the Dobrushin threshold one. The first corrector is above it already at $r = 1.44$; the second stays below it at $r = 1.50$, where Proposition 7.8 certifies the bound on all of $\mathcal{R}_r$, and crosses it by $r = 1.54$.

*The continuum problem.* Two general facts limit what can be imported into problems (3) and (4) above from constructions of continuum measures. Both concern a random distribution $F$ on $\mathbb{R}^d$, a Borel probability measure on the tempered distributions with finite moments, and the growth condition

$$\mathbb{E}\, e^{F(\chi)} \le e^{C(\|\chi\|_1 + \|\chi\|_2^2)} \qquad \text{for all real } \chi \in \mathcal{S}(\mathbb{R}^d), \tag{9.1}$$

which is the growth condition of the regularity axiom of Glimm and Jaffe at $p = 2$ [33, Sect. 6.1, (6.1.5)]. It is the hypothesis under which reflection positivity across coordinate and diagonal hyperplanes is shown in [62] to give rotation invariance of the Schwinger functions, a step proposed there for the continuum limit of lattice gauge theories.

**Proposition 9.1.** *Let $F$ satisfy (9.1), and suppose that its connected two-point function is, off the diagonal, a locally integrable function $S_2(x, y)$ with $S_2(x, y) \ge c|x-y|^{-2\Delta}\big(\log \frac{1}{|x-y|}\big)^{-k}$ for $0 < |x - y| \le r_0$, where $c > 0$, $k \ge 0$ and $2\Delta > d$. Then $F$ does not exist: no random distribution has both properties.*

*Proof.* Applying (9.1) to $\chi$ and $-\chi$ and using $\cosh x \ge 1 + \frac{x^2}{2}$ gives $\mathbb{E}F(\chi)^2 \le 2(e^{C(\|\chi\|_1 + \|\chi\|_2^2)} - 1)$. Fix nonnegative $\varphi, \psi \in C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^d)$, not zero, with supports in a ball of radius $\frac{R}{2}$ and at distance $\delta > 0$ from each other, and put $\varphi_\varepsilon(x) = \varepsilon^{-d/2}\varphi(x/\varepsilon)$, and likewise $\psi_\varepsilon$. Then $\|\varphi_\varepsilon\|_2 = \|\varphi\|_2$ and $\|\varphi_\varepsilon\|_1 = \varepsilon^{d/2}\|\varphi\|_1 \le \|\varphi\|_1$ for $\varepsilon \le 1$, so the covariance of $F(\varphi_\varepsilon)$ and $F(\psi_\varepsilon)$ is bounded uniformly in $\varepsilon$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. On the other hand the supports of $\varphi_\varepsilon$ and $\psi_\varepsilon$ are disjoint, and for $u, v$ in the supports $\varepsilon\delta \le |\varepsilon u - \varepsilon v| \le \varepsilon R$. For

ones for Yang–Mills theory, have also been proposed for the effective dimension of spacetime [55] and for completions of quantum gravity [10, 15]; they do not bear on the infrared estimates needed here.

$\varepsilon R \le r_0$ and $\varepsilon R < 1$ the lower bound for $S_2$ therefore gives

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{Cov}(F(\varphi_\varepsilon), F(\psi_\varepsilon)) &= \varepsilon^d \iint \varphi(u)\psi(v) S_2(\varepsilon u, \varepsilon v)\, du\, dv \\ &\ge c\, R^{-2\Delta} \varepsilon^{d-2\Delta} \Big(\log \frac{1}{\varepsilon\delta}\Big)^{-k} \|\varphi\|_1 \|\psi\|_1,\end{aligned}$$

which tends to infinity as $\varepsilon \to 0$. □

The action density $\operatorname{Tr} F_{\mu\nu} F_{\mu\nu}$ has dimension $\Delta = 4$ in four dimensions. A two-sided short-distance law of the form $|x-y|^{-8}$ times the fourth power of the running coupling, which is what asymptotic freedom predicts and what the conditional construction of [63] states for the smeared action density, has $2\Delta = 8 > 4$ and $k = 2$; so that field cannot satisfy (9.1), and rotation invariance for it has to come from another source, as in [63], where it is reduced to a separate infrared hypothesis. In three dimensions the free part of the action density already has $2\Delta = 6 > 3$. Condition (9.1) suits fields of dimension at most $\frac{d}{2}$, such as the field strength of the free Maxwell field, whose covariance is bounded in momentum space.

Positivity, symmetry and regularity do not produce a gap by themselves.

**Proposition 9.2.** *On $\mathbb{R}^4$ let $F$ be the centred Gaussian random distribution with covariance*

$$\widehat{C}(p) = \int_0^1 \frac{m^2}{|p|^2 + m^2}\, dm.$$

*Then $F$ is invariant under all Euclidean motions, reflection positive, satisfies (9.1) with $C = \frac{1}{2}$, and its Osterwalder–Schrader Hamiltonian has no gap above the vacuum.*

*Proof.* Since $0 \le \widehat{C} \le 1$, $\mathbb{E} e^{F(\chi)} = e^{\frac{1}{2}\langle \chi, C\chi\rangle} \le e^{\frac{1}{2}\|\chi\|_2^2}$, with the unitary Fourier transform. Invariance is clear. The covariance is the integral over $m \in (0,1)$, with the weight $m^2 dm$, of the covariances of free fields of mass $m$, each of which is reflection positive [33, Sect. 6.2]; a positive combination of reflection positive covariances is reflection positive, and so is the Gaussian measure with such a covariance [33, Sect. 6.2]. For $\chi(t,\mathbf{x}) = h(t)g(\mathbf{x})$ with $h \ge 0$ supported in $t > 0$, not zero, and $\hat{g}(0) \ne 0$, the vector $v = F(\chi)$ is orthogonal to the vacuum, and after the Fourier transform in $\mathbf{x}$,

$$\begin{aligned}\langle v, e^{-sH} v\rangle = \int_0^1 m^2\, dm \int \frac{|\hat{g}(\mathbf{k})|^2}{2\omega} e^{-\omega s} \\ \times \Big(\int_0^\infty h(t) e^{-\omega t} dt\Big)^2 d\mathbf{k},\end{aligned}$$

with $\omega = \sqrt{|\mathbf{k}|^2 + m^2}$ and constants absorbed in $\hat{g}$. If $H$ had a gap $m_0 > 0$, the left side would be at most $e^{-m_0 s}\|v\|^2$. For $0 < \eta < m_0$ the part of the integral with $m, |\mathbf{k}| \le \eta/2$ is at least $c_\eta e^{-\eta s}$ with $c_\eta > 0$, a contradiction as $s \to \infty$. □

The Gaussian field of Proposition 9.2 is not a gauge theory; it shows only that an infrared estimate, such as a bound $\langle v_a, T_a^{\lfloor t/a \rfloor} v_a\rangle \le C_v e^{-m_* t}$ uniform in the spacing $a$ along the continuum tuning, has to be proved in addition to the axioms. The lattice bounds of this paper are of this form only with $m_*$ proportional to $1/a$, and by [14] such bounds give trivial limits. The routes we know to a continuum gap therefore all stop at the same two estimates: the construction of the infinite-volume continuum measure past Bałaban's small-field analysis [4, 6], which the conditional construction of [63] assumes clause by clause and which yields there a non-negative Hamiltonian without any statement on its spectrum, and a decay estimate in physical units at large scales. The finite-size criterion described in [63, Sect. 9.4] reduces a gap to a threshold condition on one box, uniformly in the cutoff; as stated there, the condition fails in every small box and would have to be checked at large scales, which the construction does not reach.

## 10. The continuum step at one physical scale

The bounds of the preceding sections hold at fixed coupling and give a gap that is at least a fixed number in lattice units, and [14] shows that no such bound can produce a continuum gap. This section replaces the single-link condition of Proposition 3.2 by a condition on one cube of $n^4$ sites, averaged over its translates in the manner of Dobrushin and Shlosman [28], and proves that the condition gives a gap of order $1/n$ in lattice units. If it holds with $n$ proportional to $1/a$, that is, in a cube of fixed physical size, the gap survives in physical units and passes to every continuum limit (Theorem 10.4). The two statements that remain unproved are named at the end: the cube estimate and the existence of the limit.

10.1. **Averaged cubes.** For a finite set $V \subset A$ let $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q)$ be the probability measure on $G^V$ with density proportional to $\exp\bigl(N\beta \sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F\bigr)$ with respect to Haar measure, the links outside $V$ being those of $Q$. Its conditional law of $Q_e$, $e \in V$, given the other links of $V$ is $\gamma_e^F$. Write $d_V(Q_V, Q'_V) = \sum_{i \in V} \delta(Q_i, Q'_i)$ and, for $j \in A \setminus V$,

$$C_{V,j} = \sup \frac{W_1^{d_V}\bigl(\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q), \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q')\bigr)}{\delta(Q_j, Q'_j)},$$

the supremum over pairs that differ only at $j$; $W_1^{d_V}$ is the Kantorovich distance for $d_V$. The coefficient vanishes unless $j$ shares a plaquette with a link of $V$.

Let $n \geq 2$ be even and let $V$ be the set of active links $(x, \mu)$ with $x \in [0, n)^4$. The direction field has period two, so the translations by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ preserve $F$, $A$ and $\gamma^F$, and the translates $V_x = V + x$, $x \in 2\mathbb{Z}^4$, satisfy $C_{V_x, j+x} = C_{V,j}$. Every active link lies in exactly $N_n = (n/2)^4$ of them. A *class* is an orbit of $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ on $A$, that is, a residue of the base point modulo two together with a direction; there are at most 64 classes. For a class $c$ put

$$K_c = \sum_{j \in c \setminus V} C_{V,j}.$$

**Definition 10.1.** For $0 < \alpha < 1$, the condition $D(n, \alpha)$ at the coupling $\beta$ is $K_c \leq \alpha N_n$ for every class $c$.

Since $\sum_{x \in 2\mathbb{Z}^4,\, j \notin V_x} C_{V_x, j} = \sum_x C_{V, j-x}[j - x \notin V] = K_{c(j)}$ for the class $c(j)$ of $j$, the condition says that the total influence of a link on the translates that do not contain it is at most the fraction $\alpha$ of the number of translates that do. Figure 6 shows the cubes.

For $n = 2$ it is a bound on blocks of 48 links. Distances between links are those of their midpoints; a link of $V$ and a link sharing a plaquette with $V$ are at distance at most $\rho_n = 2n$, and $c_n$ denotes the number of active links within distance $\rho_n$ of a given one.

**Theorem 10.2.** *Let $\beta \geq 0$ and suppose that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds. Then statements* (i)–(iv) *of Proposition 3.2 hold,* (v) *holds for every $\lambda < \log(1/\alpha)/\rho_n$, and the transfer matrix of $\omega$ has spectral gap at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n)$.*

*Proof.* The proof of Proposition 3.2 uses the coefficients $C_{ee'}$ only through Lemma B.1 and Corollary B.2. Lemma B.4 of Appendix B gives the same conclusions under $D(n, \alpha)$, for every $\lambda > 0$ with $\alpha e^{\lambda \rho_n} < 1$, with the constant $\theta D/(1-\theta)$ replaced by $D(1 + c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n})/(1-\theta)$ and $\theta = \alpha e^{\lambda \rho_n}$. The measures used there are invariant under every $\gamma_{V_x}$ with $V_x$ disjoint from the exceptional set: a Gibbs measure of $\gamma^F$ and its conditional measures given the links of a finite set by Lemma B.4(a), and the extended finite-volume measure of part (ii) because every plaquette that meets such a $V_x$ lies in $P(\Lambda)$. Part (vi) then follows from Proposition F.1 as before, with every $\lambda < \log(1/\alpha)/(2n)$. □

10.2. **The continuum limit.** Let $a_k = 2^{-k} a_0$ and let $\beta_k \geq 0$ be couplings, typically with $\beta_k \to \infty$. Suppose that the lattice states $\omega_k$ at $\beta_k$ exist as in Proposition 3.2, with transfer matrices $\mathbb{T}_k$ on the reconstructed spaces $\mathcal{H}_k$ and vacua $\Omega_k$ (Appendix F). Let $\mathcal{T}$ be a complex vector space of test functions on $\mathbb{R}^4$ supported in $\{t > 0\}$ and, for each $k$, let $f \mapsto O_k(f)$ be

(a) averaged cubes, $n = 4$ (b) one physical scale

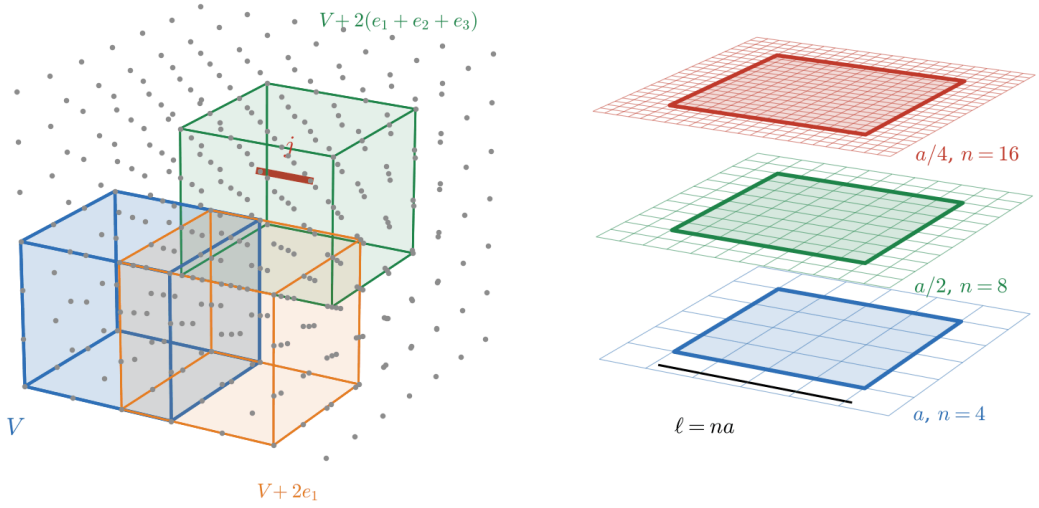



FIGURE 6. (a) The cube $V$ of side $n = 4$ and two of its translates by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$, drawn in three of the four dimensions. A link $j$ outside $V$ enters $K_c$ through every translate whose boundary it touches, and $D(n, \alpha)$ compares that total with the $N_n = (n/2)^4$ translates that contain $j$. (b) The cube of Theorem 10.4: its physical side $\ell = na$ is held fixed while the spacing is halved, so $n$ doubles at each step and the lattice gap $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n)$ is of order $a/\ell$.

a linear map from $\mathcal{T}$ to gauge-invariant local observables supported in positive lattice times; the example to keep in mind is $O_k(f) = Z_k \sum_x a_k^4 f(a_k x)\Phi(x)$ for a local gauge-invariant field $\Phi$, a renormalisation constant $Z_k$ and $\Phi(x)$ the translate of $\Phi$ to $x$. Write $\vartheta$ for the time reflection and $\tau_t$ for the time translation by $t$ lattice steps.

**Definition 10.3.** A *continuum limit* of $(\omega_k, O_k)$ is a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$ with a unit vector $\Omega$, a self-adjoint operator $H \geq 0$ with $H\Omega = 0$, and a linear map $f \mapsto \psi(f)$ from $\mathcal{T}$ to $\mathcal{H}$ with dense range, such that for all $f, g \in \mathcal{T}$ and all dyadic $\tau \geq 0$,

$$\langle \psi(f), e^{-\tau H} \psi(g) \rangle = \lim_{k \to \infty} \omega_k\big(\vartheta(\overline{O_k(f)})\, \tau_{\tau/a_k} O_k(g)\big),$$
$$\langle \Omega, \psi(f) \rangle = \lim_{k \to \infty} \omega_k(O_k(f)),$$

the limits taken over the $k$ for which $\tau/a_k$ is an integer. It is *nontrivial* if $\mathcal{H} \neq \mathbb{C}\Omega$.

The Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction [52, 53] produces such a limit from convergent renormalised Schwinger functions that satisfy the axioms; the definition records only what the next theorem uses.

**Theorem 10.4.** *Suppose that there are $\alpha < 1$, $\ell > 0$ and even $n_k$ with $n_k a_k \leq \ell$ such that $D(n_k, \alpha)$ holds at $\beta_k$ for every $k$. Then every continuum limit of $(\omega_k, O_k)$ satisfies*

$$\sigma(H) \subset \{0\} \cup [m_*, \infty), \qquad m_* = \frac{\log(1/\alpha)}{2\ell},$$

*and $0$ is a simple eigenvalue. If the limit is nontrivial, $\sigma(H) \cap [m_*, \infty) \neq \emptyset$, so $H$ has a mass gap of at least $m_*$.*

*Proof.* By Theorem 10.2 the state $\omega_k$ exists and $\mathbb{T}_k$ has gap at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)$ on the complement of $\Omega_k$. Let $f \in \mathcal{T}$, put $O = O_k(f)$ and $\varphi_k = \Psi_O - \omega_k(O)\Omega_k$. In the reconstruction of Appendix F, $\langle \Psi_F, \mathbb{T}_k^t \Psi_H \rangle = \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t H)$, so $\langle \Omega_k, \Psi_O \rangle = \omega_k(O)$, and

$\mathbb{T}_k\Omega_k = \Omega_k$; hence, for integers $t \geq 0$,

$$\begin{aligned}\langle \varphi_k, \mathbb{T}_k^t \varphi_k\rangle &= \omega_k\big(\vartheta(\bar{O})\,\tau_t O\big) - |\omega_k(O)|^2 \\ &\leq e^{-t\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)}\,\|\varphi_k\|^2.\end{aligned}$$

Take $\tau \geq 0$ dyadic and $k$ large, so that $t = \tau/a_k$ is an integer; then $t/(2n_k) = \tau/(2n_k a_k) \geq \tau/(2\ell)$, and the right side is at most $e^{-m_*\tau}\|\varphi_k\|^2$. Both sides converge by Definition 10.3. With $\varphi = \psi(f) - \langle\Omega, \psi(f)\rangle\Omega$ and $e^{-\tau H}\Omega = \Omega$ the limit reads

$$\langle \varphi, e^{-\tau H}\varphi\rangle \leq e^{-m_*\tau}\|\varphi\|^2.$$

The maps $f \mapsto O_k(f)$ and $f \mapsto \psi(f)$ are linear, so the vectors $\varphi$ form a linear subspace, and it is dense in $\Omega^\perp$ because the range of $\psi$ is dense. The inequality extends to $\Omega^\perp$ by continuity, and from dyadic $\tau$ to all $\tau \geq 0$ by the strong continuity of $e^{-\tau H}$. For $\varphi \in \Omega^\perp$ with spectral measure $\mu_\varphi$ of $H$ this says $\int e^{-\tau E} d\mu_\varphi(E) \leq e^{-m_*\tau}\mu_\varphi([0,\infty))$ for all $\tau \geq 0$; if $\mu_\varphi([0, m_* - \eta]) > 0$ for some $\eta > 0$, the left side is at least $\mu_\varphi([0, m_* - \eta])e^{-(m_*-\eta)\tau}$, which exceeds the right side for large $\tau$. So $\mu_\varphi$ lives on $[m_*, \infty)$ for every $\varphi \in \Omega^\perp$, which gives both claims about 0, and the spectrum on $\Omega^\perp \neq \{0\}$ lies in $[m_*, \infty)$ and is not empty. □

The theorem bypasses the obstruction of [14]: under the hypothesis the lattice gap is at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)$, of order $a_k/\ell$ in lattice units, which tends to zero, and only its value in physical units is bounded below. In the language of [14] the hypothesis implies the gap part (R2) of Hypothesis R, with $m = m_*$, and the conclusion holds for every continuum limit without a separate assumption on the gap.

10.3. **Smoothed observables.** The observables $O_k(f)$ of Definition 10.3 need not be local. The renormalised fields that one expects to converge are smoothed by the gradient flow of the Wilson action [45]; at positive flow time their correlation functions are finite to all orders of perturbation theory once the coupling is renormalised [46]. Flow in all four directions mixes the two sides of the reflection plane, but the spatial flow of [56, Sec. II.B] does not: it flows the links of each time slice under the Wilson action of that slice and leaves the temporal links alone.

Fix a bi-invariant Riemannian metric on $G$. For a configuration $U$ of all links of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ (for the states of this paper, the links of $F$ equal to 1), let $\Phi_s(U)$, $s \in \mathbb{R}$, solve

$$\frac{d}{ds}U_e = -\nabla_e \sum_{p \ni e,\ p \text{ spatial}} (N - \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} U_p)$$

for every spatial link $e$, the sum running over the four plaquettes of the time slice of $e$ that contain it, with the temporal links held fixed and $\nabla_e$ the gradient in the variable $U_e$.

**Proposition 10.5.** (i) *$\Phi_s$ is defined on every configuration of the infinite lattice, $\Phi_s \circ \Phi_{s'} = \Phi_{s+s'}$, and $\Phi_s$ commutes with gauge transformations, with spatial and temporal translations and with the reflections in time. The link $\Phi_s(U)_e$ depends only on the spatial links of the time slice of $e$, and there are constants $\kappa, c$ depending only on $G$ such that, if $\Phi_s^R$ denotes the flow of the links of that slice within distance $R$ of $e$ with all other links held fixed,*

$$\delta\big(\Phi_s(U)_e, \Phi_s^R(U)_e\big) \leq D\, e^{\kappa|s|}\,\frac{(c|s|)^{R+1}}{(R+1)!}$$

*for every configuration $U$.*

(ii) *Let $\omega$ be a state as in Appendix F and $O$ a bounded gauge-invariant function of finitely many links at times in $[t_0, t_1]$, continuous in them. Then $O \circ \Phi_s$ is a bounded gauge-invariant function of the links at times in $[t_0, t_1]$ and a uniform limit of gauge-invariant local functions at those times.*

(iii) *Theorem 10.4 holds with $O_k(f)$ replaced by $O_k(f) \circ \Phi_{s_k}$ for any $s_k \in \mathbb{R}$, in particular for $s_k = \tau/a_k^2$ at a fixed flow time $\tau$ in physical units.*

(iv) *The image measure* $(\Phi_s)_*\omega$ *is reflection positive, and its transfer matrix is unitarily equivalent to that of* $\omega$*, the unitary fixing the vacuum.*

*Proof.* (i) Embed $G$ in a matrix algebra. The right side of the equation is a smooth function of the links of the four plaquettes containing $e$, tangent to $G$ at $U_e$, so on the Banach space of bounded assignments of matrices to the spatial links it is a vector field that is bounded and Lipschitz on a neighbourhood of the configurations with values in $G$, with a Lipschitz constant that does not depend on the volume because every link meets finitely many others. The Picard–Lindelöf theorem gives a unique local solution; it stays on $G$ because the field is tangent there, and since the field is bounded on $G$ the solution exists for all $s$; uniqueness gives the group law. The action of a time slice and the metric are invariant under gauge transformations, translations and the reflections, so the flow commutes with them by uniqueness. Since the equation of a spatial link involves only links of its own slice, so does the solution. For the comparison, let $d_{e'}(s)$ be the distance between the two flows at a link $e'$ of the slice. Smoothness on the compact group gives constants $\kappa_0, c_1$ with $d_{e'}(s) \le \int_0^{|s|} (\kappa_0 d_{e'} + c_1 \sum_{e''\sim e'} d_{e''})$ for $e'$ within distance $R$ of $e$, where $e'' \sim e'$ means that the two links share a spatial plaquette (twelve neighbours), while $d_{e'} \le D$ beyond. Iterating the integral form of this inequality, a term that reaches the links beyond distance $R$ needs at least $R+1$ steps of $\sim$, and $\sum_{k>R} x^k/k! \le e^x x^{R+1}/(R+1)!$; this gives the bound with $c = 12c_1$ and $\kappa = \kappa_0 + c$.

(ii) The truncated flow $\Phi_s^R$ commutes with gauge transformations for the same reason as $\Phi_s$, so $O \circ \Phi_s^R$ is a gauge-invariant function of finitely many links at times in $[t_0, t_1]$. By (i) and the uniform continuity of $O$, it converges to $O \circ \Phi_s$ uniformly as $R \to \infty$.

(iii) The proof of Theorem 10.4 uses $O_k(f)$ only through the vectors $\Psi_{O_k(f)}$ and the identity $\langle \Psi_F, \mathbb{T}^t \Psi_H \rangle = \omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t H)$. By (ii) and the footnote in Appendix F, both extend to uniform limits of local functions at positive times, and $f \mapsto O_k(f) \circ \Phi_{s_k}$ is linear.

(iv) By (i), $\Phi_s$ and $\Phi_{-s}$ preserve the functions of the links at positive times and commute with $\vartheta$ and $\tau_t$. Hence $(\Phi_s)_*\omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t H) = \omega(\vartheta(\overline{F \circ \Phi_s})\,\tau_t(H \circ \Phi_s))$, which for $t = 0$ and $H = F$ is nonnegative, and $F \mapsto F \circ \Phi_s$ induces an isometry between the reconstructed spaces that intertwines the transfer matrices and fixes the vacuum; $\Phi_{-s}$ gives its inverse. □

Part (iv) says that smoothing changes the variables and not the theory: it neither creates nor removes a gap. Its use is in the choice of the observables. With $O_k(f)$ the spatially flowed fields at a fixed physical flow time, for instance $Z_k \sum_x a_k^4 f(a_k x)(\mathcal{E}_\tau(x) - \omega_k(\mathcal{E}_\tau(x)))$ with $\mathcal{E}_\tau(x)$ the flowed action density of the slice, statement (E) asks for the convergence of correlation functions that are known to be finite in perturbation theory [46], and Theorem 10.4 applies to them. Neither their nonperturbative convergence nor their nontriviality is proved here.

10.4. **The two residues.** Theorem 10.4 reduces a continuum mass gap to two statements, neither of which is proved here or, to our knowledge, anywhere else.

(D) *The cube estimate.* There are $\alpha < 1$ and $\ell > 0$ such that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds with $na \le \ell$ along the continuum tuning $\beta = \beta(a) \to \infty$, uniformly in $a$.

(E) *The limit.* The renormalised Schwinger functions converge along $a_k = 2^{-k} a_0$ to Schwinger functions that satisfy the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms and are not those of the vacuum alone.

(D) and (E) together give the mass gap of the continuum theory; the remaining Clay requirements, Euclidean invariance and the local structure of the limit [39], belong to (E). (D) is a statement about a single cube of fixed physical size and a single coupling at each spacing; (E) is the construction problem, on which Bałaban's renormalisation group analysis [4, 5, 6] gives the ultraviolet part in finite volume.

*Remark* 10.6. A linear-response count suggests that (D) is consistent with a massive continuum theory. If the gauge-fixed field responds to a change of one link on the boundary of a cube through a Poisson kernel with decay length $\xi$ in lattice units, the response summed

over the cube is of order $\xi$, so $K_c$ is of order $n^3\xi$ and $D(n,\alpha)$ asks for $n \gtrsim \xi/\alpha$, that is, $\ell \gtrsim \xi a/\alpha$, a fixed multiple of the physical correlation length. The count is not a proof, and it assumes that the gauge-fixed links decorrelate on the scale $\xi$. The gauge here is built on straight lines, and in gauges of axial type the gauge-fixed variables can fluctuate on all scales even when gauge-invariant observables cluster; if that happens, (D) fails in this gauge and has to be posed for block-averaged variables, where it becomes part of the renormalisation group problem.

*Remark* 10.7. The other routes we tried stop at (D) or (E), or earlier.

(a) *Disjoint blocks.* The block criterion of Lemma B.3 with a partition into cubes of side $n$ requires, for a link on a face, that its influence on the neighbouring cube be less than one. In the count of Remark 10.6 that influence is of order $\xi$, which grows like $1/a$. Averaging over the $N_n$ translates divides it by the number of translates on whose boundary the link lies, a factor of order $1/n$, and this is why (D) is stated for averaged cubes.

(b) *Rescaling a fixed lattice gap.* Any bound uniform in lattice units, such as those of Theorems 1.1–1.7, gives trivial continuum two-point functions [14]; rescaling it produces no gap.

(c) *Assuming the gap.* Hypothesis R of [14] assumes the gap in physical units together with the limit. Theorem 10.4 replaces the gap part by the cube estimate (D), which concerns one box and one coupling at each spacing.

(d) *Computation.* At a fixed coupling and a fixed small $n$, $D(n,\alpha)$ is a finite set of Kantorovich bounds and could in principle be certified as in Propositions 7.8 and 7.9; for $n = 2$ and SU(2) the block already has 48 links and 144 real variables. (D) asks for it at infinitely many couplings with $n \to \infty$, which no finite computation covers.

(e) *Axioms alone.* Proposition 9.2 shows that positivity, invariance and regularity do not force a gap, and Proposition 9.1 shows that the growth route to rotation invariance is closed for the action density. The infrared input therefore has to be an estimate such as (D).

10.5. **What the cube estimate requires.** This subsection proves four facts about $D(n,\alpha)$. It holds at small coupling for every even $n$ above an explicit size (Proposition 10.9). It forces the gauge-fixed variables of a cube with trivial exterior to stay a fixed distance from the identity on average (Theorem 10.10), so that for every fixed $n$ it fails once $\beta$ is large (Corollary 10.11). And it cannot be obtained from bounds on the conditional law of a single line of links that are uniform in the configuration around the line (Proposition 10.14). None of the four decides (D) along the continuum tuning, where $n$ grows while $\beta$ grows.[12]

For a finite $V \subset A$ and $j \in A \setminus V$ let $b(V,j)$ be the number of links of $V$ that share a plaquette with $j$, and write $k \sim i$ when two active links share a plaquette.

**Lemma 10.8.** *Suppose that $C_{ee'} \le c_0$ for all active $e, e'$, with $12c_0 < 1$. Then $C_{V,j} \le c_0\, b(V,j)/(1-12c_0)$ for every finite $V \subset A$ and every $j \in A \setminus V$.*

*Proof.* Fix $Q, Q'$ that differ only at $j$, put $d = \delta(Q_j, Q'_j)$, $\mu = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q)$ and $\nu = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q')$. The couplings of $\mu$ and $\nu$ form a weakly compact set on which $\pi \mapsto \int d_V\, d\pi$ is continuous, so one of them, $\pi$, minimises it; let $\rho_i = \int \delta(X_i, Y_i)\, d\pi$. Fix $i \in V$. Under $\mu$ the conditional law of $X_i$ given the other links of $V$ is $\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid X)$, and likewise for $\nu$. Replace $(X_i, Y_i)$ by a pair drawn from an optimal coupling of $\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid X)$ and $\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid Y)$, chosen measurably [64, Cor. 5.22], and keep the other coordinates. The new coupling still has marginals $\mu$ and $\nu$,

[12] The four statements answer the question of which parts of (D) can be settled with the methods of this paper. The first places (D) in the range where the single-link method already works, the second and third show what any proof of (D) at weak coupling has to produce, and the fourth excludes the most direct one-dimensional route. The finite counts used below, from Table 3, are rechecked by `cube_requirements.py` in the archive.

and changing the links in which $X$ and $Y$ differ one at a time gives

$$W_1(\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid X), \gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid Y)) \le \sum_{k \in V,\, k \neq i} C_{ik}\, \delta(X_k, Y_k) + C_{ij}\, d.$$

Minimality of $\pi$ therefore gives $\rho_i \le c_0 \sum_{k \in V,\, k \sim i} \rho_k + c_0 [i \sim j]\, d$. Sum over $i \in V$: every $\rho_k$ occurs at most twelve times by Lemma 2.2(iv), so $(1 - 12c_0) \sum_i \rho_i \le c_0\, b(V, j)\, d$. Since $W_1^{d_V}(\mu, \nu) \le \sum_i \rho_i$, dividing by $d$ proves the lemma. □

**Proposition 10.9.** *Let $n = 2m$ and let $V$ be the cube of Definition 10.1. For every class $c$,*

$$\sum_{j \in c \setminus V} b(V, j) \le 10m^3 - 2m^2,$$

*with equality for three classes. Consequently, if $C_{ee'} \le c_0$ for all $e, e'$ with $12c_0 < 1$, then $D(n, \alpha)$ holds for every $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ with*

$$\alpha \ge \hat{\alpha}_n = \frac{c_0}{1 - 12c_0} \Big( \frac{20}{n} - \frac{8}{n^2} \Big).$$

*For* SU(2) *and $|\beta_W| < \frac{1}{3}$ this reads $\hat{\alpha}_n = \frac{|\beta_W|}{1 - 3|\beta_W|} (\frac{5}{n} - \frac{2}{n^2})$, which is below one for every even $n > 5|\beta_W|/(1 - 3|\beta_W|)$.*

*Proof.* Let $j = (y, \mu)$ lie in the class $c$, with $y \equiv r$ modulo two. A link of $V$ that shares a plaquette with $j$ has base point $y + d$ with $d \in \{-1, 0, 1\}^4$ and at most two nonzero coordinates, and the twelve offsets $d$ depend only on $c$. For a fixed offset we count the $y \equiv r$ with $y + d \in [0, n)^4$ and $y \notin [0, n)^4$. In the coordinate $l$ there are $m$ values of $y_l \equiv r_l$ with $y_l + d_l \in [0, n)$, and one of them lies outside $[0, n)$ exactly when $d_l = 1$ and $r_l = 1$ (the value $y_l = -1$) or $d_l = -1$ and $r_l = 0$ (the value $y_l = n$). If $q$ is the number of such coordinates, the count is $m^4 - m^{4-q}(m-1)^q$, that is 0, $m^3$ or $2m^3 - m^2$ for $q = 0, 1, 2$. Summing over the twelve offsets, the class sum is $a_c m^3 - b_c m^2$, where $b_c$ is the number of offsets with $q = 2$ and $a_c$ is the number with $q = 1$ plus twice $b_c$. Reading the offsets from Table 3, the pairs $(a_c, b_c)$ over the 48 classes are $(2, 0)$, $(7, 0)$, $(7, 1)$, $(9, 1)$, $(9, 2)$ and $(10, 2)$ three times each and $(3, 0)$, $(4, 0)$, $(5, 0)$, $(6, 0)$ and $(8, 1)$ six times each. In every case $a_c \le 10$ and $8 - a_c + b_c \ge 0$, so

$$(10m^3 - 2m^2) - (a_c m^3 - b_c m^2) = m^2((10 - a_c)m + b_c - 2) \ge m^2(8 - a_c + b_c) \ge 0,$$

with equality for the three classes with $(a_c, b_c) = (10, 2)$. By Lemma 10.8, $K_c \le c_0(10m^3 - 2m^2)/(1 - 12c_0)$, and $N_n = m^4$ gives $K_c/N_n \le \hat{\alpha}_n$. For SU(2) the proof of Theorem 1.1 gives $c_0 = |\beta| = |\beta_W|/4$. □

At $\beta_W = \frac{3}{10}$ and $n = 16$, for instance, $\hat{\alpha}_{16} = \frac{117}{128}$, and Theorem 10.2 gives the gap $\log \frac{128}{117}/32$, much weaker than Theorem 1.1. The proposition shows that the cube condition is not empty; it does not extend the range, because the absorption $12c_0 < 1$ is the single-link condition itself.

The next theorem uses the configuration in which every link outside $V$ is the identity. Write $\gamma_V^1 = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid 1)$ and

$$\varepsilon_V(\beta) = \frac{1}{|V|} \sum_{i \in V} \int \delta(1, Q_i)\, d\gamma_V^1(Q)$$

for the mean distance of the gauge-fixed variables of the cube from the identity. Recall that $\delta$ is bi-invariant of diameter $D$.

**Theorem 10.10.** *Let $n$ be even, $V$ the cube of Definition 10.1, and suppose that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds at $\beta$. Then*

$$\varepsilon_V(\beta) \ge \frac{(1 - \alpha)\, D}{3}.$$

*Proof. A flat configuration.* By Lemma 2.2(i) and the period two of $\sigma$, the sixteen residues modulo two fall into eight pairs $\{r, r+e_{\sigma(r)}\}$, the residues met by one line of $F$. The eight residues 0010, 0011, 0100, 0110, 1001, 1011, 1100, 1101 form four of these pairs. Choose $z, w \in G$ with $\delta(z,w) = D$, put $g(x) = w$ if $x$ is congruent to one of those eight residues and $g(x) = z$ otherwise, and let $Q^g_{(x,\mu)} = g(x)g(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$ for every link of $\mathbb{Z}^4$. Then $g$ is constant on every line of $F$, so $Q^g$ equals 1 on $F$, every plaquette variable of $Q^g$ is 1, and $Q^g$ has period two. By bi-invariance $\delta(1, Q^g_{(x,\mu)}) = \delta(g(x+e_\mu), g(x))$, which is $D$ when $x$ and $x+e_\mu$ receive different values and 0 otherwise; from Table 3 the first case occurs for exactly 32 of the 48 classes. Let $\delta_c$ be the common value of $\delta(1, Q^g_e)$ for $e$ in the class $c$, so that $\sum_c \delta_c = 32D$.

*Gauge covariance.* Let $\Phi(Q)_{(x,\mu)} = g(x)Q_{(x,\mu)}g(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$ on $G^V$. The gauge transformation by $g$ maps the configuration equal to $Q_V$ on $V$ and to 1 elsewhere to the one equal to $\Phi(Q_V)$ on $V$ and to $Q^g$ elsewhere; it leaves every plaquette trace unchanged and every link of $F$ equal to 1, and $\Phi$ preserves Haar measure. Hence $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g) = \Phi_* \gamma^1_V$.

*Upper bound.* Only the finitely many links outside $V$ that share a plaquette with $V$ enter $\gamma_V$. Changing them one at a time from 1 to $Q^g$ and applying the definition of $C_{V,j}$ at each step,

$$W_1^{d_V}\big(\gamma^1_V, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)\big) \le \sum_{j \in A \setminus V} C_{V,j}\, \delta(1, Q^g_j) = \sum_c \delta_c K_c \le \alpha N_n \sum_c \delta_c = 32\,\alpha D N_n.$$

*Lower bound.* The function $f(Q) = -\sum_{i \in V} \delta(Q_i, Q^g_i)$ is 1-Lipschitz for $d_V$. By gauge covariance and bi-invariance, $\int f\, d\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g) = -\int \sum_i \delta(Q_i, 1)\, d\gamma^1_V = -|V|\varepsilon_V$, and by the triangle inequality $\int f\, d\gamma^1_V \le -\sum_i \delta(1, Q^g_i) + |V|\varepsilon_V$. Every class has $N_n$ links in $V$, so $\sum_i \delta(1, Q^g_i) = 32 D N_n$ and

$$W_1^{d_V}\big(\gamma^1_V, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)\big) \ge 32 D N_n - 2|V|\varepsilon_V.$$

With $|V| = 48 N_n$ the two bounds give $96 N_n \varepsilon_V \ge 32(1-\alpha) D N_n$. □

**Corollary 10.11.** *For every even $n$ and every $\alpha < 1$ there is $\beta_0(n,\alpha)$ such that $D(n,\alpha)$ fails at every $\beta \ge \beta_0(n,\alpha)$. In particular, if $D(n_k,\alpha)$ holds at couplings $\beta_k \to \infty$, then $n_k \to \infty$.*

*Proof.* For $\beta > 0$, $\gamma^1_V$ has density proportional to $e^{-N\beta S}$ with respect to Haar measure, where $S = \sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} (N - \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q^F_p)$ is continuous and nonnegative on $G^V$ and vanishes exactly when $Q^F_p = 1$ for every plaquette $p$ that meets $V$. We show that this forces $Q_V = 1$. The other plaquettes have all their links equal to 1, so every plaquette variable is 1; since the plaquettes of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ fill every closed lattice path, there is a function $h$ on the sites with $Q_{(x,\mu)} = h(x)h(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$ on every link, and $h$ takes equal values at the two ends of every link on which $Q = 1$. Every link with base point outside $[0,n)^4$ is such a link. From a site with a coordinate at least $n$ one can move in every positive direction along links of this kind, and from a site with a negative coordinate $x_\nu$ one can move in the positive directions other than $\nu$ until another coordinate reaches $n$; so $h$ is constant on the sites outside the box. Every line of $F$ leaves the box, and $h$ is constant along it, so $h$ is constant and $Q_V = 1$.

Let $U$ be a neighbourhood of 1 in $G^V$, $s = \min_{G^V \setminus U} S > 0$, and $U' \subset U$ a neighbourhood of 1 on which $S < s/2$. Then $\gamma^1_V(G^V \setminus U) \le e^{-N\beta s}/(|U'| e^{-N\beta s/2})$, which tends to zero, so $\varepsilon_V(\beta) \to 0$ as $\beta \to \infty$, and Theorem 10.10 excludes $D(n,\alpha)$ once $\varepsilon_V(\beta) < (1-\alpha)D/3$. □

The size $\beta_0(n,\alpha)$ in Corollary 10.11 comes from a compactness argument. For SU(2) it can be made explicit, and then reads as a lower bound on the side of any cube that satisfies the condition.

**Proposition 10.12.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ with the chordal metric, so that $D = 2$, let $b = \beta_W \ge \frac{1}{9}$, let $n \ge 2$ be even and put $L(b) = 1 + \log 24 + \frac{3}{2}\log(9b)$. Then*

$$\varepsilon_V(\beta) \le (4n^2 + 2n)\Big(\frac{12 L(b)}{b}\Big)^{1/2}.$$

*Consequently, if $D(n,\alpha)$ holds at $b$, then*

$$n^4 \geq \frac{(1-\alpha)^2\, b}{675\, L(b)}.$$

*Proof.* Put $m = n/2$. Under $\gamma_V^1$ every link outside $V$ equals 1: the links of $F$ always, the others by the choice of exterior. A plaquette that does not meet $V$ therefore has plaquette variable 1.

*Links as loops.* Let $e = (x,\mu) \in V$, $y = x + e_\mu$, $\sigma = \sigma(x)$ and $\tau = \sigma(y)$. The directions $\sigma, \tau, \mu$ are distinct: $\sigma \neq \mu$ because $e$ is active; $\tau \neq \mu$ because otherwise the line of $F$ through $y$ would contain $x$, and the lines of $F$ are disjoint; and $\tau \neq \sigma$ by Table 3, in which $\sigma(x + e_\mu) \neq \sigma(x)$ whenever $\mu \neq \sigma(x)$. Since $0 \leq x_\sigma < n$, one of $n - x_\sigma$ and $x_\sigma + 1$ is at most $m$; call it $s$ and let $\epsilon = \pm 1$ be the sign for which $x' = x + s\epsilon e_\sigma$ has $\sigma$-coordinate outside $[0,n)$. Choose $t \leq m$ and $\epsilon'$ in the same way for $y$ and $\tau$ (note $y_\tau = x_\tau$). Let $R_1$ be the $s$ plaquettes of the rectangle with corners $x$, $x'$, $x' + e_\mu$, $y$ in the plane $\{\sigma,\mu\}$, and $R_2$ the $st$ plaquettes of the rectangle with corners $y$, $x' + e_\mu$, $x' + e_\mu + t\epsilon' e_\tau$, $y + t\epsilon' e_\tau$ in the plane $\{\sigma,\tau\}$. The union $R(e) = R_1 \cup R_2$ is a disc, and its boundary runs from $x$ along the line of $F$ through $x$ to $x'$, then to $x' + e_\mu$, along $e_\tau$ to $x' + e_\mu + t\epsilon' e_\tau$, along $e_\sigma$ to $y + t\epsilon' e_\tau$, back along the line of $F$ through $y$ to $y$, and over $e$ to $x$. The links of the first and fifth pieces lie in $F$. The links of the second and third pieces have base points with $\sigma$-coordinate $x'_\sigma \notin [0,n)$, and those of the fourth have base points with $\tau$-coordinate outside $[0,n)$; none of them lies in $V$. So the holonomy of the boundary of $R(e)$ is $Q_e^{\pm 1}$. Adding the plaquettes of a disc one at a time along its boundary shows that this holonomy is a product of conjugates of the plaquette variables $(Q_p^F)^{\pm 1}$, $p \in R(e)$, one for each plaquette. By bi-invariance and the triangle inequality,

$$\delta(1, Q_e) \leq \sum_{p \in R(e)} \delta(1, Q_p^F), \qquad |R(e)| = s(t+1) \leq m(m+1).$$

*Multiplicity.* If a plaquette $p$ lies in $R_2(e)$, its plane is $\{\sigma,\tau\}$, $\mu$ is one of the two other directions, and the base point of $p$ is $y + ae_\sigma + ce_\tau$ with $-m \leq a, c \leq m-1$. Given $p$, there are two ways to name the directions of its plane, two choices of $\mu$ and $(2m)^2$ of $(a,c)$, and they determine $y$, hence $e$; so $p$ lies in at most $16m^2$ of the sets $R_2(e)$. Likewise $p \in R_1(e)$ forces its plane to be $\{\sigma,\mu\}$ and its base point to be $x + ae_\sigma$ with $-m \leq a \leq m-1$, which leaves at most $4m$ links $e$. Every plaquette therefore lies in at most $16m^2 + 4m = 4n^2 + 2n$ of the discs $R(e)$.

*The energy.* For the chordal metric $\delta(1,q)^2 = 2 - \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} q$. Let $S = \sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} \delta(1, Q_p^F)^2$; then $\gamma_V^1$ has density $e^{-bS/2}/Z$ with $Z = \int e^{-bS/2}$, the integral over $\mathrm{SU}(2)^V$ with Haar measure. The function $t \mapsto \log \int e^{-tS}$ is convex and vanishes at $t = 0$, so its derivative at $t = b/2$, which is $-\int S\, d\gamma_V^1$, is at least $2 \log Z/b$. A plaquette that meets $V$ contains at most three links of $V$ and the other links are 1, so $\delta(1, Q_p^F)^2 \leq 3 \sum_{e \in p \cap V} \delta(1, Q_e)^2$; every link lies in six plaquettes, so $S \leq 18 \sum_{e \in V} \delta(1, Q_e)^2$ and $Z \geq I^{|V|}$ with $I = \int e^{-9b\,\delta(1,q)^2} dq$. The chordal distance is at most the geodesic one, and the geodesic ball of radius $r = (9b)^{-1/2} \leq 1$ has measure greater than $r^3/24$ (proof of Proposition 10.14), so $I \geq e^{-1}(9b)^{-3/2}/24$ and

$$\int S\, d\gamma_V^1 \leq \frac{2|V|\, L(b)}{b}.$$

*Conclusion.* At most $6|V|$ plaquettes meet $V$. Summing the loop bound over $e \in V$ and using the multiplicity and the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality,

$$\begin{aligned} |V|\,\varepsilon_V &\le (4n^2+2n) \sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} \int \delta(1, Q_p^F)\, d\gamma_V^1 \\ &\le (4n^2+2n)\Big(6|V| \int S\, d\gamma_V^1\Big)^{1/2} \\ &\le (4n^2+2n)\,|V|\Big(\frac{12L(b)}{b}\Big)^{1/2}. \end{aligned}$$

If $D(n,\alpha)$ holds, Theorem 10.10 with $D=2$ gives $\varepsilon_V \ge \frac{2}{3}(1-\alpha)$; squaring and using $4n^2+2n \le 5n^2$, $\frac{4}{9}(1-\alpha)^2 \le 300\, n^4 L(b)/b$. □

*Remark* 10.13. The proof loses the area of a disc, of order $n^2$, in passing from plaquettes to links, and on loops that loss is of the right order. On the periodic lattice $(\mathbb{Z}/L\mathbb{Z})^4$ with $L$ even and coordinates $0 \le x_j < L$, let $\phi = 4\pi/L^2$, $q(\theta) = \cos\theta + \mathbf{i}\sin\theta$, and put $U_{(x,2)} = q(\phi x_1)$, $U_{(x,1)} = q(-\phi L x_2)$ when $x_1 = L-1$, and $U = 1$ on every other link. Every plaquette of the plane $\{1,2\}$ equals $q(\phi)$, including those on the seam $x_1 = L-1$ and at the corner $x_1 = x_2 = L-1$, where the angle is $\phi - 4\pi$; all other plaquettes equal 1. So every plaquette variable lies within $\phi$ of the identity, while the boundary of the square $[0, L/2]^2$ of the plane $\{1,2\}$ has holonomy $q(\phi L^2/4) = -1$, at the largest possible distance $D = 2$, against the bound $\phi L^2/4 = \pi$ given by the disc. Every staple sum of this configuration is parallel to its link, so it is a stationary point of the Wilson action, and gradient flow [45] does not change it. Plaquette variables within $O(n^{-2})$ of the identity therefore do not force loops of length $n$ near the identity, and an argument of the kind above that places gauge-fixed links near the identity needs plaquette bounds of order $o(n^{-2})$.

Along the continuum tuning Theorem 10.10 says the following. If (D) holds, then in a cube of fixed physical size $\ell$ with the identity outside, the forest-gauge variables stay on average at distance at least $(1-\alpha)D/3$ from the identity, at every spacing. This is not a contradiction: $n = \ell/a$ grows like $1/a$, while asymptotic freedom makes $\beta(a)$ grow only like $\log(1/a)$, and the corollary concerns fixed $n$. The size bound of Proposition 10.12 is likewise met along the tuning, since its right side grows only like $\log(1/a)$. It turns the assumption of Remark 10.6, that the gauge-fixed links decorrelate on the scale of the cube, into a necessary condition. Whether the forest-gauge variables are disordered at a fixed physical scale, as the gauge-invariant ones are expected to be in a massive theory, is part of what (D) asks.

The last statement concerns a strategy that suggests itself: control the conditional law of one line of links, given everything else, uniformly in the configuration around it, and assemble the cube from lines. Fix a site $x$, let $s = \sigma(x)$ and $\mu \neq s$, and let $c_k = (x + k e_s, \mu)$, $k \in \mathbb{Z}$. All $c_k$ are active, since $\sigma$ is constant along the line through $x$.

**Proposition 10.14.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$, identified with the unit quaternions, and $b = \beta_W \ge 1$. There is a configuration of the active links outside $\{c_k\}$, independent of $b$, for which the conditional law of $(Q_{c_k})_k$ has a ten-step transfer operator, similar to a positive self-adjoint operator $K_b$ on $L^2(S^3)$ with simple top eigenvalue $\Lambda_b$, whose gap satisfies*

$$0 < 1 - \frac{\Lambda_{b,1}}{\Lambda_b} \le e^{20}\, 24^{10}\, b^{15}\, e^{-b/1280},$$

*where $\Lambda_{b,1}$ is the next point of the spectrum.*

*Proof. The interactions.* By Lemma 2.2(iii), $c_k$ lies in two plaquettes of the plane $\{\mu, s\}$, which contain $c_{k-1}$ or $c_{k+1}$, the link $(x + k e_s, s)$ or $(x + (k-1)e_s, s)$ of $F$, and an active twist link of direction $s$; and in four plaquettes of the planes $\{\mu, t\}$ and $\{\mu, \rho\}$, each containing $c_k$, one link of $F$ and two active links not on the line. The four plaquettes at $c_k$ lie in the hyperplane of $s$-coordinate $x_s + k$, so these plaquettes at different $k$ share no link;

two plaquettes through $c_k$ share no other link; and their links have directions other than $s$, so they are not twists. Set every twist to 1; then the plaquette at $x + ke_s$ in the plane $\{\mu, s\}$ contributes $b\langle q_k, q_{k+1}\rangle$ to the exponent, with $q_k = Q_{c_k}$. In each of the four other plaquettes at $c_k$ set one of its two links to 1 and the other to $X$; after a cyclic rotation and possibly an inversion the plaquette variable is $q_k X^{\pm 1}$ or $q_k^{-1} X^{\pm 1}$, and since $\mathrm{Re}(q\bar{u}) = \mathrm{Re}(\bar{q}u) = \langle q, u\rangle$ for unit quaternions, $X$ can be chosen so that the plaquette contributes $b\langle q_k, u\rangle$ for any prescribed unit vector $u$. Every other active link is set to 1. Four unit vectors add up to any vector of length at most 4 (two copies each of $t \pm (1 - |t|^2)^{1/2}\nu$ with $t = v/4$ and $\nu \perp t$ a unit vector), so the conditional density of the line is proportional to $\exp\big(b\sum_k \langle q_k, q_{k+1}\rangle + \sum_k \langle h_k, q_k\rangle\big)$ for any fields $h_k$ with $|h_k| \le 4b$.

*The fields.* Let $a = \frac{1}{2}$, $c = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$, let $e_1, \dots, e_4$ be the standard basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$, and let $r_k$ have period ten with $(r_0, \dots, r_9) = a(e_1, -e_1, e_2, -e_2, e_3, -e_3, e_3, -e_2, e_2, -e_1)$. Put $h_k = b(2r_k - r_{k-1} - r_{k+1})$, so $|h_k| \le 4ab = 2b$, and the configuration is independent of $b$ because $h_k/b$ is. With $v_k = q_k - r_k$ and $|q_k| = 1$, $|r_k| = a$, summation by parts gives, over $0 \le k \le 9$,

$$\frac{1}{2}\sum_k |v_{k+1} - v_k|^2 = \sum_k \big(1 - \langle q_k, q_{k+1}\rangle\big) - \frac{1}{b}\sum_k \langle h_k, q_k\rangle + \frac{1}{2}\sum_k |r_{k+1} - r_k|^2 + B(q_0) - B(q_{10}),$$

with $B(q) = \langle q, r_0 - r_9\rangle$. The boundary terms only conjugate the ten-step transfer kernel by a multiplication operator, so up to similarity it is

$$K_b(x, y) = \int_{(S^3)^9} \exp\Big(-\frac{b}{2}\sum_{k=0}^{9} |v_{k+1} - v_k|^2\Big)\, dq_1 \cdots dq_9, \qquad q_0 = x,\ q_{10} = y,$$

with normalised Haar measure. The sequence $r_0, \dots, r_{10}$ is a palindrome, so $K_b = B_b B_b^*$ for the five-step kernel $B_b$; $K_b$ is compact, positive and self-adjoint with a continuous positive kernel, its top eigenvalue $\Lambda_b$ is simple, and its eigenfunction $\psi_b > 0$ is even under the reflection $x_4 \mapsto -x_4$, which commutes with $K_b$.

*A barrier.* Let $E = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{k=0}^{9} |v_{k+1} - v_k|^2$ and suppose that $(q_0)_4 \ge 0 \ge (q_{10})_4$ and $E \le \frac{1}{1280}$. Put $\Delta = (20E)^{1/2} \le \frac{1}{8}$ and $w = v_0$; by Cauchy–Schwarz $|w - v_k| \le \Delta$ for all $k$, and $0 \le w_4 \le \Delta$ because the $r_k$ have no fourth coordinate. From $|v_k + r_k| = 1$, $\big||w + r_k|^2 - 1\big| \le \Delta(2 + \Delta) =: \eta$ for $0 \le k \le 5$. The pairs $r_k = \pm a e_l$ give $|w_l| \le \eta/(2a) = \eta$ for $l = 1, 2, 3$ and $|w|^2 \ge \frac{3}{4} - \eta$, so $\frac{3}{4} \le 3\eta^2 + \Delta^2 + \eta \le 3(\frac{17}{64})^2 + \frac{1}{64} + \frac{17}{64} = \frac{2019}{4096}$, a contradiction. Hence $K_b(x, y) \le e^{-b/1280}$ whenever $x_4 \ge 0 \ge y_4$.

*The top eigenvalue.* Let $\epsilon = b^{-1/2}$. The geodesic ball of radius $\epsilon \le 1$ in $S^3$ has normalised measure $\frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^{\epsilon} \sin^2\theta\, d\theta \ge \frac{8\epsilon^3}{3\pi^3} > \frac{\epsilon^3}{24}$. If each $q_k$ lies in the ball of radius $\epsilon$ about $r_k + ce_4$, then $|v_k - ce_4| \le \epsilon$ and $E \le 20\epsilon^2$, so the integrand is at least $e^{-20}$. Testing $K_b$ on the normalised indicator of the ball about $r_0 + ce_4$ gives $\Lambda_b \ge e^{-20}(\epsilon^3/24)^{10} = e^{-20} 24^{-10} b^{-15}$.

*The gap.* Let $\phi(x) = \mathrm{sign}(x_4)\psi_b(x)$, a unit vector orthogonal to $\psi_b$. Then

$$\Lambda_b - \langle \phi, K_b \phi\rangle = 4\int_{x_4 > 0 > y_4} \psi_b(x) K_b(x, y) \psi_b(y)\, dx\, dy \le e^{-b/1280},$$

because $\int_{x_4 > 0} \psi_b \le \frac{1}{2}$ by Cauchy–Schwarz. By the variational principle $\Lambda_{b,1} \ge \langle \phi, K_b \phi\rangle$, and dividing by the lower bound on $\Lambda_b$ proves the estimate; the gap is positive because $\Lambda_b$ is simple. □

The exterior of Proposition 10.14 is legal at every coupling, so a bound on the conditional law of single lines that is uniform in the exterior cannot be better than $e^{-b/1280}$ up to powers of $b$, and an argument of this kind cannot give (D) along the tuning. A proof of (D) has to use what such a bound discards: the joint resampling of the transverse links inside the cube, which the averaged coefficients $C_{V,j}$ retain, or the smallness of the probability of such exteriors under the Wilson measure.

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## Declarations

**Data and code availability.** The analytic proofs are complete as written, except the evaluations in Propositions 7.8 and 7.9 and Lemma 8.3 and the numerical bounds of Lemma 5.5, which are computations with rigorous error bounds, and the finite check of Lemma 5.1. The archive `creelie/4Y-M` (release v3.7.0, `https://github.com/creelie/4y-m/releases/tag/v3.7.0`) contains the programs of that computation, in Python with python-flint (FLINT and Arb) and a C kernel for products of Taylor polynomials, with their outputs and the list of certified boxes; the programs and outputs of the earlier certificate at $\beta_W = \frac{45}{64}$; independent checks in exact rational arithmetic of Lemmas 6.2 and 7.2 and of (7.3); numerical checks of Lemma 6.1 on tori; the searches of Remark 6.8 and Section 9; a Lean 4 certificate of the line field (Lemmas 2.1 and 2.2 for the table of Appendix A, by `decide`); the programs of Appendix C for the plaquette blocks, with the floating-point search of Remark 5.7; an exact computation of the curvatures of Table 1 from the root systems; exact checks of the finite counts and of the discs of Section 10.5, with Monte Carlo estimates of the influence coefficients and of $\varepsilon_V$ that the proofs do not use; and the source of the preprint version of this paper. The computations and the Lean, Python and shell checks were run with AI assistance (Claude Opus 5.5, Claude Fable 5.1 with Ultracode, GPT-6.1 Sol Ultra and GPT-6 Astra Ultra) under the direction of Deep Bhattacharjee. The first composite behind Theorem 1.1 was assembled by Anaxia, the reasoning engine of the BLLM system, in release v3.0.5 [11], as described in the footnote to that theorem; release v3.1.0 [12] records the engine's Yang–Mills runs in its failure log, whose last Yang–Mills entry is the change from single links to blocks of several links; the plaquette blocks of Section 5, the bound of Lemma 5.4, their SU(3) version in Section 8 and the certified constants were found and checked by the authors. All three authors approved the final text.

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## Appendix A. The line field

Table 3 lists, for each residue class of $x$ modulo two, the direction $\sigma(x)$ and the permutation $\pi_x(\mu) = \sigma(x + e_\mu)$. In every row $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$ and is a three-cycle on the other directions, which is the condition of Lemma 2.1.

TABLE 3. The line field: $x$ modulo two (digits $x_0x_1x_2x_3$), the direction $\sigma(x)$ and the values $\sigma(x+e_\mu)$ for $\mu=0,1,2,3$.

| $x$ | $\sigma(x)$ | $\mu=0$ | $\mu=1$ | $\mu=2$ | $\mu=3$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0000 | 0 | 0 | 2 | 3 | 1 |
| 1000 | 0 | 0 | 3 | 1 | 2 |
| 0100 | 2 | 3 | 0 | 2 | 1 |
| 1100 | 3 | 2 | 0 | 1 | 3 |
| 0010 | 3 | 1 | 2 | 0 | 3 |
| 1010 | 1 | 3 | 1 | 0 | 2 |
| 0110 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 2 | 0 |
| 1110 | 1 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 0 |
| 0001 | 1 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 0 |
| 1001 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 2 | 0 |
| 0101 | 1 | 3 | 1 | 0 | 2 |
| 1101 | 3 | 1 | 2 | 0 | 3 |
| 0011 | 3 | 2 | 0 | 1 | 3 |
| 1011 | 2 | 3 | 0 | 2 | 1 |
| 0111 | 0 | 0 | 3 | 1 | 2 |
| 1111 | 0 | 0 | 2 | 3 | 1 |

## APPENDIX B. THE COMPARISON LEMMA

Let $(G,\delta)$ be a compact group with a bi-invariant metric of diameter $D$, $\Omega=G^A$, and $C_{ee'}$ the coefficients of Section 3, with row and column sums at most $\alpha<1$ and $C_{ee'}=0$ unless $e,e'$ share a plaquette, so that $|e-e'|\le 1$ for the distance of link midpoints. Fix $\lambda>0$ with $\theta=\alpha e^{\lambda}<1$.

**Lemma B.1.** *Let $S\subset A$, possibly infinite, and let $\mu_1,\mu_2$ be probability measures on $\Omega$ invariant under $\gamma_e^F$ for every $e\notin S$. Let $T\subset A\setminus S$ be finite, $w_b=e^{-\lambda\,\mathrm{dist}(b,T)}$, and suppose $\sum_{z\in S}w_z<\infty$. There is a coupling of $\mu_1,\mu_2$ whose link distances $\varrho(b)=\mathbb{E}\,\delta(\sigma_b,\sigma'_b)$ satisfy*

$$\sum_{b\notin S} w_b\varrho(b)\le\frac{\theta D}{1-\theta}\sum_{z\in S}w_z.$$

*If $S=\emptyset$ then $\mu_1=\mu_2$.*

*Proof.* The couplings form a weakly compact set and $\Psi(\pi)=\sum_b w_b\mathbb{E}_\pi\delta(\sigma_b,\sigma'_b)$ is weakly continuous because $\sum_b w_b<\infty$; let $\pi^*$ be a minimiser. For $e\notin S$ replace the pair $(\sigma_e,\sigma'_e)$ by a sample of an optimal coupling of $\gamma_e^F(\cdot\mid\sigma)$ and $\gamma_e^F(\cdot\mid\sigma')$, chosen measurably [64, Cor. 5.22]. Both $\mu_i$ are invariant, so the result is again a coupling, and changing the finitely many links that enter $\gamma_e^F$ one at a time gives $W_1\le\sum_{e'}C_{ee'}\delta(\sigma_{e'},\sigma'_{e'})$. Minimality gives $\varrho(e)\le\sum_{e'}C_{ee'}\varrho(e')$. Multiply by $w_e$ and sum over $e\notin S$; where $C_{ee'}\neq0$, $w_e\le e^{\lambda}w_{e'}$, so

$$\sum_{e\notin S}w_e\varrho(e)\le\theta\Big[\sum_{e'\notin S}w_{e'}\varrho(e')+\sum_{z\in S}w_z\varrho(z)\Big],$$

all sums are finite, and $\varrho\le D$ on $S$. If $S=\emptyset$, $\varrho\equiv0$. □

**Corollary B.2.** *Let $\mu$ be the Gibbs measure of $\gamma^F$, $F$ a local function with support $S_F$, $L_F$-Lipschitz in each link, and $H$ bounded with finite support $S_H$ disjoint from $S_F$. Then*

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_\mu(F,H)|\le\|H\|_\infty L_F\frac{\theta D}{1-\theta}|S_H|\,e^{-\lambda\,\mathrm{dist}(S_F,S_H)}.$$

*Proof.* Condition on the links of $S_H$ [42, Ch. 3]; the conditional measures $\mu^\sigma=\mu(\cdot\mid\sigma_{S_H})$ are invariant under $\gamma_e^F$ for $e\notin S_H$. Lemma B.1 with $S=S_H$ and $T=S_F$, for which

$w_b = 1$ on $S_F$ and $w_z \le e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(S_F,S_H)}$ on $S_H$, gives $|\mu^\sigma(F) - \mu^{\sigma'}(F)| \le L_F \sum_{b\in S_F} \varrho(b) \le L_F \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta} |S_H| e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(S_F,S_H)}$ for any two boundary values. Since $H$ depends only on $\sigma_{S_H}$, $\operatorname{Cov}_\mu(F,H) = \iint H(\sigma)(\mu^\sigma(F) - \mu^{\sigma'}(F))\, d\mu(\sigma)\, d\mu(\sigma')$, and the bound follows. □

**Lemma B.3.** *Let the blocks partition $A$, let $C_{Bj}$ be the block coefficients of Section 5, with $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le \alpha < 1$ for every $j$ and $C_{Bj} = 0$ unless every link of $B$ lies within distance 2 of $j$, and fix $\lambda > 0$ with $\theta = \alpha e^{2\lambda} < 1$. Let $S \subset A$ be a union of blocks and let $\mu_1, \mu_2$ be invariant under $\gamma_B^{\mathcal{B}}$ for every block $B \not\subset S$. With $T$, $w_b$ as in Lemma B.1 and $\sum_{z\in S} w_z < \infty$, there is a coupling with $\sum_{b\notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta} \sum_{z\in S} w_z$, and $\mu_1 = \mu_2$ if $S = \emptyset$.*

*Proof.* Take a minimiser $\pi^*$ of $\Psi$ as before. For a block $B \not\subset S$ replace $(\sigma_B, \sigma'_B)$ by an optimal coupling, for the metric $d$, of the two block laws; it is again a coupling, and changing the boundary links one at a time bounds the expected new $d$-distance by $\sum_j C_{Bj} \varrho(j)$. Put $\bar w_B = \max_{i\in B} w_i$. Minimality gives

$$\sum_{i\in B} w_i \varrho(i) \le \bar w_B \sum_j C_{Bj} \varrho(j),$$

and $\bar w_B \le e^{2\lambda} w_j$ whenever $C_{Bj} \ne 0$. Summing over the blocks outside $S$ and using the column sums,

$$\sum_{b\notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \theta \Big[ \sum_{j\notin S} w_j \varrho(j) + \sum_{z\in S} w_z \varrho(z) \Big],$$

which gives the claim as in Lemma B.1. □

**Lemma B.4.** *Let $n \ge 2$ be even, let $V_x$, $x \in 2\mathbb{Z}^4$, be the translates of Section 10, and suppose that $D(n,\alpha)$ holds.*

(a) *If a probability measure $\mu$ on $G^A$ is invariant under $\gamma_e^F$ for every $e$ in a finite set $V$, it is invariant under $\gamma_V$.*

(b) *Fix $\lambda > 0$ with $\theta = \alpha e^{\lambda\rho_n} < 1$. Let $S \subset A$, and let $\mu_1, \mu_2$ be invariant under $\gamma_{V_x}$ for every $x$ with $V_x \cap S = \emptyset$. With $T$, $w_b$ as in Lemma B.1 and $\sum_{z\in S} w_z < \infty$, there is a coupling with*

$$\sum_{b\notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \frac{D(1 + c_n e^{\lambda\rho_n})}{1-\theta} \sum_{z\in S} w_z,$$

*and $\mu_1 = \mu_2$ if $S = \emptyset$.*

*Proof.* (a) Let $\nu_\eta$ be the conditional law of $Q_V$ given the links $\eta$ outside $V$. For bounded $f$ on $G^V$ and bounded $g$ of $\eta$, $\gamma_e^F(fg) = g\, \gamma_e^F f$ for $e \in V$, so invariance gives $\int g(\eta)(\nu_\eta(\gamma_e^F f) - \nu_\eta(f))\, d\mu = 0$ for all $g$; taking $f$ in a countable dense set of continuous functions, $\nu_\eta$ is invariant under every $\gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid \cdot, \eta)$, $e \in V$, for $\mu$-almost every $\eta$. So is $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$, whose conditional laws of single links are the $\gamma_e^F$. The composition $P_\eta$ of the kernels $\gamma_e^F$, $e \in V$, in a fixed order has a density with respect to Haar measure on $G^V$ bounded below by a positive constant, because each single-link density is at least $e^{-12N^2\beta}$ times its maximum over the group. A Markov kernel with such a lower bound has at most one invariant probability measure (Doeblin's condition), so $\nu_\eta = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$.

(b) Let $\pi^*$ minimise $\Psi$ as in Lemma B.1 and call $x$ admissible if $V_x \cap S = \emptyset$. For admissible $x$ replace $(\sigma_{V_x}, \sigma'_{V_x})$ by an optimal coupling, for $d_{V_x}$, of the two block laws; both $\mu_i$ are invariant, so the result is a coupling, and changing the boundary links one at a time bounds the new expected $d_{V_x}$-distance by $\sum_j C_{V_x,j} \varrho(j)$. With $\bar w_x = \max_{i\in V_x} w_i$, minimality gives

$$\sum_{i\in V_x} w_i \varrho(i) \le \bar w_x \sum_{j\notin V_x} C_{V_x,j} \varrho(j),$$

and $\bar w_x \le e^{\lambda\rho_n} w_j$ whenever $C_{V_x,j} \ne 0$. Let $S'$ be the set of links outside $S$ that lie in a translate meeting $S$; each is within distance $\rho_n$ of a link of $S$, so $\sum_{i\in S'} w_i \le c_n e^{\lambda\rho_n} \sum_{z\in S} w_z$.

A link outside $S \cup S'$ lies in $N_n$ translates, all admissible. Summing over admissible $x$ and using $\sum_{x:\, j \notin V_x} C_{V_x,j} = K_{c(j)} \le \alpha N_n$,

$$N_n \sum_{i \notin S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) \le \theta N_n \Big[ \sum_{i \notin S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) + \sum_{i \in S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) \Big].$$

All sums are finite and $\varrho \le D$, so $\sum_{i \notin S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) \le \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta}(1 + c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n}) \sum_{z \in S} w_z$; adding $\sum_{i \in S'} w_i \varrho(i) \le D c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n} \sum_{z \in S} w_z$ gives the bound. If $S = \emptyset$ then $S' = \emptyset$ and $\varrho \equiv 0$. □

The covariance bound of Corollary B.2 follows from part (b) in the same way, with $\theta D/(1-\theta)$ replaced by $D(1 + c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n})/(1-\theta)$, since the conditional measures $\mu^\sigma$ there are invariant under $\gamma_{V_x}$ for $V_x \cap S_H = \emptyset$ by part (a).

## Appendix C. The plaquette blocks

Table 4 lists the block plaquettes of Section 5 modulo $2\mathbb{Z}^4$: the plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ is a block plaquette exactly when $x$ modulo two and $\{\mu, \nu\}$ appear in the table. Eight lie in the plane $\{0, 1\}$ and eight in $\{2, 3\}$; together they contain the 48 active links of a cell of side two, each once.

Table 4. The sixteen block plaquettes modulo two: the base point $x$ (digits $x_0 x_1 x_2 x_3$ modulo two) and the plane.

| $x$ | plane | $x$ | plane |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0000 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0000 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 0001 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0011 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 0010 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0100 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 0011 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0111 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1100 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1000 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1101 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1011 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1110 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1100 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1111 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1111 | $\{2,3\}$ |

The program `cover.py` in the folder `strong-coupling/gauge-fixed/blocks/` of the archive finds this set by an exact-cover search on the torus of side two and checks Lemma 5.1 on the tori of side four and six. The program `constants.py` evaluates the bounds of Lemma 5.5 in ball arithmetic with python-flint at 120 bits: the series of $Z_0$ and of its first three derivatives in $s = r^2$ is summed to forty terms, and the tail is bounded for $s \le 5$ by twice the first omitted term $(5/4)^{40} 40^3/(40!\,41!)$, because consecutive terms decrease by a factor below one half. The program `alpha.py` evaluates the constants of (5.2) and $\alpha$ at a given $\beta_W$, read exactly.

For SU(3) the folder `strong-coupling/gauge-fixed/blocks/su3/` contains `consts.py`, which evaluates the bounds of Lemma 8.3 on the 841 boxes of side $\frac{3}{16}$ at $r = \frac{3}{2}$ and the 784 boxes of side $\frac{19}{100}$ at $r = \frac{38}{25}$ with the moments of Appendix E, and `alpha3.py`, which reads these bounds and the cover of Proposition 7.8 or Proposition 7.9 and evaluates the constants of (8.2) and $\alpha_3$ in ball arithmetic at 120 bits; its outputs at $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ and 0.76 are listed with the bounds of each box. The cover of Proposition 7.9 is computed by the program of Appendix E with `-r 38/25 -thr 1.03`.

## Appendix D. The blocks of Lemma 6.2

*Diagonal blocks.* Let $w_a = e^{i\phi}$. On the diagonal part, $f_p = -\cos\phi\,(y_1+y_2-y_3-y_4)^2$ and $c_p = 2(y_1y_4 - y_1y_2 + y_2y_3 - y_3y_4)$, so

$$\mathcal{F} = \sum_i \alpha_i y_i^2 + \cos\phi\,(y_1+y_2-y_3-y_4)^2 \\ -\tfrac{9}{5}(y_1y_4 - y_1y_2 + y_2y_3 - y_3y_4)$$

with $y_k = 0$ and weights $\alpha_{k\pm1} = \frac{21}{10}$, $\alpha_{k+2} = \frac{5}{4}$. It is affine in $\cos\phi$, so positivity at $\cos\phi = \pm1$ suffices. For $k = 1$ and $\cos\phi = 1$ the matrix in $(y_2, y_3, y_4)$ is

$$\begin{pmatrix} \frac{31}{10} & -\frac{19}{10} & -1 \\ -\frac{19}{10} & \frac{9}{4} & \frac{19}{10} \\ -1 & \frac{19}{10} & \frac{31}{10} \end{pmatrix},$$

and Table 5 lists the leading principal minors for every position; all are positive.

Table 5. Leading principal minors of the diagonal blocks of Lemma 6.2.

| Fixed link | $\cos\phi = 1$ | | | $\cos\phi = -1$ | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $e_1$, $e_4$ | $\frac{31}{10}$, | $\frac{673}{200}$, | $\frac{8421}{2000}$ | $\frac{11}{10}$, | $\frac{53}{200}$, | $\frac{21}{2000}$ |
| $e_2$ | $\frac{31}{10}$, | $\frac{861}{100}$, | $\frac{8421}{2000}$ | $\frac{11}{10}$, | $\frac{21}{100}$, | $\frac{21}{2000}$ |
| $e_3$ | $\frac{9}{4}$, | $\frac{673}{200}$, | $\frac{8421}{2000}$ | $\frac{1}{4}$, | $\frac{53}{200}$, | $\frac{21}{2000}$ |

*Pair blocks.* Let $w_a = e^{i(\chi+\vartheta)}$ and $w_b = e^{i(\chi-\vartheta)}$. The terms of $f_p$ carry $w_a + \bar{w}_b = 2\cos\chi\, e^{i\vartheta}$ or its conjugate, and $c_p$ carries $w_a\bar{w}_b = e^{2i\vartheta}$, so the Hermitian matrix $M(m,\vartheta)$ of $\mathcal{F}$, $m = \cos\chi$, is affine in $m$ with $M(-1,\vartheta) = M(1,\vartheta+\pi)$, and $m = 1$ suffices. For the fixed link $e_2$, in the variables $(z_1, z_3, z_4)$ and with $c = \cos\vartheta$,

$$M = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{21}{5} + 2c & -2e^{i\vartheta} & -\frac{9}{5} - 2e^{i\vartheta} \\ -2e^{-i\vartheta} & \frac{21}{5} + 2c & \frac{9}{5} + 2e^{-i\vartheta} \\ -\frac{9}{5} - 2e^{-i\vartheta} & \frac{9}{5} + 2e^{i\vartheta} & \frac{5}{2} + 2c \end{pmatrix}.$$

With $u = \cos^2(\vartheta/2) \in [0,1]$ its leading principal minors are

$$\tfrac{20u+11}{5}, \quad \tfrac{(20u+1)(20u+21)}{25}, \quad \tfrac{400u(40u^2-23u+4)+21}{250},$$

and $40u^2 - 23u + 4$ has negative discriminant $529 - 640$. The other positions give the same determinant and the leading minors $\frac{20u+11}{5}$ or $\frac{8u+1}{2}$ and $\frac{800u^2-180u+53}{50}$, whose discriminant $32400 - 169600$ is negative. Every block is positive definite.

The inequality is not tight. In floating point the least eigenvalue of the whole form over $W \in \mathrm{U}(N)$, $N \le 4$, is 0.0149, which is also the least eigenvalue of the exact blocks; this slack is what the choice of the weights $\frac{21}{10}$, $\frac{5}{4}$, $\frac{9}{10}$ trades against the constant $\frac{29}{2}$.

## Appendix E. The certified computation

*Truncation.* For a corner $b$ of a box the moments of Lemma 7.6 are derivatives of $Z$ at $(b, \bar{b})$. The truncated series is $\mathbb{E}_H[A_t(UD)B_t(\bar{U}D')]$ with $A_t$ the part of $\sum_\lambda c_\lambda s_\lambda(UD)$ over partitions with $\lambda_1 - \lambda_3 \le 34$ and $\lambda_3 \le 11$, and $B_t$ likewise. Every omitted partition has $|\lambda| > 34$, because $3 \cdot 12 > 34$, and the omitted part is at most $T(\|D\|) = \sum_{n>34}(\frac{3}{2}\|D\|)^n/n!$ in modulus. On the polydisc $|D_{ij} - b_{ij}| \le \rho$, $\|D\| \le \|b\| + 3\rho$, and Cauchy's estimate bounds the $\alpha$-th derivative of the omitted part by $\alpha!\rho^{-|\alpha|}T(\|b\| + 3\rho)$. The derivatives of the full exponential are at most $2^{-|\alpha|}e^{v/2}$ with $v = \sum_k |b_k|$, since $|\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)| \le \sum_k |b_k|$ for diagonal $b$. With $\varepsilon_\alpha = 2^{|\alpha|}\alpha!\rho^{-|\alpha|}T(\|b\| + 3\rho)$ the truncated moment differs from the true one by at

most $\varepsilon_\alpha e^{v/2} + (e^{v/2} + \varepsilon_\alpha)\varepsilon_\beta$, and $\rho$ is chosen to minimise $\rho^{-6}T$. The largest error bound of an unnormalised moment at any corner is $1.7 \times 10^{-11}$.

*Weight zero.* Conjugation by the diagonal torus $T$ preserves Haar measure and $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)$ for diagonal $b$, and multiplies $u_{ij}$ by $t_i t_j^{-1}$; a moment of a monomial on which $T$ acts by a nontrivial character is therefore 0, and only 8278 of the 134596 monomials of degree at most six have the trivial character. The functions $\operatorname{Tr}(X)$, $e_2(X)$, $\det X$ of $X = DD'^{\top}$ and $\det D$, $\det D'$ are invariant under the same action on the variables, so after these are formed in the full ring of Taylor polynomials of degree six in the 18 variables, the series is computed in the subring of weight-zero monomials.

*Rounding.* The truncated series is a Taylor polynomial of total degree six in the 36 real directions of $(D - b, D' - \bar{b})$, computed in double precision. Every operation is repeated on absolute values and carries an operation count $n$, so that the computed coefficient differs from the exact one by at most $\gamma_n = nu/(1 - nu)$, $u = 2^{-53}$, times the absolute-value coefficient [35, Sec. 3.1]. With $C$ in $2^{-30}\mathbb{Z}$, the polynomials $2^{31}q_h$, $X_a(2^{31}q_h)$, $12{\cdot}2^{31}(\varphi_h{+}\Delta q_h)$ and $12 \cdot 2^{31}\langle \nabla\varphi_{F_k}, \nabla q_h\rangle$ for the coordinate vectors $h$ have coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$, and every partial sum in their computation is bounded, through the same operations on absolute values, by less than $2^{50}$; they are therefore computed exactly. Normalisation by $Z$, the products with the corner coordinates, the quadratic forms and their error matrices are formed with the same bookkeeping, and the largest eigenvalues are bounded in ball arithmetic [40].

*Separation.* The functional $c$ of a discarded box is the dual solution of a linear program for the gauge of the centre of the box with respect to a $72 \times 72$ grid of $T$. Only the final inequality is used: $\max_T \ell$ is bounded by its maximum over a $512 \times 512$ grid plus $\frac{1}{2}H\delta^2/2$, with $\delta = 2\pi/512$ and $H = |c_1| + |c_2| + 2|c_3|$ a bound for its Hessian on the torus, and the inequality is checked with relative margin $10^{-12}$.

*Running time.* The moments at one corner take about one and a half seconds and the bound on one box about two and a half seconds on one core. The cover runs in about an hour on four cores and writes every certified box with its $\theta$ and its bound.

## Appendix F. The transfer matrix

This appendix recalls the Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction for the lattice [52, 53, 54] in the form used for the gaps, following our earlier paper [13].

Let $\omega$ be a state on the gauge-invariant local functions of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ that is invariant under translations and the hypercubic group and reflection positive for reflections in planes through sites and in planes bisecting links; by Proposition 3.2(iii)–(iv) and its analogues in the other theorems, the states of this paper are of this kind. The reconstruction gives a Hilbert space with a vector $\Omega$, a map $F \mapsto \Psi_F$ with dense range, and a self-adjoint $\mathbb{T}$ with $0 \le \mathbb{T} \le 1$, $\mathbb{T}\Omega = \Omega$ and $\langle \Psi_F, \mathbb{T}^t \Psi_H\rangle = \omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t H)$, where $\vartheta$ is the time reflection and $\tau_t$ the time translation.[13]

**Proposition F.1.** *For $m > 0$ the following are equivalent:*

(a) *the spectrum of $\mathbb{T}$ on $\Omega^\perp$ lies in $[0, e^{-m}]$;*

(b) *for every $F$ in a class of gauge-invariant local functions supported at times in a bounded interval and dense in $L^2(\omega)$ on each such support, there is $C_F < \infty$ with $0 \le \omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t F) - |\omega(F)|^2 \le C_F e^{-mt}$ for all $t \ge 0$.*

*Under* (a) *one may take $C_F = \|F\|_\infty^2$ for every bounded $F$.*

*Proof.* If (a) holds, then

$$\omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t F) - |\omega(F)|^2 = \langle \Psi'_F, \mathbb{T}^t \Psi'_F\rangle$$

[13] $\Psi_F$ is the class of $F$ in the completion of the positive-time local functions for the form $\langle F, H\rangle = \omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})H)$, which is positive semidefinite by reflection positivity. Since $|\omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})F)| \le \omega(|F|^2)$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality and the invariance of $\omega$ under $\vartheta$, functions that are close in $L^2(\omega)$ give close vectors.

with $\Psi'_F = \Psi_F - \langle \Omega, \Psi_F \rangle \Omega \in \Omega^\perp$; this number lies in $[0, e^{-mt}\|\Psi_F\|^2]$, and $\|\Psi_F\|^2 \le \|F\|_\infty^2$. Conversely, let $\sigma$ be the spectral measure of $\mathbb{T}$ at $\Psi'_F$ and let $\delta > 0$. Then

$$\sigma\big((e^{-m+\delta}, 1]\big) e^{(-m+\delta)t} \le C_F e^{-mt}$$

for all $t$, so $\sigma((e^{-m+\delta}, 1]) = 0$. The spectral projection of $(e^{-m}, 1]$ restricted to $\Omega^\perp$ therefore annihilates the vectors $\Psi'_F$ of the class, which are dense by the footnote above, and it vanishes. □

## Appendix G. The single-link law of SU(2)

This appendix proves the sharp quarter, $W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le \frac{1}{4}|b - b'|$ for the one-link law of SU(2), which Theorems 1.1 and 1.3 use, and the exact value at $b = 0$, which Theorem 1.2 uses. The argument is that of our earlier paper [13]; it is given in full so that the present paper is self-contained.

G.1. **The von Mises–Fisher law.** Identify SU(2) with the unit quaternions, that is with the unit sphere $S^3 \subset \mathbb{R}^4$, so that $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} U = 2x_0(U)$ and $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(UV) = 2\langle u, \bar v\rangle$ for the Euclidean inner product of $\mathbb{R}^4$ and quaternion conjugation $v \mapsto \bar v$. Fix a link $e$ and the field off $e$. Every plaquette through $e$ can be rotated cyclically so that its trace reads $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Q_e A_p)$ with $A_p \in \mathrm{SU}(2)$, the staple of $e$ in $p$. The action therefore depends on $Q_e$ only through

$$N\beta \sum_{p \ni e} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Q_e A_p) = \langle x, b\rangle, \qquad b = 4\beta \sum_{p \ni e} \bar A_p \in \mathbb{R}^4,$$

with $x = Q_e \in S^3$. Since there are six staples, each of norm one,

$$\kappa := |b| \le y := 24|\beta|. \tag{G.1}$$

The conditional law of $Q_e$ is the von Mises–Fisher law[14]

$$\nu_b(dx) = Z(\kappa)^{-1} e^{\langle x, b\rangle}\, \sigma(dx) \tag{G.2}$$

on the unit sphere, with $\sigma$ the normalised surface measure. We use coordinates in which $b = \kappa e_1$. The density of $t = x_1$ is proportional to $(1-t^2)^{1/2} e^{\kappa t}$ on $[-1, 1]$, so $Z(\kappa) = 2I_1(\kappa)/\kappa$ with the modified Bessel function $I_1$, normalised so that $Z(0) = 1$.

**Lemma G.1.** *For every $\kappa \ge 0$ the law $\nu_b$ on the unit sphere $S^3$ satisfies the Poincaré inequality $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_b}(g) \le \frac{1}{3}\int |\nabla g|^2 d\nu_b$, and the constant $\frac{1}{3}$ is attained at $\kappa = 0$.*

*Proof.* In the polar angle $\theta \in (0, \pi)$ from $e_1$ the generator of the reversible diffusion of $\nu_b$ is $L = \partial_\theta^2 + b(\theta)\partial_\theta + \sin^{-2}\theta\, \Delta_{S^2}$ with $b(\theta) = 2\cot\theta - \kappa\sin\theta$. On spherical harmonics of degree $\ell$ on $S^2$ it acts as a Sturm–Liouville operator $L_\ell$ with potential $\ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta$. A ground state comparison of Barta's type [8] with the trial function $\psi = \sin\theta\, e^{a\kappa\cos\theta}$ gives $-L_1\psi \ge 3\psi$ for $a = -\frac{1}{5}$, and the same trial function with $a = -\frac{2}{5}$ gives the bound 3 for the derivatives of zonal eigenfunctions; Appendix H carries out both computations. Hence every nonzero eigenvalue of $-L$ is at least 3. At $\kappa = 0$ the first eigenvalue of the Laplacian of the unit $S^3$ is 3. □

[14] On the sphere $S^{p-1} \subset \mathbb{R}^p$ the von Mises–Fisher law with mean direction $\mu$ and concentration $\kappa$ has density proportional to $e^{\kappa\langle x, \mu\rangle}$ with respect to the surface measure, and its normalising constant is $(2\pi)^{p/2} I_{p/2-1}(\kappa)/\kappa^{p/2-1}$; it is the maximum entropy law with prescribed mean resultant, and it plays on the sphere the role of the Gaussian in $\mathbb{R}^p$. For $p = 4$ the Bessel index is 1. The mean resultant length $\mathbb{E}\langle x, \mu\rangle = I_{p/2}(\kappa)/I_{p/2-1}(\kappa)$ is the function $A$ of Lemma G.2. See Mardia and Jupp [48], Ch. 9, for these facts and for the tangent-normal decomposition used in Appendix H.

G.2. **Moments.** Let $A(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}_{\nu_b} x_1 = Z'(\kappa)/Z(\kappa) = I_2(\kappa)/I_1(\kappa)$.

**Lemma G.2.** *For every $\kappa > 0$, in coordinates with $b = \kappa e_1$,*

(i) $\mathbb{E}x_2^2 = \mathbb{E}x_3^2 = \mathbb{E}x_4^2 = A/\kappa$, $\mathbb{E}(1 - x_1^2) = 3A/\kappa$, *the covariance matrix of $x$ is* $\operatorname{diag}(A', A/\kappa, A/\kappa, A/\kappa)$, *and* $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$;

(ii) $\dfrac{\kappa}{2 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 4}} \le A(\kappa) \le \dfrac{\kappa}{1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9}}$;

(iii) $A' \le A/\kappa \le \big(1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9}\big)^{-1} \le \frac{1}{4}$;

(iv) $A(\kappa) \ge \kappa/\big(\frac{3}{2} + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4}\big)$.

*Proof.* (i) Integrating by parts against $\frac{d}{dt}(1-t^2)^{3/2} = -3t(1-t^2)^{1/2}$ gives $\kappa\,\mathbb{E}(1-x_1^2) = 3\mathbb{E}x_1$, and the three coordinates $x_2, x_3, x_4$ are exchangeable under $\nu_b$, with $\sum_i x_i^2 = 1$. The off-diagonal covariances vanish by the reflections $x_i \mapsto -x_i$, $i \ge 2$, and $A' = \operatorname{Var} x_1$ because $A = (\log Z)'$. (ii) By (i), $A$ solves the Riccati equation $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$ with $A(\kappa) = \kappa/4 + O(\kappa^3)$. Appendix H shows that the left side of (ii) is a subsolution and the right side a supersolution of this equation, with the same behaviour at 0, and concludes by comparison. (iii) The middle inequality is (ii). For the first, put $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 4}$. By (ii), $4A/\kappa \ge 4/(2+s)$ and $1 - A^2 \le 1 - \kappa^2/(2+s)^2$, and

$$1 - \frac{\kappa^2}{(2+s)^2} \le \frac{4}{2+s} \iff (2+s)^2 - \kappa^2 \le 4(2+s)$$
$$\iff s^2 - \kappa^2 \le 4,$$

which holds with equality. So $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa \le A/\kappa$. (iv) is the comparison of (ii) with a third barrier, which improves the lower bound of (ii); it is carried out in the same appendix. □

G.3. **The Lipschitz rate of the family.** Let $\delta$ be the chordal metric $\delta(x, x') = |x - x'|$ on $S^3$ and $W_1$ the Kantorovich distance for $\delta$. For $c \in \mathbb{R}^4$ and a unit vector $h \in \mathbb{R}^4$ put

$$L(c, h) = \sup_g \operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_c}\big(g, \langle h, x\rangle\big), \tag{G.3}$$

the supremum over 1-Lipschitz functions $g$ for $\delta$. Since $\frac{d}{dt}\nu_{c+th}(g) = \operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_{c+th}}(g, \langle h, x\rangle)$, the Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality gives, for all $b, b'$,

$$W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le |b - b'| \sup_{c \in [b, b']} L\Big(c, \frac{b' - b}{|b' - b|}\Big). \tag{G.4}$$

By rotation invariance $L(c, h)$ depends only on $\kappa = |c|$ and on the angle $\varphi$ between $h$ and $c^\perp$, and we write $L(\kappa, \varphi)$.

**Lemma G.3.** *For all $c$ and $h$, $L(c, h) \le 1/(2\sqrt{3})$. Moreover:*

(i) *at $c = 0$, $L(0, h) = \frac{1}{4}$ for every $h$;*

(ii) *if $h \perp c$, then $L(c, h) = \mathbb{E}_{\nu_c} x_2^2 = A(\kappa)/\kappa \le \frac{1}{4}$;*

(iii) *if $\kappa \ge \sqrt{88}/3 \approx 3.127$, then $L(c, h) \le \frac{1}{4}$ for every $h$.*

*Proof.* A 1-Lipschitz function for $\delta$ is 1-Lipschitz for the geodesic distance, which is larger, so $|\nabla g| \le 1$ almost everywhere, and Lemma G.1 gives $\operatorname{Var} g \le \frac{1}{3}$. By Lemma G.2(i), (iii) the largest eigenvalue of the covariance of $x$ is $A/\kappa \le \frac{1}{4}$, so $\operatorname{Var}\langle h, x\rangle \le A/\kappa$. The Cauchy–Schwarz inequality gives

$$L(c, h) \le \big(\tfrac{1}{3}A/\kappa\big)^{1/2} \le \Big(3\big(1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9}\big)\Big)^{-1/2} \le \frac{1}{2\sqrt{3}}. \tag{G.5}$$

(i) and (ii) are reflection arguments. Let $R$ be the reflection in the hyperplane $h^\perp$, and suppose $\nu_c$ is $R$-invariant, which is the case when $c = 0$ or $h \perp c$. Then $\mathbb{E}\langle h, x\rangle = 0$ and

$$\operatorname{Cov}(g, \langle h, x\rangle) = \mathbb{E}\big[(g(x) - g(Rx))\langle h, x\rangle;\ \langle h, x\rangle > 0\big]$$
$$\le \mathbb{E}\big[2\langle h, x\rangle^2;\ \langle h, x\rangle > 0\big] = \mathbb{E}\langle h, x\rangle^2,$$

since $\delta(x,Rx)=2|\langle h,x\rangle|$. Equality holds for $g=\langle h,x\rangle$, which is 1-Lipschitz. At $c=0$, $\mathbb{E}\langle h,x\rangle^2=\frac14$; for $h\perp c$, $\mathbb{E}\langle h,x\rangle^2=A/\kappa$. (iii) By (G.5), $L\le\frac14$ as soon as $1+\sqrt{\kappa^2+9}\ge\frac{16}{3}$, that is $\kappa^2\ge\frac{88}{9}$. □

The reflection settles the directions $h\perp c$ and the point $c=0$; for an oblique $h$ the reflection no longer preserves $\nu_c$, and the Cauchy–Schwarz bound (G.5) is too weak for $\kappa<\sqrt{88}/3$. The next theorem closes this case.

**Theorem G.4** (The sharp quarter)**.** *For every $c\in\mathbb{R}^4$ and every unit vector $h\in\mathbb{R}^4$,*

$$L(c,h)\le\tfrac14,$$

*with equality at $c=0$. Equivalently, $W_1(\nu_b,\nu_{b'})\le\frac14|b-b'|$ for all $b,b'\in\mathbb{R}^4$, and the constant $\frac14$ is the best possible.*

The equivalence is (G.4) in one direction and the derivative formula above it in the other; the sharpness is Lemma G.3(i). The metric matters.[15] The proof has four steps. A Lipschitz function on $S^3$ extends to the unit ball $B\subset\mathbb{R}^4$, and Green's formula in $B$ bounds the covariance by a negative Sobolev norm of the density (Lemma G.5). This norm splits into a zonal and a transverse part, both explicit series in modified Bessel functions (Lemma G.6). The transverse part is at most $\frac14$ because a certain power series has nonnegative coefficients (Proposition G.8), and the zonal part is at most $\frac14$ by a Riccati comparison (Proposition G.9).

G.4. **Harmonic extension.** Let $\sigma$ be the normalised surface measure of $S^3$ and $H_k$ the space of spherical harmonics of degree $k$, the restrictions to $S^3$ of harmonic homogeneous polynomials of degree $k$ on $\mathbb{R}^4$. The spaces $H_k$ are orthogonal in $L^2(\sigma)$ and span it; we write $u_k$ for the component of $u$ in $H_k$, and for $u$ with $\int u\,d\sigma=0$ we put

$$\mathcal{Q}(u)=\sum_{k\ge1}\frac1k\,\|u_k\|^2_{L^2(\sigma)}. \tag{G.6}$$

This is $\langle u,\Lambda^{-1}u\rangle$ for the Dirichlet-to-Neumann operator $\Lambda$ of $B$, which acts on $H_k$ as multiplication by $k$.

**Lemma G.5.** *Let $u$ be a real-analytic function on $S^3$ with $\int u\,d\sigma=0$ and let $g$ be 1-Lipschitz for the chordal metric. Then*

$$\int_{S^3} g\,u\,d\sigma\le\tfrac12\,\mathcal{Q}(u)^{1/2}.$$

*Proof.* The chordal metric is the Euclidean metric of $\mathbb{R}^4$ restricted to $S^3$, so McShane's extension $G(y)=\inf_{x\in S^3}(g(x)+|x-y|)$ is 1-Lipschitz on $\mathbb{R}^4$ and equals $g$ on $S^3$ [49]; by Rademacher's theorem $|\nabla G|\le1$ almost everywhere. Let $\psi=\sum_{k\ge1}k^{-1}r^k u_k(\omega)$ in polar coordinates $y=r\omega$. Each term is a harmonic polynomial, the series converges with all derivatives on the closed ball because $u$ is real-analytic,[16] and $\partial_r\psi=u$ on $S^3$. Green's formula for the Lipschitz function $G$ and the smooth harmonic function $\psi$ reads $\int_{S^3}G\,\partial_r\psi\,dS=\int_B\nabla G\cdot\nabla\psi\,dy$. With $|S^3|=2\pi^2$ and $|B|=\pi^2/2$ the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality gives

$$\int g\,u\,d\sigma=\frac{1}{2\pi^2}\int_B\nabla G\cdot\nabla\psi\,dy\le\frac{|B|^{1/2}}{2\pi^2}\Big(\int_B|\nabla\psi|^2dy\Big)^{1/2}.$$

[15] In the geodesic metric of $S^3$ the statement is false already at $c=0$: the function $\arcsin x_2$ is geodesically 1-Lipschitz and its covariance with $x_2$ under the uniform law is $\frac{8}{9\pi}\approx0.283>\frac14$. A proof therefore has to use that the chordal distance between two points is shorter than their geodesic distance, that is, it has to see the sphere from the ball it bounds. The proof below does exactly this: it extends a chordally Lipschitz function to the ball and integrates by parts there.

[16] For real-analytic $u$ the norms $\|u_k\|$ decay geometrically in $k$, and the supremum of a function in $H_k$ is at most $(\dim H_k)^{1/2}=k+1$ times its $L^2(\sigma)$ norm, so the series for $\psi$ and for each of its derivatives converge uniformly on $\bar B$.

Green's formula once more gives $\int_B |\nabla\psi|^2 = \int_{S^3} \psi\, \partial_r\psi\, dS = 2\pi^2 \sum_k k^{-1}\|u_k\|^2 = 2\pi^2 \mathcal{Q}(u)$, and the right side becomes $\frac{1}{2}\mathcal{Q}(u)^{1/2}$. □

The lemma is a form of Thomson's principle. By Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality, $\sup_g \int gu\, d\sigma$ is the least cost of a flow in $\mathbb{R}^4$ that carries the positive part of $u\, d\sigma$ to its negative part, the cost being the total length travelled by the mass.[17] The harmonic field $\nabla\psi$ is one such flow, through the interior of the ball, and the lemma computes its cost. At $c = 0$ the flow is optimal: for $u = \langle h, x\rangle$ one has $\psi = \langle h, y\rangle$, the field $\nabla\psi = h$ is constant, the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality is an equality, and $\mathcal{Q}(u) = \|u\|^2 = \frac{1}{4}$.

G.5. **Spectral decomposition.** Fix $c = \kappa e_1$ with $\kappa > 0$ and write $h = \cos\varphi\, e_1 + \sin\varphi\, e_2$, which is no loss of generality by rotation invariance. Let $\rho = d\nu_c/d\sigma = e^{\kappa x_1}/Z(\kappa)$, $Z(\kappa) = \int e^{\kappa x_1} d\sigma = 2I_1(\kappa)/\kappa$, and

$$u = \big(\langle h, x\rangle - \mathbb{E}_{\nu_c}\langle h, x\rangle\big)\rho,$$

so that $\mathrm{Cov}_{\nu_c}(g, \langle h, x\rangle) = \int gu\, d\sigma$ and $\int u\, d\sigma = 0$. Let $U_n$ be the Chebyshev polynomials of the second kind and put

$$d_n(\kappa) = \frac{(n+1)\, I_{n+1}(\kappa)}{I_1(\kappa)}, \qquad n \geq 0. \tag{G.7}$$

**Lemma G.6.** *With this notation*

$$\mathcal{Q}(u) = \cos^2\varphi\, \mathcal{Q}_z(\kappa) + \sin^2\varphi\, \mathcal{Q}_x(\kappa),$$

*where*

$$\mathcal{Q}_z = \sum_{n\geq 1} \frac{d_n'(\kappa)^2}{n}, \qquad \mathcal{Q}_x = \frac{1}{3\kappa^2} \sum_{n\geq 1} (n+2)\, d_n(\kappa)^2.$$

*Proof.* The functions $U_n(x_1)$, $n \geq 0$, are the zonal harmonics: $U_n(x_1) \in H_n$, and they are orthonormal in $L^2(\sigma)$ (Appendix I). The expansion $e^{\kappa t} = \frac{2}{\kappa}\sum_n (n+1) I_{n+1}(\kappa) U_n(t)$ of the same appendix gives $\rho = \sum_n d_n(\kappa) U_n(x_1)$, with $d_0 = 1$.

Write $u = \cos\varphi\, u_z + \sin\varphi\, u_x$ with $u_z = (x_1 - A)\rho$ and $u_x = x_2\rho$; here $\mathbb{E}_{\nu_c} x_1 = A$ and $\mathbb{E}_{\nu_c} x_2 = 0$. The reflection $x_2 \mapsto -x_2$ maps each $H_k$ to itself, fixes $u_z$ and reverses $u_x$, so the components of $u_z$ and $u_x$ in each $H_k$ are orthogonal and the cross term in $\mathcal{Q}(u)$ vanishes.

Since $A = Z'/Z$, we have $u_z = \partial_\kappa \rho = \sum_n d_n'(\kappa) U_n(x_1)$, and the component of $u_z$ in $H_n$ is $d_n' U_n(x_1)$, of norm $|d_n'|$. This gives $\mathcal{Q}_z$.

For $u_x$, let $y(t) = \cos t\, e_1 + \sin t\, e_2$. The law $\nu_{\kappa y(t)}$ has density $\rho_t = e^{\kappa\langle y(t), x\rangle}/Z(\kappa) = \sum_n d_n(\kappa) U_n(\langle y(t), x\rangle)$, and $\partial_t \rho_t|_{t=0} = \kappa x_2 \rho$. The function $U_n(\langle y(t), x\rangle)$ lies in $H_n$ for every $t$, hence so does its derivative $x_2 U_n'(x_1)$ at $t = 0$, and the component of $u_x$ in $H_n$ is $\kappa^{-1} d_n x_2 U_n'(x_1)$. Its norm follows from the eigenvalue $n(n+2)$ of the Laplacian of $S^3$ on $H_n$. For $f = U_n(x_1)$,

$$\begin{aligned} n(n+2) = n(n+2)\|f\|^2 &= \int |\nabla_{S^3} f|^2 d\sigma \\ &= \int U_n'(x_1)^2 (1 - x_1^2)\, d\sigma, \end{aligned}$$

since the tangential gradient of $x_1$ has squared length $1 - x_1^2$. Given $x_1$, the point $(x_2, x_3, x_4)$ is uniform on the sphere of radius $(1 - x_1^2)^{1/2}$, so $\mathbb{E}[x_2^2 \mid x_1] = \frac{1}{3}(1 - x_1^2)$ and $\|x_2 U_n'(x_1)\|^2 = \frac{1}{3} n(n+2)$. Summing $n^{-1}\kappa^{-2} d_n^2 \cdot \frac{1}{3} n(n+2)$ over $n \geq 1$ gives $\mathcal{Q}_x$. □

[17] This is the Beckmann formulation of the transport problem with cost $|x - y|$: the optimal cost equals the least $\int |V|$ over vector measures $V$ on $\mathbb{R}^4$ with divergence $u\, d\sigma$. Restricting the flow to the closed ball does not change the infimum, since projecting onto $\bar{B}$ shortens paths. The gradient $\nabla\psi$ on $B$ is one admissible flow. It minimises the energy $\int |V|^2$ rather than the cost $\int |V|$, and the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality converts one into the other at the price of the factor $|B|^{1/2}$.

By Lemmas G.5 and G.6,

$$L(\kappa,\varphi) \le \tfrac{1}{2}\max\big(\mathcal{Q}_z(\kappa),\mathcal{Q}_x(\kappa)\big)^{1/2}, \tag{G.8}$$

and Theorem G.4 follows once both parts are at most $\frac{1}{4}$. Both are $\frac{1}{4}$ at $\kappa = 0$, by continuity from the values $d_1 \sim \kappa/2$, $d_1' \to \frac{1}{2}$ and $d_n = O(\kappa^n)$.

G.6. **Three Bessel sums.** The series of Lemma G.6 reduce to closed forms. Write $I_j$ for $I_j(\kappa)$.

**Lemma G.7.** *For every $\kappa > 0$,*

$$\sum_{j\ge1} j^2 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa}{4}\, I_1(2\kappa), \qquad \sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}(I_0^2 + I_1^2),$$
$$I_1(2\kappa) = 2\sum_{j\ge1} I_{j-1} I_j.$$

The first and third identities follow from Parseval's formula for $e^{\kappa\cos\theta} = \sum_{j\in\mathbb{Z}} I_j e^{ij\theta}$, and the second from the recurrences of $I_j$ by telescoping; Appendix I gives the proofs.

G.7. **The transverse part.**

**Proposition G.8.** *$\mathcal{Q}_x(\kappa) \le \frac{1}{4}$ for every $\kappa \ge 0$.*

*Proof.* By (G.7), $\mathcal{Q}_x = (3\kappa^2 I_1^2)^{-1}\sum_{j\ge2} j^2(j+1)I_j^2$, and the sum equals $\sum_{j\ge1}(j^3+j^2)I_j^2 - 2I_1^2$. By Lemma G.7, $\mathcal{Q}_x \le \frac{1}{4}$ is equivalent to

$$\mathcal{D}(\kappa) := (8+2\kappa^2)I_1^2 - \kappa^2 I_0^2 - \kappa I_1(2\kappa) \ge 0. \tag{G.9}$$

Each term is an entire function of $\kappa$ that is even after the factor $\kappa^2$ is removed, so $\mathcal{D}(\kappa) = \sum_{n\ge0}\mathcal{D}_n\kappa^{2n}$. Lemma I.2 of Appendix I computes the coefficients: $\mathcal{D}_0 = \mathcal{D}_1 = 0$, and for $n = m+1 \ge 2$

$$\mathcal{D}_n = \frac{N_m}{4^m\, m!\,(m+1)!\,(m+1)(m+2)},$$

with

$$N_m = \binom{2m}{m}\big(4(2m+1) + (m-1)(m+1)(m+2)\big) - 4^m(m+1)(m+2).$$

The numerator $N_m$ vanishes for $m = 0, 1, 2$ and is positive for $m \ge 3$ (Lemma I.2). So every coefficient of $\mathcal{D}$ is nonnegative and $\mathcal{D} \ge 0$. □

The first nonzero coefficient is $\mathcal{D}_4 = \frac{1}{2304}$, so $\frac{1}{4} - \mathcal{Q}_x = \mathcal{D}/(12\kappa^2 I_1^2)$ is of order $\kappa^4$ at 0: the transverse part leaves the value $\frac{1}{4}$ very slowly, which is why no estimate that loses a constant can prove the proposition.

G.8. **The zonal part.** Let $A = I_2/I_1$ as before, so that $d_1 = 2A$ and, by Lemma G.2(i), $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$.

**Proposition G.9.** *For $0 < \kappa \le \sqrt{88}/3$,*

$$\mathcal{Q}_z(\kappa) \le \frac{1}{4} + 4A'^2 + \frac{A^2}{4} - \frac{A}{2\kappa} - \frac{2A^2}{\kappa^2} < \frac{1}{4}.$$

*Proof. The higher modes.* With $r_\nu = I_{\nu+1}/I_\nu$ the recurrence $I_\nu' = I_{\nu+1} + \frac{\nu}{\kappa} I_\nu$ gives

$$\frac{d_n'}{d_n} = \frac{I_{n+1}'}{I_{n+1}} - \frac{I_1'}{I_1} = \frac{n}{\kappa} + r_{n+1} - r_1.$$

By Lemma I.3 of Appendix I, $r_{n+1} \le r_1$, and $r_1 = A \le \kappa/4$ by Lemma G.2(iii). Hence $-n/\kappa \le n/\kappa - \kappa/4 \le d_n'/d_n \le n/\kappa$ for $n \ge 2$ and $\kappa^2 \le 16$, so $d_n'^2 \le n^2 d_n^2/\kappa^2$. With $d_1' = 2A'$,

$$\mathcal{Q}_z \le 4A'^2 + \frac{1}{\kappa^2}\sum_{n\ge 2} n\, d_n^2 = 4A'^2 + \frac{S_3 - S_2 - 4I_2^2}{\kappa^2 I_1^2},$$

where $S_2 = \sum_{j\ge1} j^2 I_j^2$ and $S_3 = \sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2$; the second form uses $n\, d_n^2 I_1^2 = (j-1)j^2 I_j^2$ with $j = n+1$.

*The closed form.* The recurrences $I_0 - I_2 = \frac{2}{\kappa} I_1$ and $I_1 - I_3 = \frac{4}{\kappa} I_2$ give $I_0/I_1 = 2/\kappa + A$ and $I_2 I_3/I_1^2 = A - 4A^2/\kappa$. By Lemma G.7, $S_3/(\kappa^2 I_1^2) = \frac{1}{4}(2/\kappa + A)^2 + \frac{1}{4}$, and, keeping three terms of the third identity,

$$\frac{S_2}{\kappa^2 I_1^2} \ge \frac{I_0 I_1 + I_1 I_2 + I_2 I_3}{2\kappa I_1^2} = \frac{1}{2\kappa}\Big(\frac{2}{\kappa} + 3A - \frac{4A^2}{\kappa}\Big).$$

Collecting terms, $\mathcal{Q}_z \le \frac{1}{4} + 4A'^2 + T(A)$ with $T(a) = \frac{a^2}{4} - \frac{a}{2\kappa} - \frac{2a^2}{\kappa^2}$, which is the first inequality.

*The barrier.* Let $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4}$ and $A_\flat = \kappa/(\frac{3}{2} + s)$. By Lemma G.2(iv), $A_\flat \le A \le \kappa/4$. The function $a \mapsto 1 - a^2 - 3a/\kappa$ decreases on $a \ge 0$, and $A' \ge 0$ because $A' = \operatorname{Var} x_1$, so $0 \le A' \le \alpha := 1 - A_\flat^2 - 3A_\flat/\kappa$. For $\kappa^2 \le 12$ the quadratic $T$ decreases on $[0, \kappa/4]$, since

$$T(a) - T(a') = (a' - a)\,\frac{2\kappa - (a + a')(\kappa^2 - 8)}{4\kappa^2}$$

and $(a + a')(\kappa^2 - 8) \le \frac{\kappa}{2}(\kappa^2 - 8) \le 2\kappa$ there. So $\mathcal{Q}_z \le \frac{1}{4} + 4\alpha^2 + T(A_\flat)$. With $\kappa^2 = s^2 - \frac{25}{4}$ and $A_\flat/\kappa = 2/(2s+3)$ both terms are rational in $s$: $\alpha = 16/(2s+3)^2$, and

$$4\alpha^2 + T(A_\flat) = \frac{(2s-5)\,p(s)}{4(2s+3)^4}, \qquad p(s) = 8s^3 + 28s^2 - 98s - 695. \tag{G.10}$$

For $0 < \kappa \le \sqrt{88}/3$ we have $\frac{5}{2} < s \le \sqrt{577}/6 < 4.004$. On $s \ge \frac{5}{2}$ the cubic $p$ increases, since $p'(s) = 24s^2 + 56s - 98 > 0$, and $p(4.004) < -120$. So the right side of (G.10) is negative. □

G.9. **Proof of Theorem G.4.** At $c = 0$ the theorem is Lemma G.3(i), and for $|c| \ge \sqrt{88}/3$ it is Lemma G.3(iii). For $0 < |c| < \sqrt{88}/3$, Propositions G.8 and G.9 give $\mathcal{Q}_x, \mathcal{Q}_z \le \frac{1}{4}$, and (G.8) gives $L \le \frac{1}{4}$. □

## Appendix H. Computations for the single-link law

H.1. **Barta's inequality.** Let $\rho(\theta) = \sin^2\theta\, e^{\kappa\cos\theta}$ on $(0,\pi)$, let $V$ be a continuous potential, and let

$$T = -\rho^{-1}\partial_\theta\, \rho\, \partial_\theta + V.$$

If $\psi > 0$ is smooth on $(0,\pi)$ with $\rho\psi^2 = O(\sin^4\theta)$ at the end points and $T\psi \ge \lambda_0\psi$, then

$$\int (|h'|^2 + Vh^2)\rho\, d\theta \ge \lambda_0 \int h^2 \rho\, d\theta$$

for every smooth $h$ vanishing to first order at 0 and $\pi$. Indeed, writing $h = \psi u$ and integrating by parts, the boundary terms $\rho\psi\psi' u^2$ vanish and

$$\int (|h'|^2 + Vh^2)\rho = \int \rho\psi^2 |u'|^2 + \int \frac{T\psi}{\psi}\, h^2\rho \;\ge\; \lambda_0 \int h^2\rho.$$

This is the inequality of Barta [8] in the form of a ground state transformation.

H.2. **The computations of Lemma G.1.** The generator of the reversible diffusion of $\nu_b$ on $S^3$ is $L = \Delta_{S^3} + \kappa \nabla x_1 \cdot \nabla$. In the polar angle $\theta$ from $e_1$ the round metric is $d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\, g_{S^2}$, so $\Delta_{S^3} = \partial_\theta^2 + 2\cot\theta\,\partial_\theta + \sin^{-2}\theta\,\Delta_{S^2}$, and $\nabla x_1 \cdot \nabla = -\sin\theta\,\partial_\theta$. On $h(\theta)Y_\ell$ with a spherical harmonic $Y_\ell$ of degree $\ell$ on $S^2$ the operator acts as $L_\ell = \partial_\theta^2 + b\,\partial_\theta - \ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta$, $b = 2\cot\theta - \kappa\sin\theta = \rho'/\rho$, so $-L_\ell = T$ with $V = \ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta$.

*Degree* $\ell \geq 1$. Take $\psi = \sin\theta\, e^{a\kappa\cos\theta}$. Then $\psi'/\psi = \cot\theta - a\kappa\sin\theta$ and $\psi''/\psi = (\psi'/\psi)^2 + (\psi'/\psi)'$, and a short computation gives

$$\frac{-L_1\psi}{\psi} = 3 + (1+5a)\kappa\cos\theta - a(1+a)\kappa^2\sin^2\theta.$$

For $a = -\frac{1}{5}$ this is $3 + \frac{4}{25}\kappa^2\sin^2\theta \geq 3$. Since $V = \ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta \geq 2\sin^{-2}\theta$ for $\ell \geq 1$, Barta's inequality gives $-L_\ell \geq 3$ on every sector with $\ell \geq 1$.

*Degree* $\ell = 0$. Let $g(\theta)$ be a zonal eigenfunction, $-L_0 g = \lambda g$, $g$ not constant, so that $g'(0) = g'(\pi) = 0$. Differentiating $g'' + bg' = -\lambda g$ gives, for $h = g'$,

$$-(h'' + bh') - b'h = \lambda h, \qquad -b' = \frac{2}{\sin^2\theta} + \kappa\cos\theta,$$

so $h$ is an eigenfunction of $T$ with $V = 2\sin^{-2}\theta + \kappa\cos\theta$, with eigenvalue $\lambda$, and $h \not\equiv 0$ vanishes at both ends. With the same $\psi$,

$$\frac{T\psi}{\psi} = 3 + (2+5a)\kappa\cos\theta - a(1+a)\kappa^2\sin^2\theta,$$

which for $a = -\frac{2}{5}$ is $3 + \frac{6}{25}\kappa^2\sin^2\theta \geq 3$. Barta's inequality applied to $h$ gives $\lambda \geq 3$. Together with the case $\ell \geq 1$ every nonzero eigenvalue of $-L$ is at least 3, which is Lemma G.1; the spectrum is discrete because $S^3$ is compact and the drift is smooth.

H.3. **Moments.** The density of $t = x_1$ under $\nu_b$ is proportional to $(1-t^2)^{1/2}e^{\kappa t}$. For every smooth $\phi$ on $[-1,1]$,

$$\frac{d}{dt}\Big[(1-t^2)^{3/2}e^{\kappa t}\Big] = (1-t^2)^{1/2}e^{\kappa t}(\kappa(1-t^2) - 3t),$$

and integration by parts gives $\mathbb{E}[\phi'(t)(1-t^2)] = \mathbb{E}\big[\phi(t)\big(3t - \kappa(1-t^2)\big)\big]$. With $\phi = 1$ this is $\kappa\mathbb{E}(1-x_1^2) = 3\mathbb{E}x_1$, the identity of Lemma G.2(i). With $\phi = t^k$ it gives the recursion

$$m_{k+2} = m_k - \frac{k+3}{\kappa}\,m_{k+1} + \frac{k}{\kappa}\,m_{k-1}, \qquad m_k = \mathbb{E}x_1^k,$$

from $m_0 = 1$ and $m_1 = A$; all polynomial moments of $\nu_b$ are rational in $\kappa$ and $A(\kappa)$.[18]

H.4. **The Riccati barriers.** By Lemma G.2(i), $A$ solves $A' = \mathcal{F}(\kappa, A) := 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$ on $(0,\infty)$, and $A(\kappa) = \frac{\kappa}{4} - \frac{\kappa^3}{96} + O(\kappa^5)$ from the series of $I_1$ and $I_2$. Let $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2+4}$, $u = \sqrt{\kappa^2+9}$, $\phi_- = \kappa/(2+s)$ and $\phi_+ = \kappa/(1+u)$. Direct differentiation gives

$$\phi_-' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa,\phi_-) = -\frac{\kappa^2}{s(s+2)^2} \leq 0,$$

$$\phi_+' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa,\phi_+) = \frac{(u-3)^2}{u(1+u)^2} \geq 0,$$

[18]For instance $m_2 = 1 - 3A/\kappa$, $m_3 = A - 3/\kappa + 12A/\kappa^2$ and $m_4 = m_2 - 5m_3/\kappa + 2A/\kappa$. The joint moments with $x_2, x_3, x_4$ follow from exchangeability: $\mathbb{E}[\phi(x_1)x_2^2] = \frac{1}{3}\mathbb{E}[\phi(x_1)(1-x_1^2)]$.

and $\phi_\pm = \frac{\kappa}{4} + O(\kappa^3)$.[19] The comparison is singular at 0 because of the term $3A/\kappa$, and we carry it out with an integrating factor. Let $D = A - \phi_-$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} D' &= \mathcal{F}(\kappa, A) - \mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_-) - (\phi_-' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_-)) \\ &= -\Big(A + \phi_- + \frac{3}{\kappa}\Big) D + R, \end{aligned}$$

with $R = \kappa^2/(s(s+2)^2) \geq 0$. Put $\mu(\kappa) = \kappa^3 \exp \int_0^\kappa (A + \phi_-)$. Then $(\mu D)' = \mu R \geq 0$, and $\mu D = O(\kappa^6) \to 0$ as $\kappa \to 0$, so $\mu D \geq 0$ and $A \geq \phi_-$. The same argument with $D = \phi_+ - A$ and $R = (u-3)^2/(u(1+u)^2)$ gives $A \leq \phi_+$. This is Lemma G.2(ii).

For (iv) let $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4}$ and $\phi_\flat = \kappa/(\frac{3}{2} + s)$. Since $s^2 - \frac{9}{4} = \kappa^2 + 4$, the same differentiation gives

$$\phi_\flat' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_\flat) = -\frac{5\,(s - \frac{5}{2})}{2\,s\,(\frac{3}{2} + s)^2} \leq 0,$$

so $\phi_\flat$ is a subsolution, and $\phi_\flat = \frac{\kappa}{4} - \frac{\kappa^3}{80} + O(\kappa^5)$.[20] Hence $A - \phi_\flat = \frac{\kappa^3}{480} + O(\kappa^5)$, and the integrating-factor argument above, with $D = A - \phi_\flat$, $R = \frac{5(s-5/2)}{2s(3/2+s)^2} \geq 0$ and $\mu = \kappa^3 \exp \int_0^\kappa (A + \phi_\flat)$, gives $\mu D = O(\kappa^6)$ at 0, $(\mu D)' = \mu R \geq 0$, and so $A \geq \phi_\flat$. Since $\frac{3}{2} + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4} < 2 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 4}$ for $\kappa > 0$, this improves the lower bound of (ii).

## Appendix I. Bessel functions

This appendix proves the auxiliary statements used in Appendix G for Theorem G.4. Throughout, $I_j = I_j(\kappa)$ with $\kappa > 0$, and $I_{-j} = I_j$ for integers $j$. We use the series

$$I_\nu(\kappa) = \sum_{i \geq 0} \frac{(\kappa/2)^{2i+\nu}}{i!\,(i+\nu)!},$$

the integral $I_j(\kappa) = \pi^{-1} \int_0^\pi e^{\kappa \cos\theta} \cos j\theta \, d\theta$, the Fourier series $e^{\kappa\cos\theta} = \sum_{j \in \mathbb{Z}} I_j e^{ij\theta}$ and the recurrences

$$I_{j-1} - I_{j+1} = \frac{2j}{\kappa} I_j, \quad I_j' = I_{j+1} + \frac{j}{\kappa} I_j, \tag{I.1}$$

all of which are in Watson's treatise [65], §§3.7, 3.71, 2.22. All series below converge absolutely, because $0 < I_j \leq (\kappa/2)^j e^\kappa / j!$.

I.1. **Zonal harmonics.** Under $\sigma$ the coordinate $x_1$ has the density $\frac{2}{\pi}(1-t^2)^{1/2}$ on $[-1,1]$, the area of the two-sphere $\{x_1 = t\}$ being proportional to $1 - t^2$ and its normal speed to $(1-t^2)^{-1/2}$. The Chebyshev polynomials $U_n(\cos\theta) = \sin((n+1)\theta)/\sin\theta$ satisfy

$$\int U_n U_m \, d\sigma = \frac{2}{\pi} \int_0^\pi \sin((n+1)\theta) \sin((m+1)\theta)\, d\theta = \delta_{nm},$$

and $U_n = C_n^{(1)}$ is the Gegenbauer polynomial of index $\frac{4-2}{2} = 1$, so $U_n(\langle y, x\rangle)$ is the zonal harmonic of degree $n$ on $S^3$ with pole $y$: $|x|^n U_n(\langle y, x\rangle/|x|)$ is a harmonic polynomial on $\mathbb{R}^4$ [61], Ch. IV, §2.

**Lemma I.1.** *$e^{\kappa t} = \frac{2}{\kappa} \sum_{n \geq 0} (n+1) I_{n+1}(\kappa)\, U_n(t)$ in $L^2(\frac{2}{\pi}(1-t^2)^{1/2} dt)$, and uniformly on $[-1,1]$.*

[19] For the first identity write $\phi_- = (s-2)/\kappa$, which follows from $s^2 - 4 = \kappa^2$; then $\phi_-' = (\kappa^2/s - s + 2)/\kappa^2$ and $1 - \phi_-^2 - 3\phi_-/\kappa = (\kappa^2 - (s-2)^2 - 3(s-2))/\kappa^2$, and the difference simplifies with $s^2 = \kappa^2 + 4$. The second is the same computation with $\phi_+ = \kappa(u-1)/(u^2-1) = \kappa(u-1)/(\kappa^2+8)$ in place of $\phi_-$ and $u^2 = \kappa^2 + 9$ in place of $s^2 = \kappa^2 + 4$. After clearing the denominator $\kappa^2(1+u)^2$ the numerator becomes $\kappa^2(u-3)^2/u$, which is the stated residual.

[20] With $\phi_\flat = \kappa(s - \frac{3}{2})/(\kappa^2 + 4)$ one has $\phi_\flat' = (\frac{3}{2}s + \frac{25}{4})/(s(\frac{3}{2}+s)^2)$, using $ds/d\kappa = \kappa/s$; and $\mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_\flat) = 1 - \phi_\flat^2 - 3/(\frac{3}{2}+s)$. Clearing the denominator $s(\frac{3}{2}+s)^2$ and replacing $\kappa^2$ by $s^2 - \frac{25}{4}$ leaves $-\frac{5}{2}s + \frac{25}{4}$ in the numerator, which is the stated residual. The expansion follows from $s = \frac{5}{2} + \frac{\kappa^2}{5} + O(\kappa^4)$.

*Proof.* With $t = \cos\theta$ and $2\sin\theta\sin((n+1)\theta) = \cos n\theta - \cos(n+2)\theta$, the $n$-th coefficient is

$$\frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^\pi e^{\kappa\cos\theta}\sin((n+1)\theta)\sin\theta\,d\theta = I_n - I_{n+2} = \frac{2(n+1)}{\kappa}I_{n+1},$$

by (I.1). Since $|U_n| \le n+1$ and $I_{n+1}$ decays factorially, the series converges uniformly. □

I.2. **Proof of Lemma G.7.** Let $F(\theta) = e^{\kappa\cos\theta} = \sum_j I_j e^{ij\theta}$. Then

$$F'(\theta) = -\kappa\sin\theta\,F(\theta) = \sum_j ijI_j e^{ij\theta},$$

and Parseval's formula gives

$$\sum_{j\in\mathbb{Z}} j^2 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{2\pi}\int_0^{2\pi}\sin^2\theta\,e^{2\kappa\cos\theta}d\theta = \frac{\kappa^2}{2}(I_0(2\kappa) - I_2(2\kappa)) = \frac{\kappa}{2}I_1(2\kappa),$$

the last step by (I.1) at the argument $2\kappa$. Halving gives the first identity. The coefficient of $e^{i\theta}$ in $F^2 = e^{2\kappa\cos\theta}$ is $I_1(2\kappa) = \sum_{j\in\mathbb{Z}} I_j I_{1-j}$, and the terms with $j \le 0$ repeat those with $j \ge 1$; this is the third identity.

For the second, $jI_j = \frac{\kappa}{2}(I_{j-1} - I_{j+1})$ by (I.1), so

$$\sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}\sum_{j\ge1} j(I_{j-1}^2 + I_{j+1}^2 - 2I_{j-1}I_{j+1}).$$

Shifting indices and telescoping,

$$\textstyle\sum_{j\ge1} j(I_{j-1}^2 + I_{j+1}^2) = I_0^2 + \sum_{m\ge1} 2mI_m^2,$$
$$\textstyle\sum_{m\ge1} 2mI_m^2 = \kappa\sum_{m\ge1}(I_{m-1}I_m - I_mI_{m+1}) = \kappa I_0 I_1.$$

For the mixed term write $j = \frac{1}{2}((j-1)+(j+1))$ and apply (I.1) to $(j-1)I_{j-1}$ and to $(j+1)I_{j+1}$, using $I_{-1} = I_1$ at $j = 1$:

$$jI_{j-1}I_{j+1} = \frac{\kappa}{4}[(I_{j-1}I_j - I_jI_{j+1}) + (I_{j-2}I_{j+1} - I_{j-1}I_{j+2})].$$

Both brackets telescope, to $I_0I_1$ and to $I_{-1}I_2 = I_1I_2$, so $\sum_{j\ge1} jI_{j-1}I_{j+1} = \frac{\kappa}{4}(I_0I_1 + I_1I_2)$. Altogether

$$\sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}\Big(I_0^2 + \frac{\kappa}{2}I_1(I_0 - I_2)\Big) = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}(I_0^2 + I_1^2). \qquad \square$$

I.3. **The coefficients of $\mathcal{D}$.**

**Lemma I.2.** *Write $\mathcal{D}(\kappa) = \sum_{n\ge0}\mathcal{D}_n\kappa^{2n}$ for the function of (G.9). Then $\mathcal{D}_0 = \mathcal{D}_1 = 0$, and for $m \ge 1$*

$$\mathcal{D}_{m+1} = \frac{N_m}{4^m\,m!\,(m+1)!\,(m+1)(m+2)},$$

*with $N_m = \binom{2m}{m}(4(2m+1) + (m-1)(m+1)(m+2)) - 4^m(m+1)(m+2)$. Moreover $N_m = 0$ for $m \le 2$ and $N_m > 0$ for $m \ge 3$.*

*Proof. The coefficients.* Multiplying the series of $I_0$ and $I_1$ and collecting powers,

$$I_0^2 = \sum_{m\ge0}\alpha_m\kappa^{2m}, \qquad I_1^2 = \sum_{m\ge0}\beta_m\kappa^{2m+2},$$
$$\kappa I_1(2\kappa) = \sum_{m\ge0}\frac{\kappa^{2m+2}}{m!\,(m+1)!},$$

where

$$\alpha_m = \frac{1}{4^m}\sum_{i=0}^{m}\frac{1}{i!^2(m-i)!^2},$$
$$\beta_m = \frac{1}{4^{m+1}}\sum_{i=0}^{m}\frac{1}{i!\,(i+1)!\,(m-i)!\,(m-i+1)!}.$$

By Vandermonde's identity, $\sum_i \binom{m}{i}^2 = \binom{2m}{m}$ and $\sum_i \binom{m}{i}\binom{m+2}{i+1} = \binom{2m+2}{m+1}$, so

$$\alpha_m = \frac{\binom{2m}{m}}{4^m\, m!^2}, \qquad \beta_m = \frac{\binom{2m+2}{m+1}}{4^{m+1} m!\,(m+2)!}.$$

The coefficient of $\kappa^{2m+2}$ in $\mathcal{D}$ is $\mathcal{D}_{m+1} = 8\beta_m + 2\beta_{m-1} - \alpha_m - 1/(m!(m+1)!)$, with $\beta_{-1} = 0$; for $m = 0$ it is $\frac{8}{4} - 1 - 1 = 0$, and $\mathcal{D}_0 = 0$ because every term of $\mathcal{D}$ is $O(\kappa^2)$. For $m \ge 1$ put $\Delta = 4^m\, m!\,(m+1)!\,(m+1)(m+2)$ and $b = \binom{2m}{m}$. With $\binom{2m+2}{m+1} = \frac{2(2m+1)}{m+1} b$,

$$8\beta_m = \frac{4(2m+1)\,b}{\Delta}, \qquad \alpha_m = \frac{(m+1)^2(m+2)\,b}{\Delta},$$
$$2\beta_{m-1} = \frac{2m(m+1)(m+2)\,b}{\Delta},$$
$$\frac{1}{m!(m+1)!} = \frac{4^m(m+1)(m+2)}{\Delta},$$

and $2m - (m+1) = m - 1$ gives $\mathcal{D}_{m+1} = N_m/\Delta$.

*The sign.* Directly, $N_0 = N_1 = N_2 = 0$ $(2-2,\ 24-24,\ 192-192)$, $N_3 = 80$, $N_4 = 1140$ and $N_5 = 10416$. For $m \ge 6$ we first show $16^m \le 4m\binom{2m}{m}^2$ for $m \ge 1$ by induction: it is an equality at $m = 1$, and $(m+1)\binom{2m+2}{m+1} = 2(2m+1)\binom{2m}{m}$ gives

$$4(m+1)\binom{2m+2}{m+1}^2 = \frac{16(2m+1)^2}{m+1}\binom{2m}{m}^2$$
$$\ge \frac{16(2m+1)^2}{4m(m+1)}16^m \ge 16^{m+1}.$$

Since $(m-1)^2 \ge 4m$ for $m \ge 6$, it follows that $\binom{2m}{m}^2(m-1)^2 \ge 16^m$, that is $\binom{2m}{m}(m-1) \ge 4^m$, and

$$N_m = \Big(\binom{2m}{m}(m-1) - 4^m\Big)(m+1)(m+2)$$
$$+ 4(2m+1)\binom{2m}{m} > 0.$$

□

I.4. **Monotonicity of Bessel ratios.**

**Lemma I.3.** *For $n \ge 1$ and $\kappa > 0$, $I_{n+2}(\kappa)/I_{n+1}(\kappa) \le I_2(\kappa)/I_1(\kappa)$.*

*Proof.* We use a lemma of Biernacki and Krzyż [18]: if $f = \sum a_j x^j$ and $g = \sum b_j x^j$ have positive coefficients and $a_j/b_j$ is nonincreasing in $j$, then $f/g$ is nonincreasing on $x > 0$. Indeed

$$f'g - fg' = \sum_{i,j}(i-j)a_i b_j x^{i+j-1}$$
$$= \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i,j}(i-j)b_i b_j\Big(\frac{a_i}{b_i} - \frac{a_j}{b_j}\Big)x^{i+j-1} \le 0.$$

Take $x = \kappa^2$, $f = I_{n+1}(\kappa)/\kappa^{n+1}$ and $g = I_1(\kappa)/\kappa$. Then $a_j/b_j = 2^{-n}(j+1)!/(j+n+1)!$ decreases in $j$, so $I_{n+1}/(\kappa^n I_1)$ is nonincreasing in $\kappa$. Its logarithmic derivative is, by the second recurrence of (I.1),

$$\frac{n+1}{\kappa} + \frac{I_{n+2}}{I_{n+1}} - \frac{n}{\kappa} - \frac{1}{\kappa} - \frac{I_2}{I_1} = \frac{I_{n+2}}{I_{n+1}} - \frac{I_2}{I_1} \le 0.$$

□

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